on the other side

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/27648311.

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Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe - Roommates/Housemates, Smut, Fluff, Getting Together, Mutual Pining, Literally just so much yearning, idiots to lovers, Mating Cycles/In Heat, Slow Burn, Explicit Consent, Modern AU but still Canon Species

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Part 1 of and they were roommates

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Summary

Living with Catra can be hard, given Adora's stupid crush she cant seem to sqash, but she tries to be the best roommate she can. She wont risk ruining everything between them because of her feelings.
Catra knows Adora is never going to reciprocate her feelings, and yet she stays in this holding pattern with her. They are everything together - except actually *being* together. She never wants to live apart from Adora, but whenever her heat hits it *really* sucks to be living with the woman she is in love with.
(Catradora roommates in Modern Etheria AU)

Notes

Oh look, my fifth modern AU. ıst let me have this ok. This AU is set a little over a year after graduating college, so Catra and Adora are 23ish. Catra and Adora both have their bachelors degrees. Adora is working part-time while she goes through her 3-year Physical Therapy doctorate program. Catra is working full-time as a paralegal at the non-profit Perfuma works at and got her the initial interview for.

The Fight

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra feels like she might be going *insane*. The problem is Adora's gym has closed. Actually, scratch that – the problem is just *Adora*. Adora went for her morning workout and found a note on the door to the gym saying that rent was unpaid and until it was resolved, they and the gym owner were all locked out. So of course she returned, huffing and annoyed, and set to doing a home workout in the living room before she had to go to work.

Catra is sitting in their apartment's kitchen, roughly seven feet from where Adora is doing jumping jacks, dropping into a pushup, and then springing back to her feet. At least they live on the first floor, but they still might get a noise complaint anyway. Catra doesnt care. She is alternating between staring at Adora's thighs, her flexing back, and her tits bouncing from the movement despite her straining sports bra.

Catra is going to *die*. She isnt an idiot, she knows she is never going to be able to stomp down on her feelings for Adora, but she thought she was starting to handle her lust a bit better. Turns out she just was seeing less of Adora half-naked since they moved into their new apartment with their own bedrooms. Now she has Adora sweating in front of her in just a pair of jogging shorts and a sports bra, she realizes she is just as fucked as she has always been.

This is *bad*. She needs to get laid, she decides as she tries to resume eating her breakfast despite the way she cant look away from her roommate. She just needs to take the edge off and relax. Catra isnt cruel enough to date someone else when she is hung up this way, but she has had a few hook ups over the years, mostly during college when she and Adora were sharing a tiny room and

Catra was uselessly hoping Adora would make a move now they were out of their draconian foster home.

It was a pointless hope, because unlike Catra, Adora wasn't being held back from her true feelings by fear of the home's warden. Catra felt okay hooking up with classmates because she at least knew a bit about them, but since graduating last year that hasn't been an option. She doesn't really want to hook up with a stranger , but clearly her hand is only doing so much to ease the tension right now, and she would rather take the edge off than do something obvious and drive Adora away.

"You want to go out tonight? I want to dance, and I know this isn't enough of a workout for you," Catra asks Adora, her voice even. Adora pauses mid-jumping jack, turning to look at her as she mulls it over.

"Clubbing?" she asks. Catra nods. She can pick a girl up on some dance floor. A club is a better choice for a hook up – more likely for the girls there to be sober than at some bar. Adora is more comfortable with clubs too, and despite this whole thing being prompted by her, Catra doesn't want to go alone. After a moment, Adora shrugs.

"Sure, why not? I want us to have dinner before we go out, though," Adora agrees. Catra just nods. Adora is a bit weird about alcohol. Catra gets it – Shadow used to rely a little too heavily on wine, and once you add in why Adora was in foster care in the first place, vices made her suffer from their group foster home's warden twice over. It makes sense for her to be skittish about it, even if the alcohol had nothing to do with Shadow being an absolute bitch. That was all natural.

If Adora wants to make sure they have food in them before they potentially consume alcohol, Catra isn't bothered. Hungry Adora is kind of a bear to deal with anyway. Catra tries to return to her breakfast despite the distraction before her, telling herself that a hook up will help her be normal around Adora again.

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Adora shouldn't have agreed to this. It was a terrible idea. Sure, she loves dancing with Catra. She is bad at it, but it is a fun way to get a cardio workout in. The problem is the *idea* part. Catra dances practically pressed against her partner, mouthing along with the lyrics, her smiling face only inches away, and most of those inches are only due to their height difference because Catra is *petite*.

She realizes how fucked she is when she finds her hands are tracing along the stripes on Catra's ribs without her ever telling them to. The touch is a little too *reverent* to be casual. Adora has pet Catra's stripes before, but the high cut of her crop top and their proximity is bringing this into dangerous territory. Catra doesn't know about her massive, idiotic crush – she would have confronted her about it long ago – but Adora would like to keep things that way.

She slides her hands down to Catra's hips. The position is only moderately more appropriate, but Adora can at least justify it. She may generally be a bad dancer, but Catra has managed to teach her some moves. It was in a fit of exasperation at her lack of skill, but Adora still grins down at Catra as she does the body roll that Catra taught her. It is *almost* in time with the music. She know it wasn't perfect, but when she looks to Catra for approval she expects to at least get a fond eyeroll. Instead, Catra sends her a tight-lipped smile before she twists away, slipping off into the crowd to find another dance partner. Adora is left standing alone on the dance floor, staring at Catra's retreating back.

Adora tries to convince herself it is fine as she makes her way off the floor. Catra just wants to dance with other people tonight, she reasons. She knows she isn't a great dance partner, and Catra usually ends up dancing with a few other girls when they go out. Adora often waits by the bar for her, idly chatting with the other

patrons, but she just isn't up for conversation right now. She moves to lean against the wall, trying to keep an eye out for Catra, but she has trouble picking her out amongst the other bodies on the floor.

The longer Adora waits, the more worried she gets. She clearly made Catra uncomfortable. She has touched Catra like that plenty of times before and she knows Catra doesn't usually mind the contact, but there was a bit more intent in the touch tonight than Adora usually allows herself. She hadn't realized what she was doing until it was too late and Catra clearly didn't like it. She will have to apologize when she finds her again.

Speaking of finding Catra again, she hasn't caught a glimpse of her for awhile now. She frowns to herself, pushing off the wall and heading back to the floor, but even once in the center of it, she can't find Catra.

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Catra just wanted to loosen up. The whole reason they are here is that she has been wound too tight, so of course Adora had to touch her like that, grinning and looking to her for innocent approval. Catra's thoughts were anything but *innocent*. Adora was touching her absently, just dancing with her friend, but it was driving Catra *insane*. The hip roll was her death sentence. If she wanted to stop herself from kissing Adora in the middle of the floor, she had to get out of there.

It worked her up enough to lead her *here*, on the counter of the club bathroom, a blonde she found out on the floor pressed against her. Catra has never done something like this before, but Adora has been working her up and she just needs to unwind a little. She doesn't even know the girl's name, just that she has broad enough shoulders to be passable. Catra has no plans to have sex in a public bathroom,

but a make out and some heavy petting is just what she needs right now.

She is on the bathroom counter, her thighs spread as the blonde stands between them, kissing her with a bit too much tongue, but Catra doesnt *care*. She cant stop feeling Adora' s hands on her. She needs to replace them with something else. When the blonde keeps her eyes closed, Catra cant see her brown eyes and she can pretend as the hands roam over her.

The blonde has just gotten involved enough with her tongue to realize Catra has fangs, pulling back a little but still not breaking the kiss, when the bathroom door opens. The other woman doesnt stop, so Catra doesnt either . *Wares* . They are both clothed, and as long as it isnt a bouncer coming in, theyre fine. Catra has certainly walked in on more compromising positions than this in a club bathroom before. A pair of lesbians making out isnt anything to write home about.

Except it *is* a bouncer, because the next thing she knows theyre being pulled apart and someone is hauling the blonde off of her. Catra stares, panting, flushed, and *stunned* as Adora steps between her and the blonde, glaring down at where she has *thrown* the woman onto the floor. Catra hasnt seen Adora this mad in years. Her fists are clenched, the muscles in her arms standing out, and her breath is coming out of her nose in short bursts. She positions herself between where Catra is perched on the counter and the blonde on the floor.

Catra feels herself swallow, closing her legs as she looks between Adora and the other girl. The blonde looks a bit shell-shocked, but she props herself up on her elbows, sending Catra a glare. That definitely doesnt help Adora calm down. Catra was already turned on, but seeing Adora like this has her thighs clenching as she buries a whimper in her throat. She doesnt know what is going on, she doesnt even know why Adora is upset, and she feels stunned by this turn of events.

"Should have told me you have a girlfriend," the blonde accuses from the floor, her gaze darting between Adora and Catra. *Oh*, that's why she is glaring. It's a fair assumption to make given Adora's fury, but it's the farthest thing from true. The blonde looks *worried*. She is tall, but Catra can tell from a once over that she has nothing on Adora's strength, and she doesn't even match her height either. She is probably trying to deflect blame onto Catra to avoid a fight she can't win breaking out.

"This is what you like to do on Saturday nights? Take advantage of drunk girls?" Adora asks, gesturing a bit violently at the girl on the floor. Catra could roll her eyes as it all clicks into place for her and she finally understands Adora's anger. Adora is still standing between them, physically shielding Catra from the other woman with her body.

She hasn't had a single drink, but she also hasn't seen Adora in awhile as she worked her way through the floor, and it is fair enough to assume she is impaired considering she doesn't usually hook up with strangers and she has *never* done something like this in a bathroom before. She understands why Adora jumped to conclusions after she ran off given the way clubs make her nervous anyway.

"Adora, I'm not drunk-" she starts to protest, hoping to placate her, but Adora turns to her and cuts her off.

"We're going home," she says firmly, reaching out and *lifting* Catra *off* the counter by her hip, *her* hand. Catra doesn't manage to fight down her blush, but Adora is a bit too worked up to notice. Her blue eyes are practically sparking in the low light of the bathroom. Catra throws the blonde one last glance before she lets Adora lead her out of the bathroom with an arm around her waist. Adora's grip on her is *firm* as she leads Catra towards the front of the club.

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Okay, her behaviour in the bathroom was a bit *bizarre*, especially after almost feeling Catra up on the dance floor, but as Catra starts to catch up with events she seems to settle on being too pissed off to notice.

"I haven't touched a drink. I was *enjoying* myself, Adora," Catra grumbles as they walk down the street. Her arms are crossed and Adora is pretty sure she is only allowing the arm around her waist as they walk home due to the chill of the night. Adora flinches, hunching her shoulders in a little.

"I'm sorry, I thought-"

"*I know* what you thought, but you ruined my hook up. It's been *months*, Adora," Catra points out. Adora bites her lip to keep silent. She is *aware* of that. She had walked in the door after a long day of work and heard-

She cuts that trail of thought off, just like she had then as she walked deeper into the apartment and shut herself in her bedroom. She didn't *mean* to slam the door, but it had cut off the noises next door. She knows she should have just left and come back later, but she was exhausted. She collapsed in her bed, and when she awoke again at dinnertime, Catra was alone in the apartment and made no mention of what Adora had overheard.

Adora's jealousy had been ugly then, and the few times Catra hooked up back in college, but she had never *reacted* like she did tonight. Some of it had just been the panic. She was looking all over for Catra, and then she found her being plastered to a counter by some girl. She knows Catra, and when Catra hooks up, she tops. She immediately thought Catra had to be inebriated to be letting herself be pinned like that. It was a stupid thought, especially considering how much it takes to get Catra drunk, but it was the push she needed to justify her jealousy and step in.

"She wasn't your type?" Adora tries to placate. She *wasn't*. Too femme, no muscles, shorter than Catra usually goes for. It was another reason Adora immediately jumped to Catra being taken advantage of. Catra told her once that she likes a girl with enough strength to at the *very least* pick her up. She said something else after that, definitely, but Adora's mind had gone blank at that point. In the present, Catra glares at her, her tail lashing.

"I don't *care*. You interrupted last time, too. For fuck's sake, let me get *laid*," Catra complains, looking away with a huff. Adora swallows, trying to choke down her anxiety. Ice is running through her veins, and she involuntarily tightens her arm around Catra's waist, afraid of her leaving.

It is a mistake. Catra growls lowly and pulls away, stomping a few feet in front of her to head into the front door of their apartment building. Adora trails after her, feeling *sick*. She doesn't know what to do to make this better. Catra is pissed off. They are finally to their apartment door, at least. She searches for what she can say as Catra unlocks their front door.

"I'm sorry. I was trying to protect you," she tries. No, she wasn't actually. She was trying to keep Catra to herself. She jumped to the first convenient excuse to step in and convinced herself it was true before she bothered with things like reason. Catra hisses at her words, taking a few steps into the apartment and then turning around to glare at her. Her face is flushed with her irritation.

"I don't need you to *protect* me, I need you to leave me alone so I can *get fucked*," Catra returns, and then turns on her heel and storms into her bedroom, slamming the door behind her and leaving Adora standing in the apartment, alone with a sinking feeling.

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Catra isn't actually mad at Adora – she is *jealous* though. Fucking noble Adora. Always so goddamn perfect, so *kind* even while she was ruining Catra's hook up. Even after storming out on her, Catra has to quietly get herself off thinking about the sparking of Adora's eyes and the flex of her muscles when she fucking *threw* the blonde aside.

Fuck does Catra want those hands on her thighs, lifting her up just as easily. Catra is pissed off, and yet she is still laying in her bed thinking about Adora as she touches herself, tracing the stripes on her sides and remembering how Adora's hands had stroked them earlier in the night. She has one hand in her jeans because she couldn't even wait long enough to get them *off*.

When Catra walks out of her room on Sunday morning, it is to find Adora doing another home workout in the living room in nothing even *approaching* clothes. She growls to herself at her instant reaction, tail lashing behind her as she stalks into the kitchen to grab one of her dried fruit bars. Adora stops her workout instantly, but Catra *cannot* talk to her when she isn't even wearing real clothes. She is annoyed, and wound up, and her first thought when she sees her is that she wants to pin her to the floor.

It isn't the first time she has ignored Adora, but Adora doesn't usually look so broken up about it, staring at her dejectedly as she snatches food from the fridge and retreats to her room. She tries to pretend how broken up Adora looks doesn't make her chest clench. Catra is just grateful it's Sunday. She always goes to Scorpia and Perfuma's place for yoga on Sundays. It not only gives her a reason to leave the house, but an opportunity to vent. She gets dressed while cursing Adora out in her head. Said curses mostly involve phrases like *fucking abs* and *perfect fucking face*, but they still count.

Perfuma is going to have a fucking field day with this one. After a thirty-minute bus ride, Catra explains what happened last night – and this morning - in a grumble as they lay out the mats and get started, Catra and Scorpia mirroring Perfuma's instructional positioning. She may work in PR professionally, but she has been doing yoga almost

since she could walk, and the girl knows her moves even if she is not an official instructor.

"Wildcat, really?" Scorpia questions after Catra explains, looking a bit incredulous. Catra doesn't know why. Scorpia has more than been on the receiving end of Catra's attempts to deal with her feelings for Adora. They have talked it out now – that conversation is the whole reason Scorpia and Perfuma even know about her feelings and Catra can go to them about stuff like this – but Scorpia shouldn't be surprised by it at this point. Catra, through sheer force of will, manages to sulk while still maintaining her triangle pose.

"Half-naked. T its *bouncing*. Perfuma would have climbed you like a tree if she woke up to that. Leave me alone, Scorpia," Catra defends in a grumble. Perfuma flushes but makes no protests. Scorpia opens her mouth, no doubt to point out she doesn't *have* tits, but Catra doesn't have time for semantics right now. "Look, I'm not mad at her. I know she didn't do anything wrong. She was just trying to take care of me, blah blah. If I had been drunk I would be grateful, but it was *not* the way I needed her to give me a hand," Catra tells them as Perfuma drops her pose and they both follow suit.

Scorpia's yoga attempts have always been half-hearted. She is mostly here for moral support and to admire her girlfriend. She isn't the most flexible, but she does try, even if she rarely succeeds. She sends Catra a pitying look and Catra, maturely, sticks her tongue out at her.

"Your heat is coming up," Perfuma supplies, helpfully. Catra growls under her breath. Right, that explains some things about her general moodiness. She should really question why Perfuma has that marked on her calendar, because even Catra doesn't really track them, but she also doesn't really care.

"I've got to get laid," Catra decides as she follows Perfuma's new position. Perfuma turns her head, breaking the pose to level Catra with a flat look. "You want me to go through a week of that in close quarters with Adora after *several* dry months? I'll find someone

before it hits, just blow off steam so it isnt as bad once it comes," Catra argues.

"That isnt exactly the emotionally healthy thing to do. Y ou made a commitment to improving, Catra," Perfuma reminds her . Catra feels her tail lash. She *did*, but that was two years ago and she has come fucking leaps and bounds since then. She can only do so much, especially when Adora has gotten no less oblivious to the affect that she has on Catra.

"It is the thing I am *going* to do. Thanks for the pep talk, flowers, but Im not risking losing control during my heat. That would be even less healthy," Catra tells her . Perfuma changes stances, and Catra is pretty sure it is exclusively so she can turn to look her in the eye.

"Y ou have always maintained good control of yourself during your heats, Catra," she reminds, voice gentle. Catra winces. She forgets that Perfuma knows too much as Scorpia's girlfriend. She is well aware of the fears that Catra had leading up to her first heat. Catra sighs.

"I'm not worried about *that* . I know better than that now. It's more about being too needy and accidentally saying something. If she even felt the same, do you think the middle of my heat is the time for an I love you?" She would never believe it," Catra points out. At least that finally shuts Perfuma up. She doesnt seem happy about it, but she sighs and lets it go. Catra doesnt doubt it is only a temporary reprieve, but she will take it.

Catra at least has a plan now. Perfuma is right that she should have noticed the signs – the increased desire and irrational mood – and the fact that they are so prevalent means it is coming soon. Catra would never be comfortable hooking up during her heat and would never want to anyway, but she can take the edge off beforehand and then make it through how she normally does.

Besides, a plan is already forming in her mind, and it is petty, but she is going to do it anyway.

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There was a period in freshmen year college when Catra had a friends with benefits things with one of her friends – probably her best friend, outside of Adora. They fought about it, because Adora was insistent that it wasn't just sex to Scorpia. Catra didn't want to hear it. She deflected by saying that just because Adora wasn't interested in hook ups, that didn't mean everybody was like her. Casual sex isn't Adora's thing, but that had not been her issue with Scorpia.

Her issue with Scorpia was she checked every box for Catra's type, was having sex with her, and was also *in love with her*, even if Catra refused to see it. Catra stopped talking to her for two days following that conversation, up until Scorpia confessed her crush to Catra when she told Scorpia what she and Adora were actually fighting about.

Catra came home upset, sure she broke her friend's heart despite not feeling the same. Adora just tried to support her and pretend she wasn't glad it was over. After that, she and Catra were fine. Now they can even joke about it – hell, they can even joke about it *with Scorpia*, since she and Catra are still good friends.

This fight feels very similar. On Sunday, Catra ignores her, dodging her attempt to talk and then leaving the apartment entirely. Catra doesn't come back until after dark, and before Adora can even stand from her desk, Catra is in her room and shutting the door with an air of finality. Adora sags in the middle of her room, staring at the thin wall dividing them and wondering what the hell she is going to do.

She knows Catra is probably insulted that Adora thought she couldn't handle herself, on top of being annoyed at her for ruining her night. She hopes that Catra just needs a little time. It always

used to hurt Adora when Catra ignored her like this, but after an explosion of a fight, she knows Catra does it to give herself room to cool off and not do something she regrets. The best thing Adora can do is give her the space she needs so she doesnt push her into anything.

Adora can wait. Not *long* , she isnt a patient person, but she can make it a day at least. Hopefully Catra is willing to at least be in the same room as her tomorrow. Adora sets her morning alarm with a pang of sadness in her chest. She knows it has only been a day, but fuck, she misses Catra already. She eagerly stumbles out of her room on Monday morning and sees Catra's keys are already gone. Catra always has to leave before her during the week, but she doesnt usually leave this early . Adora swallows down her disappointment. Tonight, then.

She is fidgety all through her classes – although truthfully that doesnt take much - and when she finally returns home, she opens the front door cautiously. She draws to an utter halt as she registers moans coming from Catra's bedroom. It isnt Catra' s voice, and Adora knows she is silent when she is on her own anyway. Whoever the voice belongs to, she is practically singing Catra's praises. Adora feels her eye twitch and fights to stay rooted to her spot for a few moments so she doesnt do anything drastic .

She forces herself to put her things away as quietly as possible before retreating to her room. She closes the door softly, *quietly* , the exact opposite of the last time she walked in on this. She wished after that incident that she had just left, and maybe it is the masochist in her, but she cant do it now .

Okay, so they arent talking *tonight* either, because she is way too upset to not be obvious about what is bothering her. She knows what she did, but she doesnt know what she did to *deserve* this . Then again, in Catra's mind she is just being an average level of *rude* *and* , making noise and forcing Adora to sit through it for fear of making things worse between them. She is none the wiser to what she is actually putting Adora through.

Catra is eating out the other girl, and fuck does Adora wish that she didn't know that, but it is hard to mistake the moans of *your* tongue, *baby*. Adora is *aware* of Catra's tongue, she has licked her with it a number of times, but it was always innocent. Just being an asshole, or marking Adora as hers, and she swears *grinning* her once or twice during puberty.

Adora clenches her hands in fists at her side and pulls out her homework for her doctorate course. She isn't going to do it, not now she can make out Catra's rough tones next door, even if the contents of the dirty talk are unintelligible through the wall. She can definitely glare down at her homework and loathe herself though, pretending her thighs aren't clenching at hearing Catra' s voice *sound* like that.

Eventually, the other girl comes with a muffled cry, and Adora hears Catra see her out. Catra lingers in the living room afterwards, and Adora can already picture the smug look Catra would throw her if she were to join her, probably accompanied by a comment about *handling herself*. Her point has been made.

Adora still can't walk out and face her . She might actually cry.

--

Catra is being a shitty roommate, entirely on purpose, but she does need to blow off steam. It isn't *her* fault that Adora is avoiding her now. She stays shut in her room even as Catra pointedly turns the TV on and sulks on the couch. She is *inviting* Adora to come out, but Adora is ignoring her, and Catra has always hated tasting her own medicine. She glares at the shitty tube TV they bought for five dollars at a thrift store as Adora's favourite cooking competition comes on, taunting her.

The plan was to download one of those trashy hook up apps and get it out of her system. Then she could be normal around Adora again. Catra could have easily timed it so Adora was away at school for the whole thing, but she is petty and childish and she *didnt* . If Adora pulled this shit, Catra would have clawed her door down and thrown the other girl out, but Adora doesnt have the *ins* that she has. To her it is just unwarranted noisy sex.

The plan has gone awry. Adora usually at least opens her door while she does her homework, if she doesnt outright gather up her work and bring it out into the living room. Catra knows she has the volume loud enough for Adora to make out the fact she is watching one of *her* shows, even though she usually watches the TV on mute when she is by herself, but Adora still doesnt come out.

Her libido is just one of the things affected by her heat. Her mood gets volatile, and right now she feels *justified* that Adora is ignoring her. She shuts off the TV with a growl and retreats to her own room. Fine. She was an asshole, she *gets* it . Adora rarely needs time to cool down after a fight like this, but Catra is willing to give her a day. Avoiding Adora *right* after she had sex is probably a good idea anyway. She can wait until tomorrow, even if she seriously misses her by now.

Work is a nightmare on Tuesday. Catra can feel herself getting sluggish and irritable, her heat probably only a few days away, and the fact that she hasnt seen Adora since Sunday morning doesnt help. They usually miss each other on Tuesday mornings, but a part of Catra – a stupid part, clearly – was hoping Adora would get up early so they could at least see each other, even if they wouldnt have time to talk.

She makes it through the day without biting a co-worker, though she does growl a bit more than is polite in a business setting. She heads straight home and changes from her suit, flinging herself onto the couch to wait for Adora. If Adora wants to give Catra the same silence she gave her, *bad* . Catra will fucking tackle her as she

heads to her bedroom if she has to. Catra had to avoid her to keep from slipping up, and now she fucking *misses* her.

She feels anxiety spike in her throat when eight thirty rolls around and Adora isn't back yet. She might have missed the first bus, but she usually texts Catra when that is the case. They may be fighting, but they have fought before and they still checked in with each other, even if the other didn't *reply* to it. Catra waits thirty fucking minutes, well past when the second bus should have come, before she texts Bow to ask when Adora left work.

She's still here is the reply she gets. Extended her shift apparently. Catra stares at her phone screen and tries to settle between being hurt or *mad*. Adora is perfectly fine, she just purposefully didn't text so Catra would fucking *worry*.

Okay, she is definitely settling on anger. She texts Bow back to ask for Adora's new end time, and then immediately opens the hook up app again. If Adora wants to make her worry, she can generate some fucking *consequences*. She wasn't planning on doing this again, hell, she almost deleted the app after last night, but she is pissed off and she wants to get back at her. The fact that it will help her calm down is just a bonus.

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On Tuesday, Adora misses Catra again in the morning. She knows that isn't unusual, but she still feels as empty as the apartment when she walks out to a vacant kitchen in the morning. She hates this. She misses her best friend. She misses hugging her, and talking to her – hell, she misses *looking* at her. She has hardly seen a glimpse of Catra since Saturday.

She stays late at work. She almost never does it unless they are desperate for extra money, which they haven't been ever since Catra got her raise, but her boss asks her to help out with a night game and she takes it. She is afraid that if she goes home it will be to the cold shoulder again, or worse yet, moaning. Catra definitely timed that to show Adora she could handle herself. Being late will let her to miss it if Catra isn't satisfied she made her point.

She doesn't text Catra to warn her. Despite feeling guilty about it, if the whole purpose is to avoid a timed event, telling Catra when she will actually be home won't help. Besides, Catra will probably be too *busy* to check her phone.

It is a fucking mistake. Being late doesn't make her miss it—it means Catra was willing to *extend it* by switching. When Adora walks in the front door, it is to the sound of Catra's own moans and an unfamiliar voice murmuring dirty talk to her. For a long moment, Adora is rooted to the spot, staring at Catra's door and feeling her face flush.

She swallows, her throat dry, as she carefully creeps to her bedroom. She sits on the edge of her bed to take off her shoes, and then she just *keeps sitting* there, listening to Catra panting the word *harder* on the other side of the wall, only three feet away at most. Their beds are shoved against the same wall so they can listen for the other having a nightmare.

Adora actually feels lightheaded from how flushed she is. She stares at the opposite wall, hands flexing in her lap as she tries to control every urge in her body. Part of her wants to burst into the room and throw the other girl out. The rest of her wants to slip her eyes closed and *pretend*.

It would be an utter violation, but Adora knows she can't storm in there without giving herself away and ruining any chance of peace between them. She only has so much self-control after so long without Catra and a hard day at work. She finally moves again, undressing from her work uniform and laying out on her bed, lying to herself that she is going to take a nap.

Her hand twitches at her side and she throws an arm over her eyes. Catra isn't making a *lot* of noise, but every moan she releases causes Adora's thighs to clench. She is fucking soaked, and she doesn't know what she thought she was blocking out by closing her eyes, because now all she can do is picture Catra beneath her, moaning as *Adora* fucks her.

She doesn't move her hand – she already feels bad enough about just *listening* the way she is, knowing she can get off without touching herself if the circumstances are right. She trembles a little in her sheets as she listens to Catra pant and moan softly. It is the most beautiful sound she has ever heard, making her chest clench just as much as her core does. It is not the first time she is *ever* hearing these sounds – Catra sometimes can't help making noise when her heat hits – but it is the first time she has ever heard them like this, knowing someone other than Catra is eliciting them. Someone other than *her*.

She feels sick with herself, even as her hips arch up into the air. She always feels guilty thinking about Catra when she gets off, but this is on another level, probably because it is fucking garbage what she is doing. Despite knowing how bad it is, she is still dripping, slick working down her thighs as the fire builds between her legs with every noise Catra makes. Both her hands are twitching now, wanting to finally touch herself and just release this tension, but she can't cross that line.

Catra is getting close, probably, because she is getting louder. Adora hates the way that builds the heat in her entire body, her skin flushing from her raw desire. With her eyes closed, she can picture Catra straddled above her, riding her fingers as she moans and *cries out* -

Adora comes at the same time Catra does.

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The girl she hits up turns out to be a top. Catra doesnt usually let strangers above her, but she is frustrated and she honestly would like someone to take care of her right now. Adora walks in on her moans rattling off the walls. Her partner isnt that experienced, but it still helps her relax, eventually sinking back into the sheets once Adora has returned and she knows she has backup.

As she walks her hookup out, she feels irritation rise in her at spotting Adora's keys on the counter. She was fucking worried and Adora was just ignoring her. After she closes the front door, she turns to glare at Adora's shut door. Okay, Catra is being petty, but *so is Adora*. She stalks up to her door, knocking on it before she can think better of it. She intends to chew Adora out for not texting, but she doesnt get to.

She hears Adora's sharp intake of breath, followed by the sound of her rolling over in bed. She doesnt get up. She was *turning away*. Catra stands there, stunned. Her heart is in her fucking throat, but Adora still doesnt stand. She already knew Adora was avoiding her , but it fucking stings to be ignored like this to her face. Catra swallows down her own self-loathing and stalks back to her room.

Fine. If Adora isnt backing down, then neither is she.

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Adora absolutely fucking panics when Catra knocks on her door. She feels like such shit about what she just did. She knows Catra will be able to tell what happened the second she walks into the room. It is way too soon for the scent of her desire to have faded. She curls into a ball on her side and prays Catra will just go away, despite this being the first time Catra has tried to talk to her since Saturday.

Catra does leave, and Adora does her best not to fucking cry. She cant believe she let herself do that, and then on top of that she had to turn Catra away to avoid getting caught. All she wants is for Catra to talk to her again. She can even keep bringing home girls –Adora always knew she wasnt going to stay single forever , after all –but she cant take this cold shoulder .

She still has to hide in her room for the rest of the day, like she had yesterday evening, if only to keep her feelings buried. She worries she still smells of it. She doesnt have Catra' s senses, and while she has a good handle on Catra's range of hearing, her sense of smell is a bit vaguer to Adora. She just has to hide and hope she will see Catra in the morning.

She doesnt. Adora decides it is time to take drastic measures. She emails her professor for her last class of the day that she isnt feeling well –it is true, the heartache is damn near making her sick at this point –and she comes home early , before Catra gets off from her nine-to-five. She puts all her things away and sets to making Catra's favourite tea, determining to talk even if it takes a fucking bribe.

She has just set two mugs on the kitchen table when she hears an unfamiliar giggle at the front door and her heart sinks through the floor. She thought Catra would at least come home and change out of her office clothes first, but no, the lock turns and Catra stumbles through the front door in her suit, her hands already on the other girl's hips.

Adora and Catra lock eyes for a brief moment and she watches the heated look there *die*, her eyes widening with shock as she stares at Adora over the other girl's shoulder. Said girl turns to actually look at the apartment she was letting herself be steered backwards into. She's a platinum blonde - ripped, tall, and broad - checking all the physical traits for *Catra's type* . Adora closes her eyes, breathing out through her nose as she drops her hands to her sides from where she was setting out the mugs.

"I'll leave you two alone," she manages, her voice *more* approaching even. If she didn't feel sick before, she certainly does now. She forces herself to open her eyes, walking to the counter to collect her keys and then breezing past where the girl is awkwardly shifting in the doorway, clearly uncomfortable with how uncomfortable *Adora* is.

She can feel Catra's eyes on her, no doubt glaring holes into the side of her head for having the nerve to interrupt, as she shoulders her way past and out the front door.

So that was the *joke* of talking.

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They make it to the bedroom, but they don't even get naked before Catra cuts it off. The mood is kind of dead and she feels *weird*. She is perfectly nice, strong and gentle like Catra likes – like Adora *is* – but she can't go through with this knowing she has driven Adora out of the apartment. She says she gets it, to call her some other time when she isn't dealing with roommate issues, and Catra walks her out with a clawing feeling in her throat.

There are two mugs of hojicha tea on the kitchen table. Adora doesn't even like hojicha, she only drinks it when Catra does. Catra sighs, dropping down into her usual seat and snagging the handle of her favourite mug – which she *knew* she left dirty in the sink this morning – and dragging it closer. She really has been fucking up steadily all week.

Adora didn't want to talk to her last night, but who can fucking *blame* her. All Adora does is try to protect her and do the right thing, and Catra makes her sit through noisy roommate sex in punishment. Yes, Adora has been avoiding her in turn, but Catra definitely started it.

And here she is, skipping class to make amends, but the moment she had seen Catra walking in with another girl-

Catra can't even begin to unpack that facial expression. She looked *hurt*. It was probably just that their chance to talk got ruined. She did *all this* after all, and then she tried to be good by doing the opposite of what she had done that first night and leaving, letting Catra have her fun, but Catra doesn't actually want it.

The kitchen chair is hard on her ass, so she moves to the couch to sulk. She considers texting Adora, but despite herself she is still annoyed at being left worrying without a text and then *ignored* last night. She looks to the clock, realizing Adora should only just now be getting out of class. Absences aren't taken lightly in her PT doctorate program.

Catra feels like shit, sick to her stomach and her fur prickling with discomfort. She turns on the TV, but she doesn't absorb what is happening on it, too busy watching the clock and wondering where Adora went – when she will be back. She already knew she was doing this to spite Adora, but she didn't realize she was so pathetically hung up she had no desire to even get off unless Adora was listening.

She groans, sinking further into the couch. She is so fucked. She was a fucking idiot to think she could do anything to manage her feelings for Adora. She's *Adora*. Hopeless and oblivious and totally uninterested, but Catra is always going to love her. Here she is after four days of Catra being the shittiest roommate ever, and she is still going out of her way to do nice things for her.

Catra doesn't know what she is going to do, not in a week or in a year or in another ten when she is still single and pining like she has been for fifteen years now, but she knows tomorrow morning she is going to talk to Adora over breakfast like nothing ever happened, and if Adora is smart, she will respond just the same.

They wont talk about it. When it comes to stuf f like this, they never do.

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Adora texts Glimmer that she is coming over, and if she and Bow arent home then she is breaking in. She doesnt get a reply before she reaches their apartment, but the lights are off so she uses her spare key to let herself in.

She really doesnt know what to *do*. She set everything up, she thought they were finally going to talk, but she should have predicted Catra's timing. She throws herself onto Glimmer's couch to sulk, sinking into the cushions and trying to ignore the memory of the stunned look on Catra's face as her gaze darted between Adora and the tea on the table.

How long does she have to wait - an hour? T wo? She was two hours late on Tuesday and still walked in on something. For all she knows, knowing she has the apartment to herself will just make Catra extend the whole thing. It is what she did yesterday after all. This is fucking torture. All she wants to do is talk to Catra again. Okay, yes, maybe she wants to hold her and kiss her and-

But the *point* is that she misses her best fucking friend, and she really thought she was going to be on the road to getting her back tonight, but instead she is sitting alone on Glimmer's couch, waiting for her or her boyfriend to get home.

Eventually Glimmer texts her back that they are out at the theatre, but theyll be home after the film gets out. It wont be until after eight, but Adora doesnt care. She putters around their apartment, doing the laundry for them as the best apology she can manage right now for ruining their date night. When Glimmer and Bow come home,

they can clearly tell she is upset, because they eye each other and declare it is time for a best friends squad hangout, despite how one member of said squad is missing.

Adora doesn't head back home until after eleven. At least she has guaranteed that Catra will be alone, even if she still won't talk to her .

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Catra intended to wait in the living room until Adora got home, but apparently Adora took so fucking long that she fell asleep, because Catra wakes up a little after midnight, alone on the couch, but the lights and TV have been turned off. She sits up, swallowing and finding her throat completely dry. She takes a second to check that Adora's keys are on the counter before she stumbles into the kitchen to get herself water.

Adora came back, even if Catra has no clue when. She came back to see Catra's pathetic ass on the couch and she didn't wake her , but that means she snuck around her, staying quiet and considerate even after everything. For some reason, the thought makes Catra flush, a wave of heat running through her body that leaves her shivering in the center of the kitchen. She has felt so sick all evening, her inner turmoil making her body tense and uncomfortable enough to make her nauseous. She drains her entire glass and then refills it, feeling her tail lash behind her as her fur *itches* a little with-

heat. Flooding through her body, and *for her* is now not a good time, but she knew this was coming and she still fucked around, not even warning Adora. She is standing in her work clothes, in the middle of the kitchen, shivering even as warmth soaks through her limbs. She can smell traces of Adora's scent in this space, and it doesn't matter what weird dance they have been doing, they have a

fucking arrangement for this. Despite still being a bit mad at Adora for last night, there is nowhere safer to her than in Adora's bed.

She at least has the presence of mind to bring her glass of water with her when she slips into Adora's room. She sets it quietly on the nightstand as she lets herself take a deep, calming breath. The entire room smells like Adora, traces of her everywhere, and it instantly soothes Catra to be in here. She usually spends most of her heats in Adora's bed. Adora has always let her curl up in here and sweat it out.

Speaking of sweating, she is fucking melting in her suit pants. Her head is pounding a little as her body starts changing gears, and she blames that and the late hour for why she strips out of her clothes, snagging one of Adora's shirts laying on the floor to yank over her head for *something* approaching decency.

She crawls into Adora's bed in nothing but her underwear and borrowed t-shirt, nuzzling up against the side of Adora's sleeping form. She has done this so many times Adora doesn't even stir beyond shifting her arm a little to drape over her. Despite herself, Catra finds herself purring and snuggling closer.

She can only hope that Adora isn't mad at her in the morning.

Chapter End Notes

> I'll be posting twice a week for this fic. I have more fics planned in this series immediately following this main fic, so make sure to subscribe to the series if you want to keep following!

Hug the Cat

Chapter Notes

> Hi welcome to Extremely Horny Yearning the fic. Listen: I know my brand, okay.
> Not *all* of Catra's hook ups are blonde - that is just a Prevalent Theme.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Adora got home, her heart kind of felt like it was in her throat at seeing Catra asleep on the couch, *still in her clothes*. There is no way in hell she put those back on after hooking up – after Adora left, so did the blonde. It definitely made hope bloom in her chest, but she is still shocked when she wakes up with Catra in her bed, purring like an engine as she kneads against Adora's side.

Adora blinks her eyes open, squinting down at Catra in surprise. It isn't unusual for her to wake up with Catra in her bed, either because Catra had a nightmare or Adora did and Catra heard it through the wall, but given the fact that Catra has hardly looked at her in a week, it completely blindsides her.

Catra is also *wearing her work clothes*. Her work clothes are scattered around the floor. Adora was hopeful they would finally talk today, but she didn't think Catra would be okay with *this*. She feels dazed, blinking down at Catra in shock. Catra's eyes are open, but she is pointedly not looking at her, her ears pinned back despite how she is still purring and kneading. She seems embarrassed, and Adora is terrified of saying the wrong thing and driving her away again.

"My heat started," Catra mutters, cheeks flushed and looking anywhere but at Adora. Suddenly it all falls into place for Adora, and she shoves aside all her doubts and worries, reaching out immediately to wrap her arms around Catra and pull her close to her

chest. Yes, Catra has been kind of a *dick* for the last few days, but she is still coming to Adora for comfort, and goddammit if Adora isn't willing to put everything aside to give it to her.

Catra left a gap between them, just a few inches, but an unusual amount of space for when she is on her heat. Adora knows it was probably cautionary, but it doesn't have to be there. Catra trills as Adora turns on her side and tucks her in under her chin, purring and nuzzling against Adora's throat. She lets out a sigh dripping with contentment and relief as her own arms come up to wrap around Adora in turn.

They worked this out in college, when Catra's heats first started. There is the increased libido, but Catra's main issue is that her senses go a bit crazy, especially her sense of smell. It wears down on her, but her body relaxes a bit when she feels safe. Apparently, the safest place in the world to Catra is Adora's arms. The thought always makes warmth bloom in her chest.

"When did it start?" she asks Catra softly, petting one hand down the length of Catra's back. Catra wriggles a bit in her arms, pressing closer but also shifting herself beneath Adora's hands. Adora gets the hint. She reaches down for the edge of Catra's – *her* – shirt, sliding her hand beneath it to pet down Catra's back with direct contact. Catra releases another soft sigh, nuzzling her nose against Adora's pulse point.

"Middle of the night. Woke up all warm," Catra relays, sound muffled by Adora's neck. Adora breathes a mental sigh of relief. The blonde didn't get near Catra after her heat had started, at least. Adora sets to crushing Catra in against her chest, holding her as close as she can. Catra's purr is going like an engine as she nuzzles under Adora's jaw and then *marks* her. Adora bites down on the wave of warmth that threatens to illicit in her.

"I was trying to wait up for you, but- you know how I get sluggish right before," Catra murmurs against her neck. She sounds *close*.

Adora bites her lip, trying to maintain the steady strokes down Catra's back to keep them both calm and grounded.

"I didn't want to interrupt anything. I was at Glimmer and Bow's new place," Adora tells her. She involuntarily tightens her arms around Catra's back. She doesn't want to drive Catra off again, although from Catra's whole demeanor she seems to be willing to let things go.

"Okay," she whispers against her neck. Part of Adora wonders if that is going to be it. If Catra is going to confront her about Tuesday night, or offer an explanation for why she felt the need to punish Adora so much, but she also knows the punishment was far worse to her than Catra thought it would be.

"Can we be done? Avoiding each other and everything?" Catra asks, her voice small. Adora clutches her arms close around Catra's back, earning the return of her purr to *engine* volume.

"*Please*. I miss you so fucking much," she returns. Catra releases a sigh of relief, pressing closer despite how they are already in contact from Adora's jaw to their *ankles*. Yeah, they should probably talk about it, but there isn't much *to* talk about without revealing Adora's useless crush, so she is perfectly happy to just let it go.

"Do you want me to call in sick today?" she asks Catra, partially because she needs to know, and partially as a diversion from the topic. Catra mostly pushed through her last heat, still going to work on every day after the first, but historically she has largely stayed home. Adora used to stay home with her sometimes to help take care of her.

Catra trills, quiet and soft, but it still makes Adora's heart clench. She squeezes her arms around Catra's back, because she is feeling so damn much having Catra cuddling in her arms after missing her for a week straight. Despite her obvious delight at the concept, Catra shakes her head.

"I'll stay home until next week, but you already skipped yesterday for me. Just come home right after," she asks. Adora bites her lip, but she nods. Catra noticed at least, and she appreciated it. If Adora had hesitated before deciding to leave, would Catra have thrown the blonde out and been willing to sit down and talk?

It doesn't really matter. They are talking now. Adora wants to stay home for her, but Catra is kind of right that she can't skip again, and even if she could, she always tries to follow what Catra says she needs during her heats.

"Okay. And I'm sorry - about Tuesday. Bow told me last night that you were worried. I wasn't- I was trying to give you space," Adora tells her. Catra draws in a breath, but she nods against Adora's neck and says nothing more. It was risky to bring up, because Catra could very well ask why Adora was hiding from her afterwards and Adora doesn't have an answer for that. Catra seems just as willing to let it go as Adora is, however.

"The whole thing. You were just trying to do the right thing, and I *knew* that, but you know how irrational I can get," Catra murmurs against her neck. It takes Adora a minute, but it clicks that this is the closest Catra can get to an apology right now. It is fine by her – she knows Catra means it, even if the words are hard for her. She squeezes her closer, tucking her face into Catra's short hair and breathing deep. She wants to assure Catra, but she has also wants to do it for herself. She missed her *so much*.

"Want me to make us breakfast, or do you need me to stay here?" Adora asks. Catra considers it for a moment, her low purr still rolling between their chests.

"I'll come with you," she decides.

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Catra spends most of the morning draped against Adora's side, nuzzling into her neck and not bothering to suppress her sigh of relief at the *comfort* she finds there. Adora fixes breakfast with one arm wrapped around her, making Catra breakfast sausage so she "has plenty of fuel." Some of Adora's quick breakfasts have too much grain to be compatible with Catra on a good day, and the thought Adora is showing her helps to settle her even further.

This is why she clings to Adora during her heats. Adora is so gentle with her, never demeaning or judging, always bending over backwards to help her out wherever she can. Adora has always just accepted this difference of Catra's that no one else in their lives has to deal with or even really understands. And Adora understands – she understands an almost unreasonable amount – and that is all Catra needs.

She had been worried about how Adora would react, but Adora *apologized*, and she accepted Catra's shitty attempt at one as well. Adora seems just as relieved as she is to be done fighting. They will probably have to talk about it more later, once her heat has passed and her hormones are level again, but for now they let it lie. They curl up on the couch together once breakfast is ready, Catra half in Adora's lap and half tucked into her side, their shared plate balanced between their laps, fighting just a little bit with their forks like they are still kids. Catra asks Adora to tell her about her week, and she closes her eyes and lets Adora's voice wash over her as they eat.

Adora calls into work for her, because she is *considerate* like that, knowing the shitty audio quality from her cheap phone is grating on Catra's sensitive hearing anyway, but especially when it goes into overdrive along with her sense of smell during her heat. Catra marks Adora at least five times before she lets her get out the front door, but Adora *allows* it, humming and threading her hands through Catra's hair as she nuzzles under her jaw.

Any hybrid who gets within thirty feet of Adora is going to think she is fucking a magicat, but that isnt a negative in Catra' s mind, not when Adora lets her mark her as hers even when she isnt on her heat. The marks might be why Adora has been single for so long actually, but once again, Catra doesnt see a downside to keeping Adora hers.

After she is done crowding Adora against the front door to mark her one last time, she waves goodbye to her like they normally do when they arent fighting. It feels good to be sending Adora of f again, even if she instantly feels the loss of her presence leaving. Catra gets herself another glass of water –staying hydrated on her heats can be an issue –and retreats to her own room to change.

Adora didnt mention her clothes, or lack thereof. Catra usually ends up wearing one of Adora's shirts during her heat. She just feels better being surrounded by her scent when she cant have Adora herself. She knows it is some evolutionary bullshit, senses staying on high alert to avoid unfit partners or predators tracking the hormones, but natural selection is ***s****ucks* at this point in society and just makes her want to stay inside for a week every nine months.

She ditches her underwear, because they were ruined the moment Adora pulled her against her chest this morning and said she missed her. The general horniness is ***al****so* a thing, but it is far less of a problem compared to the scent issues, especially if she can get some alone time every few hours. She finds a loose pair of boxers, but doesnt bother actually putting them on, retreating instead to Adora's bed with them on hand for later.

Like she said, she needs some alone time.

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When Adora walks into her physiology course, the canidae near the door actually fluffs up the fur on her spine ridge. Adora doesnt care how the canidae whips around to look at her. She breezes past, smile absolutely beaming as she settles in her usual seat. She knows exactly what she smells like, but she is proud of being who Catra goes to when she has her heat, and she isnt afraid who knows it. It isnt like she is looking to date anyway. People can assume what they want. Besides, she may smell of Catra's marks and general affection, but it isnt like she is walking into class smelling like sex or anything.

She is in a fantastic mood after getting to spend all morning with Catra, especially hugging and supporting her. This might be exactly what they both needed, actually, because clearly Catra was feeling the distance too, that much is obvious by how she kept sighing in relief every time she nuzzled in against Adora.

Adora texts Catra whenever there are breaks in her PT courses, just checking in and making sure she is drinking enough water. She doesnt want to hover, but between all her biology classes she has learned the numbers on dehydration during heat. Catra pretty much doesnt leave the bed during her heats, at least not while Adora is home, so she wants to make sure she is getting enough water without Adora there to fetch it for her.

Adora texts Catra when she gets out of class to assure her she is headed straight home. Catra doesnt reply, but she could very well be asleep. She tends to nap a lot on her heat. Her body goes in overdrive, and that leaves a lot of necessary catch up, especially near the end of the week. Adora is careful to be quiet as she opens the front door to their apartment. If Catra is asleep, she doesnt want to wake her, and otherwise she doesnt want to startle her sensitive hearing.

She toes off her shoes by the front door. Catra usually complains when she leaves them out, telling Adora to keep her human shit in her room, but she doesnt want to track unknown scents into the bedroom. She takes her jacket off too, throwing it over the back of

the couch before snagging a glass of water from the kitchen and heading to the bedroom.

She eases the door open, but pauses when she sees the sight before her. Catra is face down in her bed, nosing in against the pillow. She is mostly laying on her stomach, but her hips are propped up and angled away, towards the wall. She has one hand clutching the edge of the sheets which she *clearly* just hauled up to cover herself. The other hand is trailing beneath the sheets. Her tail thuds once against the mattress, causing the sheets to move, but aside from that she is still.

Adora doesnt need Catra' s extra senses to know what she was doing in her bed. She pauses in the doorway, staring at Catra's back as Catra's shoulders rise and fall rhythmically with her breathing as she *waits* for Adora's reaction. Adora knows she does this – she has outright given Catra permission for it during her heats, just because she can relax more in Adora's bed – but she has never walked in on her before.

"Do you want me to go?" she asks, softly. Catra immediately growls and shakes her head against the pillow. Adora still hesitates, but after a moment more of silence, she steps through the door, closing it behind her and dropping her backpack by the desk. She hovers awkwardly by the wall, not sure how to proceed now.

Catra sighs and uncurls her grip on the sheets to slip that hand beneath the covers as well. Even over the sheets, Adora can tell she is pulling her pants back up from the way she shifts. After a moment, both of Catra's hands come up and pointedly tuck beneath the pillow.

"Okay?" Catra asks, an edge of nerves to her voice. Adora gave her permission for this back during her first heat, when Catra was dead set on curling into a ball in Adora's bed and *dying* there. Adora never minded knowing what Catra did in her bed when she wasnt there, but they havent really talked about it since, so she gets why Catra is nervous. Her back is still to Adora.

“Want me to join you?” Adora asks. She *never* hopes this, but at the moment she kind of hopes Catra says no, because her brain is now doing the very *helpful* linking of the sounds she heard Catra making earlier in the week and the mental image of Catra touching herself in her bed.

“Change first. You smell like outside. I want *you*,” Catra mutters into her pillow, sounding a bit embarrassed. Okay, yeah, there is a definite spike of heat in her gut after hearing those words, even if Catra doesn’t mean them like that. Strangers’ scents just bother her. Adora forces herself to take a few steady breaths as she crosses to her overcrowded closet, finding a spaghetti strap top she bought exclusively for the feel of the silky fabric and a pair of jogging shorts. Catra likes to feel body heat against her during her heats, and this thin top will let her feel that.

Adora gathers her phone from her discarded jeans pocket so she will have something to do and then slips into the bed beside Catra. She dumps her phone on the end table for the moment, because it has been several hours and she knows Catra must be missing contact by now.

She is right. As soon as she climbs into the bed, Catra turns over and tucks herself beneath Adora’s chin. Catra is still wearing her shirt from yesterday, but she seems to have swapped out for some boxers from the feel of her hips pressing in against Adora, purr already starting to roll between them as she nudges in and sighs softly.

“Felt like you were gone so long,” she mumbles. She sounds embarrassed, and Adora isn’t sure if it is at the admittance of missing her, or because she is trying to justify what Adora just walked in on. Adora bends down to press a kiss into Catra’s hair, near the base of her ear. She doesn’t usually risk such gestures, but Catra happily absorbs pretty much all forms of affection while she is on her heat. Catra’s purr is *loud*, satisfied and happy.

"I'm right here. I've got you," Adora promises. Catra whimpers softly, pressing in tight against her like mere skin contact is going to be enough. Adora *knows* that sound by now, and she also knows what Catra was in the middle of when she walked in.

Aside from the first time, she is never the one to suggest this. By making sure it is only brought up when Catra wants to, she adds another layer of affirming consent to it. Still, they had been on shaky ground before today, and she wants Catra to know it is still okay. They have a *system* after all.

"You need to turn over? I'm here either way," Adora asks her, softly, hoping Catra will understand her meaning. She *definitely* does, because her hips twitch and legs shift restlessly. This time, her whimper is closer to a moan. Adora doesn't say anything, just petting down her back and waiting. She doesn't want to do anything to pressure her, but she thinks Catra needs this right now.

Catra's libido goes up on her heat, but that is about it. She is hornier than normal, and it makes it difficult to concentrate if she doesn't get off regularly enough, but it doesn't make her *desperate* or anything. She is still perfectly capable of making decisions, including asking for help when she needs it. Still, getting interrupted in the middle can't have been great when her body is making demands right now. Adora wants her to know she is still happy to give her the option.

"Is that okay? You don't have to," Catra murmurs against her neck. She sounds *awful*, which is all the encouragement Adora needs. She nods against the top of Catra's head.

"You know I never mind. Whatever you need right now," she promises her. Catra lets out a soft sound, happy and relieved, before she rolls over in the bed, wriggling back against Adora until they are pressed together. Adora reaches over, rucking up Catra's shirt so she can slip her arm around Catra's bare waist, giving her that direct contact she needs. Catra sighs, content, as Adora pulls their bodies together with arm around her waist. Their hips slot together as she finally slips a hand beneath the sheets again.

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Catra gets a text from Adora warning that she is heading home, and instantly feels heat claw between her legs at the thought of having Adora around again. She has already gotten off, but it has been a few hours, and twice a day isn't *normal* on her heat, especially when she is just relying on her hand. When Adora holds her for it, it calms her body more, but given the week they have had she thinks it is best to deal with this herself.

Besides, she always feels guilty when she lets Adora hold her, no matter how good it feels. Doing this alone in her bed doesn't feel like a violation, not when Adora *knew*, but even though the whole arrangement was Adora's suggestion, Adora doesn't know everything Catra feels and is getting out of it. For now, it is probably best to just get this over with so she can enjoy Adora's innocent affection when she gets back. She shuffles her boxers down to tangle around her knees and noses into the comforter, breathing in the scent, imagining Adora against her like she had been all morning-

And then Adora comes home. This is the side of her heats that Adora is *understanding* about. No normal person is okay with their best friend getting off in their bed – no normal person is okay with laying at their friend's back and *holding* them while they do it – but after Catra's first heat where it just kind of *happened*, they had a conversation about this.

That was the conversation that solidified for her Adora was never going to be interested. Adora had been so casual, offering to help her like that with the next one too if she needed it. She had to use the phrase *your friend*, too. Adora thinking of her like that is apparently so outside of her abilities that she could hold Catra while she was getting off and still think it was a *friending*.

Catra is determined to take care of things herself this time, so of course Adora hurries home at record speeds that shouldn't even be possible given the bus schedule and catches Catra in the middle of the act. She offers, and Catra puts up the token protest she knows she should, but when Adora says she doesn't mind—and there is more proof, that this isn't something she enjoys herself but merely something that doesn't bother her—Catra can't resist anymore.

She wriggles to press her back firmly against Adora, to feel her body touching every inch of her as she shoves her boxers back down her thighs. Adora's arm around her waist flexes, pulling them tighter together now Catra's lower half is free. Catra is grateful Adora had the forethought to bunch up her shirt so she can feel her arm directly on her fur.

She can't help the soft moan she gives as soon she traces her fingers over herself. She usually tries to bite down on her sounds when she does this, and when she is on her own it isn't a problem, but-

But she has Adora's warm breath puffing against her ear, her face tucked into her hair. She has Adora pressed tight against her back, all the way down to their ankles. If Adora's arm around her waist was any tighter she might be having difficulty breathing, that is how close Adora is pressing them together. Adora's body heat is a comforting blanket against her, while her heart beats steadily against her back.

Catra doesn't have to picture anything. There is no fantasy as she begins to work her fingers over her clit. She just sinks into Adora's arms, unable to fight her moans and sighs. Heat is radiating between her legs and from Adora at her back, and on all sides she is surrounded by the comforting safety of Adora's scent. The inferno can take her and reduce her to ash for all she cares, because Adora starts whispering in her ear.

"It's okay. I have you. You're safe," she assures, voice low as she presses a kiss to the base of Catra's ear. Catra almost comes right then, hips stuttering and moaning out a shaky sound approaching

Adora's name. Adora's hand on her stomach moves, petting soft strokes there even as she holds her close. "It's just us. I'm right here," she promises.

Catra mewls, rocking her hips back, needing *more* of Adora against her. Adora doesn't pull back, letting Catra grind against her as she works her hand desperately over herself, panting and whining with each breath. In the space of a few minutes, Adora has run her ragged by just *being*, holding her close and giving her that assurance that she truthfully always wants, but especially needs during her heat.

"You can let go. I'm here for you," Adora tells her, flexing the arm around her waist again, and that is all it takes. The heat threatening to overtake her blazes like a wildfire. She definitely cries out, though she doesn't think she is loud about it, her hips rocking desperately forward against her hand as her vision whites out.

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Catra cries out her name when she comes. It makes Adora's breath catch, her hips twitching of their own accord. She always tries to force her reaction down when they are like this. This isn't *for* her, it is just something Catra needs, and she shouldn't let herself enjoy it that way. It is what she should have reminded herself of earlier in the week, but she was far too desperate for Catra to resist then. Now she has her, writhing weakly in her arms as she desperately works her hips against her own hand. Adora is hopelessly turned on, her shorts clinging to her and face flushed as she feels all of Catra's muscles tense and *clench* before the final moment of release.

It is the hottest thing Adora has ever seen. Catra is flushed, panting, and utterly relaxed as she goes limp in her arms, purr rolling forward in rhythmic swells. Adora forces herself to swallow despite how dry

her mouth has gone, petting along Catra's stomach like she had been before she was overtaken by awe at the sight of Catra. She still can't believe she gets to see this - that Catra trusts her like this.

"There you go. Just relax. I'll be here," she assures, her voice a little rough and shaky, but it is the best she can manage with the liquid desire working its way down her thighs now. She should pull away, run to the bathroom to just finish herself off and clean up, but she isn't going to *leave*. The soft trill Catra releases as Adora gathers her up in her arms and rearranges them tells her that Catra wants her to stay.

Catra usually likes to lay draped over Adora's chest during her heats. Something about holding her down and knowing she isn't leaving. Adora *is not*, so she rearranges them the way Catra wants them to be when she needs that assurance, hiking Catra's boxers back up over her hips as she does so. Catra is either barely conscious or completely out of it. She is purring like an engine, but her body is limp as she nuzzles into Adora neck.

Adora has seen her like this two or three times during her heat, so she doesn't worry, knowing it just means her body has been running too hard and is finally relaxing. It is a display of utter trust, letting Adora not only hold her through it, but letting go and trusting she will care for her while she is out of it afterwards. Adora's chest feels a bit tight thinking about it. She squeezes Catra closer, just needing to hold her for a moment. She loves it when Catra relaxes like this, and it gives her time to calm down the fire inside her.

Absently, she rucks Catra's shirt up so she can pet directly down her back. Catra's purr rolls louder again, though no part of her so much as twitches. Her tail is lying limp on the bed, calm compared to the way it was twitching tensely between them as Catra touched herself. Adora reaches for it, taking advantage of Catra's limpness to curl it up within reach so she can pet down its length while her other hand continues to trace down Catra's spine.

The coil of need has finally loosened, letting Adora breathe easier. Catra's ear twitches as she lets out a soft *mph*. Adora bites on her lip to keep from reacting to that. It was *adorable*, but she doesn't think Catra will take too kindly to her saying so – right now or ever. Still, she pauses her petting to just hold Catra close for a moment, squeezing her in a hug, before she resumes her ministrations.

"You back with me?" Adora asks, softly. Catra makes a soft noise in her throat that is either the closest thing she can manage to words right now or completely coincidental. She nudges in closer against Adora's throat, but otherwise stays completely limp.

"Mm. Thanks," she manages, words rumbling with the vibration in her chest. She always thanks Adora after. Adora lets out a soft breath, ducking her head down a little to nudge into Catra's hair. If Catra is allowed affectionate headbutts, so is she.

"You going to fall asleep on me now?" she asks, because she thinks Catra might already be halfway there. All she gets in response is Catra's rolling purr, but that is answer enough on its own. She smiles to herself as she lets herself just enjoy petting her friend, content now that Catra is out of it enough to not notice Adora's own state. By the time she wakes up, hopefully the traces of it will be faded.

Catra has never noticed anything on her previous heats, anyway. This time seemed more intense for her than usual, so it was more intense for *Adora* in turn, but Adora does at least have a defense for her reaction. She may have never done this really, but she and Catra both know how she leans – Catra was the one who taught her words like top and bottom – and it would take someone without a pulse to not react to someone writhing and moaning against them like that anyway.

For now, Adora decides not to worry about it. Catra is content, purring and nuzzling against her as she drifts off, so Adora lets herself just enjoy having Catra in her arms when this time yesterday they weren't even speaking. Adora has homework, but it doesn't matter to her as much as the feeling of Catra against her.

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Catra wakes up around dinner time. She is on the bed beside Adora, her head pillowed on her chest. Adora has her right arm draped over Catra's back, softly petting where her shirt has been rucked up while she types on her phone with her left hand. Adora was softly humming to herself, but as soon as Catra is conscious again she starts purring and it makes Adora cut off with a delighted sound.

"You awake?" she prompts softly, the hand on her back raising to gently tousle her ears. Catra butts her head up into the touch and Adora takes the hint to scratch at her scalp. Catra absolutely melts, her tail swaying happily as she nuzzles into the affection. Her body seems to be satisfied after such an intense orgasm. Now she just feels warm and fuzzy all over, safe and content.

"Feels good," she mumbles around her purr, not really sure if she is talking about the touch or just her general state. She feels so satisfied she thinks she might have fallen into some kind of pocket dimension where everything is perfect. She doesn't know what she was thinking trying to get off on her own and not bother Adora. The comfort she gets from Adora surrounding her like that is just as good as the orgasm.

"I'm glad you're feeling better, but I also *really* have to pee. I didn't want to disturb you or have you wake up alone," Adora tells her, voice a bit pleading as she sends Catra a desperate look. Catra is the maybe happiest she has ever been right now and she really doesn't want it to end, but she reluctantly rolls off Adora, immediately rubbing her face in against the sheets as Adora lets out a loud sigh of relief and starts to climb out of the bed.

"Come back after," she mutters, a little embarrassed by the request when she knows Adora is coming back anyway, but she also really

doesnt want her to go. Adora pauses at the edge of the bed. Catra cant see her – she is kind of face first in the comforter right now , and busily marking it – but after a moment she feels the mattress shift as Adora reaches out, petting over her ears and finishing with a scratch behind them.

Catra goes limp against the sheets. *I'm literally in heat, I can't help it* . Adora's hand pulls away and Catra fails to bite down on her answering whine. Adora laughs, light and amused, as she rises from the bed.

"Can I shower , or do you need me back?" she asks, amusement dancing in her voice. Catra has to suppress a twitch. She doesnt actually want Adora to shower, it will wash away all her hard work marking her and she *likes* the way Adora smells, but she knows Adora starts *feelinggross* or something if she doesnt get her shower in. Catra is fine now though - maybe a bit needier than usual, but she doesnt need anything from Adora. She has no excuse.

"I'M fine," she responds, muffled by the sheets, despite how she doesnt want to. Adora hesitates for a moment, *probably* because Catra's tail is lashing behind her, but after a moment she heads across the room to her closet to grab a change of clothes.

Catra sighs, letting herself breathe in the sheets and comfort herself with Adora's scent there as she listens to Adora shuffling out into the hall. She can still hear her moving around inside their shared bathroom, the one benefit to her extra-sensitive hearing during her heat, and it helps soothe her as she is left alone in Adora's room. *Her room* , for the next few days. The thought makes her purr, kneading absently against the sheets.

In the bathroom, she hears the sound of the shower turning on. It covers up the sounds of Adora moving around. Catra tries to pretend there is any word for her current emotion other than *crestfallen* . All she wants right now is to be wrapped up in Adora, and on a normal day she is able to trick herself that her bed is close enough, but after

one of the hardest orgasms of her life, she really cant delude herself.

Catra sighs, slipping out of the bed and wrapping the blankets around herself in a cocoon as she makes her way out into the hall.

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Adora lets out a sigh of relief when the hot water hits her back. She is a little stiff from the awkward angle her arm ended up at after Catra just *slid* off her during her sleep. She immediately nuzzled back in against Adora's chest, never waking, so Adora just held still. She would rather deal with the slight discomfort than wake her.

Now she *is* awake though, it is a relief to wash off the traces of how insanely turned on she got feeling Catra writhe in her arms like that. Catra is usually still when Adora holds her through it, but apparently she was *really* worked up today. Then again, she has never been interrupted and had to wait like that before.

After a good ten minutes standing under the water, Adora is starting to feel like a normal human who *doesn't* get off on their roommate's moans and finally shuts off the shower. She takes a few minutes to dry herself and wring out her ponytail – Glimmer would screech about proper haircare if she knew, but Adora wants to get back to Catra and what she doesnt know wont hurt her – before she pulls on the pajamas she brought with her into the bathroom.

She opens the bathroom door and nearly trips over Catra, blinking down at her in shock as she slumps a little after the door she was leaning against opens. Catra looks up at her to glare, but she blushes when she catches Adora's shock. Catra is wrapped up in Adora's comforter, curled up against the door jam, clearly waiting for her. Adora doesnt *mean* to keep staring, but her heart is doing some

weird twitching in her chest right now and she feels a bit breathless. Catra's blush is absolutely blazing now as she sinks into her blanket cloak, looking off to the side.

"I couldn't hear you over the shower from the bedroom," she mutters. The words come out like pulling teeth. Adora forces down whatever palpitations are going on in her chest, leaning down to scoop Catra up off the floor so she doesn't have to disturb her blanket cocoon.

It is hard to do – Adora may be serious about maintaining her strength, but she also hasn't played football competitively for a year now – but it is totally worth it from the way Catra lets out a sound that is either a combination of a squeak, trill, and hiss, or just all three in quick succession. If it wouldn't make her drop her friend, she would laugh as she carries her down the hall.

"Missed me that bad, huh?" she teases as she nudges the bedroom door open with her foot. In her arms, Catra growls even as she tucks her head under Adora's chin. She kind of left the bed a *mess*, one of the pillow's knocked to the floor and the sheets askew, but that only makes Adora's heart grow warmer because it means she was in a hurry.

"No, I got cold, *bitch*. I'm just using you for your body," Catra complains, rubbing her face in against Adora's neck. Adora deposits her on the bed, earning a growl as she straightens to raise a brow at Catra, putting distance between them as she grins down at her friend. Catra is blushing, the loose blanket cocoon denting back and forth on either side of Catra's legs as her tail lashes in her fluster.

"Of course. That's why you were sitting on the cold floor," she points out, before she sets to fixing the bed again. Catra makes it *difficult*, hissing when she tries to take the comforter back to actually lay it over her this time, and then inserting herself over whichever part of the bed Adora is trying to fix after she loses that fight. Adora huffs as Catra grins up at her from the head of the bed, laying exactly where her pillow normally goes.

"You are impossible," she tells her before putting the pillow down anyway, smothering Catra a little bit and earning sputtering and snarling. Catra squirms out from under the pillow, her hair an absolute mess, and glares up at Adora.

"Get in the bed, asshole. It's cuddles until dinner, and then more cuddles," Catra dictates, already reaching out with grabby hands. Adora rolls her eyes, but she can't help the smile that spreads across her face as she slips into the bed with Catra.

"But you totally didn't miss me," she reminds, as she pulls Catra into her arms. Catra growls, but Adora just laughs and presses a kiss to her ears. The growl instantly transforms into a purr.

Chapter End Notes

After this fic, I'm going to write a prequel fic of Catra's first heat/their first time together.

Just Friend Things

Chapter Notes

> This is my town and I make the rules, so Etheria doesnt have the concept of virginity because it is a *[illegible]*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

On Friday, Adora asks Catra again if she wants her to call in sick. Catra levels her with a glare that says no for her, and Adora laughs and tousles her ears like an asshole. She does that a lot ever since Catra cut all her hair off in the Great Drunken Pincers Incident when she and Scorpia were left to their own devices while wasted and decided Catra giving herself bangs again was a terrible idea, but Scorpia could definitely help.

She couldnt.

"Okay . You can stay in here all day if you need too. Right now, though, I need my morning workout and breakfast,"Adora returns, pressing a kiss to the base of her ear before she tries to slip out of the bed. Tries being the operative word, because Catra wraps around her like she is an octopus. Adora laughs as Catra sets to marking her jaw, maybe rubbing her ears along Adora's face too because her heats are the only time that Adora kisses her ears and she wants to take advantage of it while she has it.

Friday turns out easier than Thursday, even after Catra has to sit on the couch and just watch Adora move, sweat, and flex. She is flushed to her ears, but she also hasnt gotten of f since Adora got home yesterday, and she was doing fine until Adora started her

jumping squats routine. Adora either doesn't notice her watching with a twitching tail or doesn't comment, letting Catra cuddle up to her afterwards while she fixes breakfast.

"Remember the lycan I did that group demonstration with who tried to hit on me?" Adora asks her as they cuddle on the couch, Catra tucked into her side and their plates in their laps. Catra doesn't decide to growl, but she feels a burst of annoyance that becomes vocal and Adora laughs as she grumbles at her side.

Adora had been so fucking *blind* . Catra has never even met this girl, but Adora's description of how pushy she was when they were working together, combined with her insistence on getting Adora's number, had been obvious enough. Catra had made sure she marked the hell out of Adora when she next went to class, and Adora had come home confused why her partner was suddenly giving her the cold shoulder.

Catra had to explain the whole thing to her, minus the fact that she had definitely marked her like that on purpose to drive the woman off, and Adora had been disappointed that the woman was only being nice to her because she was interested like that. In her mind, she was just making a friend. Catra fell in love with a moron.

"I think I scarred her when I went to class yesterday . Her fur fluffed up the instant I walked in the room. What'd you do, write 'mine' in pheromones?" she asks, voice amused and eyes sparkling as she continues to eat. Catra growls a warning to her, but from the sparkle in her eye Catra knows she has done nothing to deter her. *Fine* . Two can play at this game.

"*Yes*," she growls, before pressing forward and dragging her cheek along the lower half of Adora's face to mark her again. "I don't want you smelling like anyone else right now. They can back off," she growls when she pulls back, looking away and tucking down into Adora's side again. Adora hums, apparently content with that.

I think D . Spinerella noticed some of the hybrids shooting me looks. She gave a small lecture on inclusion and lack of judgement in healthcare,"Adora tells her . She still sounds amused. Catra sulks into her side, feeling her ears drop down. A lycan should understand, but Catra knows there are some other hybrids in the class. People who can pick up the signals but not get it. Adora notices her sulking.

"Catra, it' s fine. Im proud to be the one you trust with this. If they want to judge it then thats their problem,"Adora tells her , wrapping her arm around her and pulling her close. Catra feels herself purr, unbidden, and turns to tuck her face into Adora's shoulder. Adora absolutely radiates happiness, the dork.

Catra is, *maybe* , completely fucking soaked. At least Adora has to leave for class soon.

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They spend most of Friday and Saturday in Adora's room, like they usually do during Catra's heat. Catra snuggles into Adora's bed when she has to work at her desk, and wraps herself around Adora when she joins her in the bed. Adora slips out for a run Saturday morning to give her privacy to take care of things, since she has no other reason to leave, and even though Catra says *yes* when Adora asks if that is okay, she is clearly reluctant.

By Saturday evening, Catra is squirming in her arms as she watches the Super Pal Trio group chat explode over something Entrapta is doing –Adora cant read her screen, Catra is wriggling that much – and absently twitching her hips as she shifts. It *has* been awhile since her private time this morning, and she is pretty sure Catra usually goes two or three times a day during her heat.

“Want me to go fix dinner?” she asks Catra, pressing a kiss to the base of her ear. They do need to eat soon, but it is a convenient reason to give Catra privacy if she wants it. Catra immediately snarls, flipping over in her arms to glare down at Adora. Unfortunately, that leaves her straddling Adora’s hips, and they both flush when the dampness soaking through Catra’s boxers meets Adora’s stomach directly. Her shirt got rucked up when Catra decided in the midst of her squirming that she needed to mark Adora’s abdomen as hers too.

Adora blinks up at Catra while Catra stares down at her, face flushed and pupils dilated. Her ears pin back, obviously embarrassed, but her hips give an almost imperceptible twitch. Adora bites her lip, trying to maintain an expression even vaguely related to neutral. She is probably failing. Carefully, she reaches up and places her hands on Catra’s shoulders, tugging her down so she is draping across her chest. It places less weight on her hips, but Adora can definitely still feel her.

“You want me to hold you through it?” she asks, voice surprisingly even. She really isn’t supposed to offer, but clearly Catra has let herself get worked up and held back. She might still be unsure if Adora is comfortable, despite how close they have been since her heat started. Catra gives a soft moan, her hips twitching down. Adora holds her breath, closing her eyes and trying to concentrate on pure thoughts as she feels her own wave of desire. Catra tucks her head down into Adora’s chest, nodding, but she doesn’t move.

Adora hesitates. She doesn’t want to position Catra herself, especially without verbal consent. She knows Catra is perfectly capable of making decisions for herself and giving consent during her heat, but she always wants to be careful with her. Cautiously, she runs her hand down Catra’s back, hoping to coax her into shifting, but all Catra does is arch her back into the touch—and then bring her hips down and moan when she rubs herself onto Adora’s hips.

Adora is going to *die*. She is definitely wet, a burning ache between her legs now. Catra still isn't moving. They always do this with Adora at Catra's back. It is the way it happened the first time, and though they don't talk about this often, when they have their check-in after Catra's heat has passed she always just says what they have been doing helps.

Catra facing away from her while they do this is probably the only thing that has saved Adora from discovery. Now, Catra has agreed that she wants it, but she is still plastered against her front, shifting a little against Adora. Adora swallows, squeezing her hands on Catra's back.

"What do you want, Catra? I'm right here," Adora asks, bringing one hand up to tangle in Catra's hair and scratch at her scalp. Catra gasps a little, shifting her head up even as her hips twitch down again.

"Can we stay like this? I can ignore it. I just need you against me," Catra asks, voice quiet like she is afraid Adora is going to say *no*. She swallows, tugging on Catra's hair a little to encourage her to lift her head. Instead, she moans and tucks her face in, hips rolling down before she catches up with herself and freezes against Adora.

"I'm sorry," Catra whispers. She really sounds *afraid* Adora's chest is a little tight, and her thighs are definitely clenching, but she slowly releases her grip on Catra's hair and pretends not to hear the whine of loss.

"It's okay. Whatever you need. Whatever helps," Adora tells her. Her voice is no longer even, a little rough, but she would be shocked if Catra couldn't smell it on her, and in her defense Catra is *grinding* on her. If Adora is having trouble concentrating right now, she knows Catra must be as well. Catra draws in a sharp breath against her chest and holds it for a long moment.

"How- *weird* would it be if I asked for your thigh right now?" she whispers, words cautious. Adora's mouth grows *dry* as she tries to

formulate a response to that. Catra takes her silence for a no, clearly, because she goes a bit limp against her and tucks her face deeper into Adora's chest. "Sorry . I know that's not- what we agreed to. I just want to be held like this right now. Ill be fine," Catra mutters. There is a nervous edge to her words. Adora swallows.

"If youre sure that is what you want, I dont mind. I just need to know it's not something youll regret," Adora tells her , despite how she absolutely shouldnt. Her mind is completely blank except for images of Catra riding her thigh right now, and the lizard part of her brain is telling her *go*. She made a promise to herself that she would never actually touch Catra during her heat, but this isnt that, not really , and it was Catra's idea. Catra looks up to her, expression cautious, hopeful, and darkened with desire.

"Im sure. Ive thought about asking before, but I didnt want to make things weird," Catra tells her . Adora blinks down at her. If this is something she has thought about in in past heats, then it is likely okay. She nods, sending Catra what she hopes is an encouraging smile. Catra draws a breath, her ears twitching, and then she shifts, wriggling her hips down until she is lower on Adora's chest, her hips positioned over her thighs.

Cautiously, Adora props her leg up, and watches with fascination as Catra slides a leg between her own to straddle it. Catra lets out a soft *ah* the moment she meets Adora's thigh, her damp boxers caught between them. Adora slides her hands so one is in Catra's hair again and the other is on her back, holding their chests together. Catra moans softly, her hips twitching but holding herself still.

"Is this okay?" she breathes. Adora feels like she is going to fucking *die*. Yes, it is absolutely okay. She should be the one asking that, really, but instead she just croaks out-

"Y eah. Ive got you. T ake what you need," she manages, her voice rough, but Catra's thigh is *between her* right now and she is pretty sure higher functions are beyond her. She wonders if this is what Catra's heat feels like when she gets pent up. She has never

been in a position this intimate with anyone, and certainly nowhere even close with anyone other than Catra.

As Catra finally starts to work her hips down, rhythmic and panting, Adora decides she is never going to have sex for the rest of her life, because it cant compare to *this* . Catra stays pressed tight against her front, nuzzling into the underside of her chest with her arms wrapped around Adora's waist, rolling her hips down in a practiced rhythm Adora is going to be tapping on every surface beneath her hands for the rest of her life.

Catra moans as she works her hips, releasing sharp cries every now and then when she hits it just *right* , her breath ragged and panting. Her tail lashes as she shifts her legs up to better position her hips for grinding down. It brings her knee to brush against Adora.

"*Fuck* ,"she hisses, feeling her eyes slip closed at just the *brush* of contact against her aching center. Catra whines above her, still rolling her hips, but she somehow manages to pant out real words. Adora has been reduced to mere cursing.

"Do you want- W e can both-"she manages to stammer out, shifting her head to finally look at Adora, her eyes brimming with desire and face flushed. The eye contact makes it even more intimate, but Adora cant look away , just like how she cant hold back her answering moan, twitching her hips down against Catra's leg.

"*Yes*,"is the best she can manage, and then Catra is bringing her own leg against her and the rest of Adora's sad excuse for thoughts just white out. All she can do is hold Catra's hungry gaze as she tries to work her hips like Catra has been doing against her.

It is a bit awkward, at first, as she rolls her hips in nothing approaching a steady rhythm, but after a few moments they manage to sync up, and then they are moving *together* , Catra bringing herself down against Adora's flexing thigh as Adora rolls up against where Catra's knee is braced on the mattress between her legs.

It shouldnt be as good as it is, not when it is just the broad surface of Catra's thigh, but Adora's breath is absolutely ragged as she tugs on Catra's hair and earns moaning and whining – moaning of *her name* as she looks up at her, Catra desperately panting *Adora* against her shirt until the sound is high and desperate as she works herself over against her thigh. Catra's gaze is hungry as it holds hers.

Catra mewls nothing approaching words when she comes, and Adora's vision goes blank as her orgasm rushes over her a few seconds after.

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Catra is fucking exhausted, and if there was ever a time she wishes she would just pass out after sex it is now, but no, her body is not going to let her miss a second of Adora twitching beneath her as the aftershocks hit. The room smells like sex – smells like *Adora and* just had sex – and all she can register is the heat of Adora's body beneath her.

They are both panting, damp with Adora's sweat as they come back to themselves. Catra's mind is still catching up with what she just did. Not that she could ever regret it, but she also cant believe Adora wanted that, *and* with her like that. It shouldnt be shocking, maybe – even having someone you arent interested in grinding against you is bound to work you up – but Adora had been so desperate for it by the time Catra touched her-

Fuck. She is an idiot. Adora is a virgin – was, anyway, because even Catra cant lie to herself that what they just did wasnt sex, not once they hit their rhythm grinding together, bodies rolling forward to meet each other and Catra moaning Adora's name while Adora tugged on her hair and stared down at her with reverent eyes. Catra blinks up

at Adora, watching her shudder a little beneath her – aftershock, *I'll* , because Adora has never *done* this before.

She is grateful Adora finally broke eye contact and fluttered her eyes shut when she came, because Catra is going through a realization right now that Adora just let her do that, and it kind of feels earth-shattering. Catra swallows, her mouth completely dry. *Fuck* does she hope that wasn't a heat of the moment thing. They were both calm when Adora agreed to give Catra her thigh, but by the time Catra asked if she wanted her to return the favour, Adora was a little far gone. If Adora regrets it-

Adora flutters her eyes open, blinking blankly up at the ceiling. Her cheeks are flushed still, her lips parted a bit as she breathes heavily. Some part of Catra's brain brings up the word *kiss* and the rest of her mind surrounds it and shoots it dead with a firing squad. Absolutely not. She will count herself lucky if Adora doesn't kick her out.

And then Adora *smiles* , easy and relaxed and totally high on endorphins, looking down at Catra with the only facial expression she ever wants to see on Adora's face for the rest of her miserable life. Miserable, because now she knows what Adora looks like when she comes, and at her *lowest* she will just get to see it every few months when her heat hits, and at worst she is never going to see Adora's face again after this.

"You good?" Adora asks, breathless and happy as she runs her hand in Catra's hair up to scratch behind her ears. Catra melts beneath her touch, some of her worry leaking away as she lets herself go limp on her roommate's chest.

"Fucking fantastic," she manages, voice a bit shaky . Okay, so Adora is okay with this right now. She wishes she could kill the hopeful part of her mind that says *everyone does* as easily as she could the part of that brought up *kiss* but-

But the thing is, they have kind of had an arrangement for a while anyway, and this she can pass off. Adora may have never dated, too busy with school and sports and work, but Catra has fucked her best friend before and –apparently – she will again. Her arrangement with Scorpia fell apart because of Scorpia's feelings for her, but Catra is aware of her own feelings, and she doesn't give a shit. She will break her own heart, but so *be it* . The way Adora looked at her with awe as she came is all she really cares about now.

"That was all okay? I – should have called time out so we could talk about it and be sure," Adora asks. Catra groans, shifting up a little to tuck her face down into Adora's neck.

"Adora, I'm still capable of making decisions, you know that. I'm probably going to be good until *Monday* after that," Catra tells her , a bit reluctantly, but she does *not* want Adora doubting this. Adora breathes a gentle sigh of relief. Her hands fell away, overly cautious, when Catra shifted up to tuck into her neck, but now they land in her hair again, gently scratching at the base of her ears. Catra was a bit too caught up in panic for a moment there to purr, but now she is, vibrations rumbling between them.

She kind of regrets telling Adora she will be fine for that long, despite it probably being true. If repeats are on the table, she just took them off of it for two days. Fuck, she is so greedy. A few seconds ago, she was worrying about Adora even speaking to her again, but now she has not immediately run her off, Catra wants more.

Despite the affections to her ears, Adora is still a bit tense beneath her. Catra bites her lip. She isn't being a good partner right now , not even a good friend, too caught up in her own panic to be checking on Adora. Adora asked *her* , but that doesn't guarantee she is okay herself. Catra shifts, sitting up a little and rearranging herself so she is straddled over Adora's hips again, her hands reaching up to frame her face. Adora stares up at her in surprise, looking a little anxious.

"Adora, *relax* for me. I can hear you worrying. Sex should be fun," Catra tells her, a bit cautious as she stares down at her. Adora's

eyes go *wider* , but at least the edge of worry softens a bit and she nods. Catra breathes a sigh of relief. "Okay . Was that good for you? Do you need anything now?" Catra asks her . Adora is flushed up to her ears, still staring at Catra mutely. Catra frowns to herself, reaching one hand up to stroke through Adora's hair. Adora actually startles a little at the touch, but at least she is blinking now instead of just *staring* .

"I should be asking you that? You're the one who-" Adora starts, but cuts off when Catra scowls at her.

"In heat or not, I *know* that was your first time. Im fine. I want to make sure you have what you need," Catra explains, still stroking her fingers through Adora's soft hair. Adora looks a bit stunned still, but at least she seems to be processing Catra's words now. After a moment, she manages to gather her thoughts again.

"I'm fine. Cuddling maybe? Then water and dinner , probably," she tells her. Catra pauses, tilting her head as she takes in Adora, remembering how ragged her voice had sounded. The scrutiny makes Adora flush, looking away and shifting beneath her.

"Can I get you water now? I could use some too. And then well cuddle until your stomach growls. It will probably only be five minutes, but that's fine," Catra asks her , tone soft and teasing. Adora flushes again, still staring up at her.

The thing about Catra's heats is she feels vulnerable as hell during them, and she trusts Adora to keep her safe and take care of her. It ranges from everything to chewing out anyone who makes a lewd comment, to holding her and letting her senses just calm down for once. She doesnt know what she would do without Adora. If she can return the favour by taking care of her *a little bit*, it at least feels more like an even exchange.

"I'm going to go get us water , okay? Ill be right back," Catra tells her , making the executive decision to just take care of Adora herself after Adora continues to stare at her. She will stop if Adora protests, but

Adora just blinks up at her and nods. Catra breathes a sigh of relief and slips out of the bed.

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Catra takes care of her. She gets her water, and she asks her how she wants to be held, and it all feels like an utter role reversal, but Catra seems happy to do it, purring as she wraps her arms around Adora. She seems amused by how out of her depth Adora is as she lays with her head on Catra's chest.

"What, did you think I was a shitty top? I know that wasn't exactly traditional, but I want your first time to be good, Adora," Catra tells her, amusement dancing in her eyes. Adora feels herself blush. So far, she has blushed every time Catra has said anything alluding to what they just did as sex. It was, but Adora wasn't thinking of it that way until Catra said it.

She helps Catra whenever she is on her heat, and Catra offered to return the favour. That is how she was thinking of it until Catra said she'd be her first. Catra is right of course, and when it comes to two people with their anatomy a first time is really what you decide it is, but her brain keeps having the thought that she just had sex with Catra, and Catra seems totally fine with it, and then she shuts down a little.

"Trust me, I've overheard enough to know you aren't. I just- pictured this different, I guess," Adora says, and then decides she should die on the spot, because she just admitted to picturing it. Above her, Catra coughs, her tail swaying a bit beneath their entwined legs.

"No one's first time is what they pictured. As long as you enjoyed yourself," Catra tells her , absently petting through her hair. Adora has to fight down a sigh of relief. She thanks whatever deity is watching

over her that Catra missed what Adora was really saying. Adora kind of wants to keep deflecting to make sure that stays true, though.

"What about yours? What did you picture?" she asks, because despite how they talk about everything, they have never talked about sex except in the abstract way two people who have no idea how it really works do. After Adora realized her feelings, it felt like a minefield to address it.

Catra doesn't say anything for a moment, and Adora has just enough time to worry whether that question was too personal before she shifts her head up on Catra's chest to look Catra in the eye and catches how flushed she is. Catra immediately darts her gaze away when Adora makes eye contact, biting her lip in clear embarrassment.

"Not what happened. I guess- I pictured it starting like *that*," Catra tells her, voice reluctant, but she still says it. Adora blinks up at her in surprise. At least why she immediately jumped to labeling it as sex makes more sense, but she knows there is a gap between what Catra is trying to say and what her brain is actually hearing. Catra chances a glance at her and immediately rolls her eyes when she sees Adora's confusion.

"Fuck, Adora, I thought it would be *you*. Shadow spouted all that bullshit about how I wouldn't be able to control myself once my heats started and how you'd better run before I *eat* you or whatever. That's why I started the whole thing with Scorpia. I wanted to understand sex and feel more in control of it once my heats started hitting. Turns out Shadow was just racist on top of being a bitch," Catra tells her, staring determinedly at the ceiling, her cheeks blazing.

And there is the *gap* her mind wasn't crossing. Catra thought it would be her. It makes sense – they have always lived together, so if Catra was going to get hit with her heat and snap or something Adora is the obvious target – but her mind is still kind of melting at the thought that Catra ever even pictured that.

Adora realized she was in love with Catra at roughly the same moment she was holding her dormmate in her arms as Catra touched herself and moaned her name for the first time. Getting through Catra's first heat had already been confusing, but it was *difficult* after that. And all the while, apparently Catra had already started fucking other people so she could *control* herself around Adora when the time came.

Just control herself, Adora reminds her. It didn't have anything to with Adora, just all of Shadow's racist fear-mongering bullshit. Adora was seventeen when Catra overheard that conversation. They were going to age out of the group home soon, and they were looking at colleges that offered free tuition for foster kids together. Shadow was making one last ditch effort to scare them apart before they never spoke to her again. Unfortunately for her, getting jumped by Catra didn't sound like the end of the world to Adora, even if she didn't truly understand why at the time.

But Catra had been afraid of it. She wasn't having some fantasy about them together, she was worried. Like she is worried now, her ears pinning back and trepidation giving way to outright fear as Adora lays silent, having a crisis of monumental proportions. She shoves it down, nudging her cheek a little against Catra's chest just to ground herself with the soft slide of her fur. It seems to assure Catra too, if the way she relaxes a little beneath her is any indication.

"Sometimes I forget how much of Shadow's bullshit you're still fighting through," Adora says, the best explanation she can come up with for her several long moments of silence. It works. Catra softens beneath her, relaxing even as she rolls her eyes.

"Don't forget you are too, but I'll let you know when I manage to get through it all," she promises her voice dry. Adora snorts a laugh, turning to nuzzle more into Catra's chest. It calms her, helps her push down all the thoughts back to freshmen year of college when Catra came back to their dorm one evening and proudly declared that she was hooking up with her friend. The pointed way she said that to Adora makes sense now.

"You ready for dinner now? As nice as this is, I'm starving," Adora tells her, hoping Catra will accept just moving on from the whole topic. They will have to talk more about what they just did once Catra's heat is done, but the first few days are the most intense for her, so Adora doubts she will even need a hand again this far in. They can talk about it when they are both completely clear-headed.

Adora definitely isn't clear-headed right now, her mind spinning out with all this new information she is absorbing. Luckily, Catra seems willing to let it go, stretching out a little beneath her.

"Alright, but it's my choice tonight," Catra agrees. Adora raises a brow at her.

"But let me guess – I'm cooking?" she asks, because Catra wouldn't have needed to specify otherwise. Catra just grins down at her.

Chapter End Notes

> There will be a meta on my tumblr later tonight on Adora's autism in otos.

Revelations

Chapter Notes

Adora works at the YSRA – Youth Sports and Recreation Association. It's similar to the YMCA, but secular.

Adora has work again on Sunday. Catra is feeling good coming off of last night though, and things are easing off a little now she is on day four of her heat. She knows her senses are still going to kick into high gear when Adora leaves, but for now she feels mostly normal. They eat breakfast on the couch again, curled up beside each other as Adora texts her manager that no, she will not be able to stay late at work today, it doesnt matter how many games they have.

Meanwhile, Catra is having her own small crisis via text. Scorpia texts her just before Adora finishes her breakfast and while Catra is still only halfway through her own meal, asking her if she is still up for their weekly yoga session. The implication that Scorpia knows she needs to cancel is there. Perfuma already knew her heat was coming, and Catra hasnt been into work for the last two days.

Catra frowns down at her phone. Despite her plans to go back into work tomorrow, she is *not* leaving the apartment before she has to. Her senses kick up when she is alone in the safety of their home. Being in public is a whole other level of hyper alertness. They usually meet up at Scorpia and Perfuma's place, but as Catra glances between her and Adora's phone screens, she has an idea.

"I think Im going to ask Scorpia to come over while youre gone at work," Catra tells Adora. Out of the corner of her eye, she watches her roommate freeze. Catra blinks as she looks up and meets Adora's eyes to find them burning. Adora is outright glaring at her phone, despite how Catra hasnt actually sent a reply yet.

Catra doesn't understand what has warranted that look. The last time she saw that look, Adora was throwing some blonde onto the floor of a club bathroom. Adora may have had issues with Scorpia when she and Catra first became friends, but Catra had those same issues with Glimmer and Bow when they befriended Adora.

They were used to it being just *them*, and they both had jealousy issues. Making other friends turned out to help them long-term, though. Catra got to see Adora interact with other people she cared about and learn some things she used to find belittling were just Adora. Catra learned how to be a better friend to Adora – and everyone else she ended up befriending in the process, too.

Adora hasn't had issues with Scorpia since Catra called off their arrangement freshmen year, though. She doesn't know what prompted this, but this is pretty much the exact same look she gave Catra when she blew off movie night for a study session with Scorpia. She had to do it, they had an exam coming up, but she knows now that Adora felt like Catra was leaving her behind for Scorpia.

"Hang on, are you *jealous*?" Catra asks her, raising an eyebrow. Adora immediately flushes, turning her head away with a cough, which is *extra's* move. "Holy shit, you are," she says, staring now as Adora slumps down on the couch, looking a bit ashamed.

"You've never wanted anyone else near you during your heats," Adora mutters in defense, cheeks still blazing and looking away. Catra blinks at her. *And she's jealous*.

"Wait, Adora, do you think I'm going to *do* anything with her?" Catra asks, gaping, because *no*. First off, Perfuma, and second - she told Adora just last night that the whole reason she ever started with Scorpia was so that she would feel more in control when her heat came. Scorpia was a friend, and safe, and Catra was fucking terrified of ruining things between her and Adora. Adora immediately shakes her head, expression setting firmly.

“*No*, Catra. I just- Remember two heats ago when Bow brought us food so I could stay in with you? *You* wouldn't even let him into the dorm because he smelled wrong,” Adora explains, waving her phone in her hand as she gestures. She seems flustered, trying to justify her reaction. Catra just slowly blinks at her.

“I had you then. But you're going to leave. Scorpia isn't- she isn't you, but I think my senses will be a little calmer with her around than when I'm totally alone. I'll trust her to keep me safe. Her and Perfuma will just come over here for yoga instead so I don't have to go out. Yoga might help with the muscle tenseness I have during my heat, anyway,” Catra tells her. Adora takes a deep breath – *a steadying* breath – before she sends Catra a semi-apologetic smile, wincing a little.

“Sorry. I know that was unfair of me. I thought we were past our jealousy stuff, but I guess I still have some hanging around,” Adora tells her, hunching her shoulders in a little and looking down at her lap. Catra is still kind of stunned by all this. She is also, *maybe*, internally preening at Adora wanting to keep Catra *hers*, even if they aren't like that.

After Catra's first heat, when they established their check-in talk, Adora said she didn't mind helping Catra through it until she "had someone." Catra wonders now if Adora was just bullshitting then, or if this is something that has developed over time, a protectiveness of this time where it is just them, even if it isn't in the best circumstances.

Adora is shooting her an almost pleading look, fiddling with her plate in her lap, like she is waiting for Catra to *accept her apology* or something. After a moment's hesitation – and another shooting look – Catra sets her mostly-empty plate aside and shuffles closer. Adora practically scrambles to shove her plate onto the end table, leaving her lap open for Catra as she crawls into it, tucking under Adora's chin. Adora releases a gentle sigh, wrapping her arms around Catra gladly.

"I really am happy that you feel safe enough to have someone else around. I just- kind of like your heats? Because we get to cuddle like this. It feels like we're still catching up, you know?" Adora murmurs into her hair, pressing a kiss to the base of each of her ears. Catra feels a purr rising in her chest and does nothing to push it down, letting it roll between them.

Yeah, she does know. They could hardly touch each other once they hit puberty. If Shadow caught them, no matter how innocent the touch, Catra would end up with lashes. That is how they ended up in football together – an excuse to touch each other during practice or the celebratory post-game hugs with the team. Once they reached college and could just touch whenever they wanted to, Catra didn't need the excuse and dropped the sport, but Adora kept it up.

Even now that they're free to touch, Catra sometimes has to pull back for fear of doing something too obvious. Her heats are one of the few times when she is totally unrestrained and needy. She has a convenient excuse on deck for if she goes too far. She could argue it isn't about Adora, just her body reacting. Adora has bought the excuse before and she will again.

"Yeah, I know. Well cuddle plenty when you get back from work, okay?" Catra returns, nuzzling into Adora's neck. Part of her mind suggests pressing a kiss there, and she wonders if the entire firing squad missed last night or the infectious idea is spreading, but she dutifully ignores it.

"I'll hold you to that," Adora tells her. Catra, against her better judgement, finds herself purring.

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"Be careful with her ," Adora warns, her hand on Scorpia' s arm to hold her still as she passes her in the apartment lobby. Scorpia blinks at her in surprise. Perfuma looks a bit too knowing in the face of Adora's intensity, but she doesnt care. Perfuma has always been observant. She has never said anything, not to Adora and not to Catra, so Adora just continues to stare a surprised Scorpia down.

"I was planning on it?" Scorpia returns, sending her an unsure smile. Adora forces herself to take a breath and release the death grip she has on Scorpia's arm. Catra has been around Perfuma while on her heat when she went into work, but she has never even *seen* Scorpia during it and-

Alright, Adora isnt worried about anything happening, especially not from Scorpia's side, but Catra used to have sex with Scorpia and Adora might be having a raging jealousy issue right now. She knows it will be fine, that likely the worst thing will happen is Scorpia doesnt give her enough space-

"Seriously , dont approach her . You could overwhelm her. Let her come to you if she wants to. And she *will* mark you if she does touch you," Adora tells her . Scorpia blinks at her, but she just nods a bit mutely. From over her shoulder, Perfuma looks a bit exasperated at this point. Adora could very well be late for work thanks to this talk, but she doesnt care. She fixes Perfuma with a narrow-eyed look now, which seems to startle her a little.

"Scents are a *lot* for her. Neither of you can really have any idea. Just give her space if she needs it," Adora tells her . She knows it sounds a bit arrogant, but Catra is the only hybrid with increased senses either of them are really close to in their lives, and if Adora hadnt grown up with her and been with her through all her heats then even she wouldnt have a proper grasp on what it's like. She doesnt want Catra to get overwhelmed while she is at work and cant come back to soothe her .

"W e wont touch her , Adora," Perfuma assures. She still looks a bit too amused and knowing for Adora to be satisfied, but she doesnt

really have any choice but to accept Perfuma's words at this point. She already waited until the last possible second to walk out the apartment door, aware Perfuma and Scorpia were almost there and she might be able to linger long enough to supervise when they first met up with Catra. Adora sighs, forcing her jaw to unclench as she looks away, carefully stretching out her fingers at her sides after they had balled into fists.

"I'll fucking hold you to that," she tells them, taking some satisfaction in Perfuma's surprise at hearing her swear before she sets out the lobby doors. As she goes, she checks the time on her phone. She is *definitely* going to be late, but she doesn't regret it one bit.

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Catra does think she will feel better with Scorpia around – hell, she thinks she will feel better with *Perfuma* around based off of how going into work went during her last heat – but she is still a bit nervous when she hears them approaching the door, talking in low murmurs. Catra can't make out every word, but it seems to be stuff along the lines of *she's fine* and *he's just a scratcher*.

That last one makes Catra fling open the apartment door before Scorpia and Perfuma even reach it. She had pinned Adora to it for five minutes straight, marking her face, neck, shoulders, and *arms* before she left for work if only to assure her, but now she leans out it and raises an eyebrow at where Scorpia is strolling up with Perfuma hanging off her arm.

"You ran into Adora, didn't you?" Catra asks, dryly. Her tail is lashing behind her, but at least it is hidden from view in the apartment. Perfuma's look is bemused while Scorpia is a bit confused and sheepish as they both draw to a halt a few feet from the doorway.

"She said not to touch you without permission. That we had to let you come to us," Scorpia relays. Catra snorts. It is the advice for befriending a *stray*, but it is also kind of accurate. Experimentally, she sniffs the air. Scorpia and Perfuma's scents are familiar, floral and earthy, and though neither of them are the drug Adora's scent is-

"You can come in. You're good," Catra tells them, stepping aside from the doorway to let them in the room. Scorpia lights up, like she is excited to be deemed *good* by Catra's highly-specific biology. She beams at Catra as she leads Perfuma into the apartment. Perfuma closes the door, locking it behind them as Scorpia drops the tote bag she was carrying over her shoulder onto the ground beside the door and starts pulling out the mats she brought. They are the same three they usually use, *familiar*, and Catra is grateful for that as she cautiously slips up behind Scorpia.

Perfuma is watching, but Scorpia isn't, too busy unpacking the bag. Catra lets herself get used to being within Scorpia's space, rolling her shoulders experimentally as she checks in with her body on how it is feeling right now. Shockingly, the answer is *safe*. It isn't the comfort she gets from Adora – not that she expected anyone else to compare, anyway – but it is still relaxing. She doesn't feel the edge of anxiety that was already stating to creep in upon Adora's departure anymore, at least. Some of that was likely due to nerves at how this would go, though.

Scorpia straightens, turning around with the yoga mats tucked under her arm, and startles with a yell when she sees how close Catra is. Perfuma giggles while the corner of Catra's mouth quirks up.

"I think Adora was worrying for nothing. You both feel safe," Catra tells her, taking the final step forward to tuck herself in against Scorpia's side. Scorpia *coos*, which forces Catra to pin her ears back, but Scorpia just wraps her free arm around her back and cuddles her close in a one-armed hug. Yeah, definitely not Adora, but still nice, still better than being alone.

Catra hums and lets her eyes slip closed. If her libido was running high at the moment, she doesn't think Scorpia and Perfuma would feel so safe, but it really has felt satisfied since last night. She knows it will start to come back today, and at that point she may want them to leave, but until then-

"Can you guys stay just until Adora's shift is over. It's a half-shift, today," Catra mutters the question, tucking her face into Scorpia's pecs. She got her double mastectomy senior year of high school. She was still really self-conscious about it and the other medical scars she acquired during chemo when she and Catra started sleeping together. Catra likes to think that she helped her feel pretty again, but whatever lingering doubts she didn't get to, Perfuma has definitely taken care of since.

Catra has spent a decent amount of time with her face in Scorpia's utter lack of tits is the point, and she can feel Scorpia's heartbeat along with her radiating warmth from this spot. It *is* safe – but it is safe.

"Of course, however long you'd like. Do you want help moving the sofa so we can lay out the mats?" Perfuma returns, from over Scorpia's shoulder. If Perfuma says it is okay, Catra isn't going to bother asking Scorpia. They never make plans without the other, and Scorpia is fucking *hard* anyway. Whatever her girlfriend says, she will go along with.

"Do you want me to give you an excuse to ogle Scorpia while she moves the couch for us, you mean?" Sure," Catra ribs, finally pulling away from her spot of safety. She instantly feels a little more *edgy*, but it isn't a level she couldn't reach on an average day anyway. "Think I'm going to be real cuddly after yoga though," she relays, turning away and blushing so she doesn't have to see the response to that.

She still *hears* it though, Scorpia's gasp of delight is plenty loud enough to ensure that.

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Adora is late, but she didn't miss the bus and it is only by six minutes, so she doesn't give a shit. She has to clock in thirty minutes before any game starts anyway. She does her best to pay attention – she is the referee, watching is her entire job – but it really is hard to focus on soccer when she is worrying about how Catra is doing right now. She gets a break to text her – okay , she doesn't get a break, she just texts Catra to check in as she is sprinting from the soccer fields to the volleyball court.

Catra texts back that she *is fine* and to *keep her eyes on the game* . Adora didn't explicitly ask how the visit with Scorpia and Perfuma went, and Catra doesn't offer details. Adora is forced to shove her phone into her pocket as the teams start entering the sand. Normally Adora isn't this busy at work, but as one of the few certified medics at the youth club, she has to be present for all the games squeezed into the two days off school every weekend.

The fact that she is trained to referee three different sports is honestly just an afterthought. A way to cut down on the number of paychecks they have to offer. At least the pay is good because of it. She is, after all, doing two jobs – even if her primary job rarely rears her head. There are no incidents today, though a worried mother comes up to her after the game to ask if that impact wasn't *hard* and *didn't they have to be at* – the answer is no to both.

Adora indulges her by giving it a cursory look, but it really is not even going to bruise and she gets off her shift in ten minutes. She hurries back to the main building of the sports complex, waving at her co-workers as she passes them and getting a few weird looks as she heads back to her medical station. The shocked looks from hybrids she gets, she knows Catra practically turned her into an

advertisement before she got out the door, but the two looks she gets shot by her human co-workers make less sense to her.

She is busy humming to herself as she pulls out her key to unlock the door to her office, remembering the assurance she had felt that morning as Catra claimed her and already looking forward to being with her again, when she notices the presence behind her. She finishes opening the door, and then turns around cautiously to find Bow standing in the hallway, *staring* at her. Adora huffs.

"Okay, seriously, you too? Did one of the kids put something on my back?" she asks as she steps into her office, waving her hand to indicate for Bow to follow her. He either will or won't. She doesn't care. Five more minutes and she can clock out and head back to Catra.

Bow does follow, and his expression is a bit more neutral as he pointedly closes the office door. That's probably a bad sign. Adora hesitates over her desk, sending him a questioning look. Bow's gaze is searching and observant as it roams over her, as if he is Sherlock Holmes, looking for clues.

"The hybrids on staff are talking. And one of the canidae in my archery class had a little sister playing in the soccer game," Bow tells her, slowly, almost like he is expecting to spook her, or that she might protest. Adora blinks at him for a moment, but after a second she shrugs, finally sitting at her station.

"I know I smell like Catra's heat. She marked me like seven times before I got out the front door," Adora dismisses, already bending down to pull her timesheets out of her desk drawer. She always is covered with marks during Catra's heat. She has been working at SSRA even longer than Catra has been having them, and though she has gotten a few snickers and heat jokes, no one has ever bothered her about it before. She knows they can tell she has been marked by someone in heat, but that should be about it, and it certainly isn't anything to write home about. To her surprise, she

finds Bow looking at her with a mix of distress and disbelief when she straightens.

"They say you're *lingering magically heat*, Adora. You don't want to know how the teenager in my class phrased it," Bow says. Adora feels herself flush to her ears. She didn't think anyone would be able to still pick that up. It has been half a *day*. She thought Catra would tell her if she smelled like sex.

Actually, there is no way she smells like sex. If the smell lingered this long, everyone would know who was fucking all the time. This wouldn't be worth talking about. This has to be a pheromones thing. That would explain why Catra didn't mention it – it is *her* scent, after all. It would probably be hard to pick up. She will have to ask her when she gets home, because right now she is staring down a gaping Bow.

"*Adora*," he says, entirely admonishing as he takes Adora's silence as confirmation. It is, but he could at least let her protest first.

"I didn't- Bow, you *know* me. I wouldn't do anything she couldn't consent to," Adora scrambles a little. Bow is still looking at her, but she recognizes that expression as *pity* for some reason. She huffs, slouching in her chair as she fiddles with a pen on her desk. "It wasn't even that much more than what we usually do," she argues, and then realizes her fatal mistake when Bow's eyebrows climb into his hairline.

"*Why would you*?" he questions, voice high. Adora winces. Catra is going to fucking kill her. Catra is going to leave her to move in with Scorpia and Perfuma, because they will at least keep her secrets, even if they won't help her out with this like Adora can. Adora decides to ignore Bow in favour of hunching over her timesheet and filling it out. She has hit the end of her shift time anyway, she really needs to get back to Catra and make sure she is okay-

"Adora Eleanor Grayskull, you look at me right now ," Bow orders. Adora feels herself hunch her shoulders as she puts her timesheet away.

"My middle name isnt Eleanor . If you get it right, maybe Ill listen. As it is, I need to get back to her," Adora tells him, standing and busying herself with gathering her jacket. He will never guess it, and luckily for her she knows Catra's middle name too, so she cant spill Adora' s secret without activating their pact of mutually assured destruction. Glimmer and Bow have been trying to guess it ever since they found out it was something embarrassing and havent even gotten the initial right yet.

"Did you have sex with your best friend this morning," Bow says, point-blank and not a question in any way . Adora manages not to flinch.

"No," she answers, honestly . Bow looks incredulous. Adora feels herself shrink into her shoulders a little. "It was last night," she mutters, looking *away* and anywhere but at Bow. Bow makes a distressed noise he definitely picked up from Glimmer. Adora sighs, doing her best to put on a brave face and shoulder past him to the door.

"You want to ask questions, fine, but you have to walk with me, because Im going home," Adora tells him. She opens the door to her office to find Glimmer standing there, staring at her *again* . Adora cannot catch a fucking break today. She raises a hand to rub her temple. "You called Glimmer to tell on me?" she demands, turning back to face Bow. Bow looks entirely unapologetic.

"Adora, sit your ass down right now and explain yourself," Glimmer hisses from behind her. Adora sighs, but she steps back into her office.

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After Scorpia moves the couch, Perfuma lays out their yoga mats. Catra's mat is strategically placed a bit further away than usual. Catra is kind of grateful. There is no way they are talking about emotional shit today, but because of the ties with these sessions she tends to feel more vulnerable during them.

Perfuma makes her promise to tell her if anything is too much, and they get started. Perfuma runs them through a fairly simple routine, the kind of routine Catra surpassed months ago but Scorpia still can't quite get. There is no way she could have handled this before last night, but as it is, it feels like a nice way to get in touch with her body after fighting with it for the last few days.

They cut it short when Catra's limbs started shaking, and are curled up on the newly-replaced couch when Catra gets a text from Adora asking how things are going. She feels her lip curl in amusement as she goes to answer it, assuring Adora everything is fine.

"What *did* Adora say to you?" Catra asks, tilting herself over to cuddle against Scorpia's free side. Scorpia has her other arm thrown over Perfuma's shoulder, but she releases a soft *aw* when Catra tucks in against her. Catra growls in warning but makes no move to pull away. Despite her protests, against Scorpia's side is probably the safest place in the apartment, rivaled only by Adora's empty bed.

"Oh, you know, she was just worried. Typical overprotective Adora stuff. She said not to touch you, and to give you space, that kind of thing. She was in a hurry," Scorpia says, waving her hand. Catra, after not receiving a follow-up from Adora, shoves her phone away and tucks her head against Scorpia chest.

Scorpia really isn't Adora, but she is better than nothing. She has known Scorpia for five fucking years now. Perfuma may have been a later addition, popping up in Scorpia's life nearly two years after Catra called off their whole thing, but Catra trusts them both.

"She also said you would mark us if you let us touch you," Perfuma adds, sounding amused. Catra blushes, slouching even further down Scorpia's side. Adora is a fucking moron, but she is *Catra's* moron, and she smells like it.

"Those are an Adora-exclusive," she mutters, feeling her ears pin back as she fixes her gaze on the tip of her own twitching tail. Perfuma hums, sounding far too smug and knowing. And there is the problem – she *does* know. Scorpia and Perfuma are basically her counselors for her non-existent relationship. Catra feels her hackles raise, a snarl forming in her throat and on her lips before she can bite down on the instinct. Scorpia radiates *concern*, but Perfuma seems unbothered.

"Adora doesn't seem to be aware of that," she says, diplomatically. Catra already knows where this is going. *Say it all with a look, Catra. Don't be so dramatic, communicate,* blah blah. Catra *has*. She has put herself out there, standing on a limb and forced to watch as Adora obliviously walks below where the branch is *cracking* from the pressure.

She can only put herself out there and have Adora totally fail to notice so many times before it becomes obvious she could never think of her that way. Best to quit while she is ahead - to stop before she can embarrass herself further trying to get Adora to even consider her that way.

"Yeah, well, Adora is oblivious to a lot of things," Catra mutters, looking down at the fabric of the lounge pants draping over her thighs. Specifically, over her thigh that was between Adora's last night, working her over as Catra shattered and fell apart, Adora holding all her pieces tightly against her chest.

Apparently Catra's voice was just a little too bitter, because she can practically hear Scorpia and Perfuma exchanging glances above her. Scorpia's arm she is tucked under had been stretched up on the back of the couch, but now she lays a cautious pincer on Catra's shoulder. Without really thinking about it, Catra turns and nuzzles her

face into the touch, not marking, but *enjoying* even if it isn't soft like Adora's skin.

"Catra, did something happen with you and Adora?" Perfuma asks, cautiously. Catra scoffs to herself. Yeah, something *happened* alright, not that Adora acted like it was any different from what they usually do come morning. In some ways, it was reassuring. In others, it made her worry.

Scorpia and Perfuma are both watching her. She feels her ears pin back as she hunches further down the couch. There is nothing accusatory in their gaze, but Catra feels caught anyway. Probably because of what the subject matter is. After several long moments of awkward shifting, she gives.

"We may have had sex last night," she admits, voice low and barely above a whisper. Above her, Scorpia *gapes*, while some dawning realization spreads through Perfuma's gaze.

"Wildcat-" Scorpia starts, but Catra cuts her off with a hiss.

"It wasn't- we didn't *touch* each other. It was just grinding. It wasn't even that much more than our usual arrangement. This time it was just- mutual," she argues. Scorpia looks a bit scandalized by her words, despite the fact Catra has been inside her and she is already well aware of their arrangement. Perfuma's expression is solidifying into *something*, but Catra can't identify it. She doesn't like it, regardless.

"Catra, I know emotional stuff is a struggle for you, but you have to stop having sex with people who are in love with you," Perfuma says, absolutely shocking Catra with both her bluntness and her words.

"If Adora loved me back, we wouldn't be *here*. She would have given *any indication* after the first time I got off in her arms," Catra immediately deflects. Her tail is lashing behind her as Scorpia gives her a semi-pitying look.

"I didn't say anything. Look, Wildcat, sometimes it seems better to stay quiet – you *know* that. Do you think Adora would have done that with anyone she considered just a friend?" Scorpia tells her. Catra narrows her eyes at her.

"I outright told her I thought my first time would be with her and she responded by saying she sometimes forgets how much of Shadow's bullshit is still kicking around my head. Yes, that's *certainly* the reaction of someone who has been secretly hoping for a confession," Catra lays out.

Anyone else, and she would have to give an hour-long presentation on how that response even connects to her statement, but when Catra sat Scorpia down and finally apologized to her for how shitty the whole thing was between them, she also told her why she ever started it. Perfuma looks a bit pained.

"Adora is... repressed. You just need to tell her the truth. You know she won't judge you for it," Perfuma tells her. Yeah, that first part Catra knew. She knew it even before she was Adora's first at twenty-three. The final part Catra also agrees with, actually, but *judgement* isn't what she is worried about.

"No, she will just hate me for letting her touch me while I feel like this, and hate *herself* for *taking advantage of me* or whatever else she convinces herself she did wrong. And don't forget the part where, oops, we already had sex and now her first time is tainted because it was with someone who was lying to her the whole time," Catra scoffs. Perfuma levels her with a look.

"What have we talked about when it comes to looking for the worst possible scenario?" Perfuma reminds her gently. Catra raises an eyebrow at her, slumping further down on the sofa. She is basically laying on the cushions at this point.

"That is *not* the worst case scenario, it is best case. Worst case scenario involves me going to jail, or maybe rehab depending on the day," Catra tells her. Perfuma looks *resigned*. Catra feels the urge to

snarl at her, so she does. Normally she doesnt threaten violence this much with people –at least not anymore –but she isnt in the mood to fight her instincts today. Perfuma purses her lips while Scorpia looks concerned.

"We are going to talk more about this, but it can wait until your heat passes," Perfume decides. Catra decides to downgrade to growling rather than full snarling, but she is grateful even for the temporary drop in the subject. Perfuma is wrong and Catra isnt going to say shit to Adora. She has had enough things taken from her –she doesnt need to rob herself of Adora. Sure, hiding her feelings is stressful and difficult at times, but Adora makes her happy and takes such good care of her.

Scorpia directs them back to lighter topics, and eventually Catra begins to relax again. As much as she wants to, she refuses to steal glances at the clock and feel Perfuma's knowing gaze on her . It is a surprise to her when she catches Adora's scent in the hall, and she blames that for why she reacts like she does.

Her entire body lights up, Catra immediately sitting up as her ears swivel towards the source of the scent. She hears Adora softly cursing as she struggles with her keys. She doesnt tell her body to move, she just *is* pulling herself away from Scorpia's side and leaping over her and Perfuma's laps as she runs for the door on all fours.

By the time Adora has stepped through the front door, Catra has reached the end of the couch, and she launches herself into Adora's arms.

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Adora protests loudly about needing to get back to Catra as Bow and Glimmer force her to sit on the bench in her office. She only shuts up when Glimmer promises to drive her home afterwards so she can be back faster. She still glares up at Glimmer and Bow as they stand over her in twin stern stances, their arms folded. Glimmer is staring her down, and Bow is trying to as well, but he isn't as successful at it.

"What did you do?" Glimmer asks her. Adora feels like she is in the principle's office, being asked to incriminate herself to lighten her punishment. She sighs, slumping in her seat as she tries to figure out what she can say to her best friends. She also feels the need to defend herself from the admonishing looks. She is honestly surprised to be getting them. She would have thought her friends knew her well enough to know she wouldn't take advantage of Catra, but apparently they are still worried.

"Catra and I – have an *arrangement* for her heats. I help her get off when she needs it. That's all. She just returned the favour, this time. I didn't touch her, she didn't touch me, and we're *fine*. I didn't know anyone would be able to tell since they haven't before," Adora says, reluctantly, looking down at her hands as she fidgets with them in her lap.

"*Adora*, how long have you been fucking your best friend?" Glimmer asks, still aghast. Adora winces. She knows why Glimmer is reacting like this, she has not-so-subtly been trying to get Adora to confess since sophomore year, but it really isn't what she thinks it is.

"I *haven't* done that, even if what we did this time was enough to be called sex," she deflects. Glimmer levels her a thoroughly unimpressed look. She feels herself blush, pointedly looking away as she mutters, "Ever since her first heat. We both agreed to it, Glimmer."

"You're in love with her," Bow points out, sounding distressed. Adora flinches. Yes, okay, Glimmer and Bow know, but they still don't have to *say* it.

"And Im happy to be with her in any way she' s comfortable with me. It was good, okay? Im not beating myself up in bed at night. I dont regret it. Ill do it again next time she asks," Adora returns. Glimmer and Bow started out worried for Catra, and now they are worried for her, but *no one needs to be worried for* . She and Catra are fine. They are *happy* . They have a good life together, even if it is as friends. Glimmer narrows her eyes at Adora.

"Remember when you were pissed at Scorpia for sleeping with Catra while she was in love with her?" Glimmer asks. Adora actually scowls at that. Glimmer is calling her a hypocrite, and maybe she is sometimes, but not about *that* .

"I was mad at Scorpia because she was having sex with Catra *period* ," Adora corrects. She didnt know it at the time, she made plenty of other justifications for it, but it was the truth. Glimmer raises an eyebrow and mutters *at least she admitted it* under her breath. Bow still looks pained.

"Adora, one of you is going to get hurt. Y ou're in love with her , and she is in love with you whether you choose to see it or not. You need to tell her the truth," Bow tells her . Adora groans. Bow has claimed this before, but he is *wrong* . Even if he wasnt, Adora is not taking the risk of ruining everything they already have for some *half* .

"Remember what happened when *Scorpia* told her the truth?" Catra immediately called it off and they stopped talking for weeks. It still took another semester for them to really be friends again, and two years after that to *talk* about it. Im happy , Bow. I dont need to drive her away," Adora argues, standing from her spot on the couch. Neither Glimmer nor Bow move, continuing to block her path. Adora glares at them.

"I'm leaving this of fice in five seconds, and neither of you are strong enough to hold me back. She needs me right now," Adora tells them both. Glimmer narrows her eyes at her while Bow shifts, uncertain. Glimmer is trying to call her bluff, but Adora *is not bluff ing* . She shoulders her way between the two of them, heading for the door.

Behind her, there is a conversation in hushed whispers. After a moment, the couple follow her.

Adora breathes a mental sigh of relief. Despite it not being a bluff, she didn't consider the fact that she has to lock her office behind her, and she couldn't exactly lock Glimmer and Bow in. Glimmer levels her with a look before Bow grabs her by the hand and leads her down the hall. They fall into a hushed conversation as Adora locks up the room. She frowns down at her watch. They made her miss the bus. She is going to be twenty minutes late at the least. With a sigh, she turns back to her friends.

"If you drive me back to the apartment, I'll let you chew me out for the whole ride, but I'm still not telling her, and neither are you," Adora tells Glimmer. Glimmer narrows her eyes at her.

"You *are*, but deal," she agrees.

Glimmer asks for details when they get to the car, which Adora leaves at *grinding* and *no, I didn't, she doesn't know I like her*. Glimmer throws both her hands up in the air, despite how they should really be on the wheel.

"I can't believe she trusts you enough to have sex with you, and you're important enough to her you aren't just hooking up all the time, but you still think she doesn't love you back," Glimmer berates her as she pulls up to a light. Adora just hums, staring determinedly out the window. She is listening—it is a little hard not to—but Glimmer is only talking bullshit right now. Catra has hooked up with her best friend before while feeling nothing for her.

For the rest of the car ride, Glimmer alternates between muttering *idiot lesbians* and listing off all the things Catra does that apparently have to mean she is in love with Adora. Most of it is just a basic part of being a close friend with Catra. It is entirely unconvincing. Adora is grateful when they pull up to the visitor parking outside of her complex.

“Adora, wait, one thing, and promise you'll at least actually think about it?” Glimmer tells her as she yanks open the passenger door to flee. Adora sighs, turning to level her with a *dry* look. “If you think Catra just treats you differently because you're *best friends* or whatever, how do you think she would act if she *was* in love?” Glimmer asks.

Adora just blinks at her. She doesn't have an *answer* for that, mostly because she has never thought about it before. Considering such a thing would mean getting *her hopes up*, and she wasn't about to start putting expectations on her best friend. She wasn't eager to delude herself searching for something that wasn't there. She can't afford to trip up and give herself away because she is thinking about it too much and does something obvious.

“I don't know,” Adora gives up, shrugging and hopping out of the car.

“I *know* you don't. Think about it,” Glimmer returns, before Adora pointedly slams the car door. She sends Glimmer a half-hearted wave over her shoulder as she makes her way into the lobby, barely waiting for the door to close behind her before she breaks into a run. She slows down before she gets too far into their hall, not wanting pounding footsteps to disturb Catra, and wanting to catch her breath before she opens the apartment door.

Her keys fight with her, because of course they do when all she wants is to see Catra again. She hears movement in the apartment as she opens the door, which means Catra is awake, but she still isn't expecting her to come *flying at her* when she steps in the doorway.

Adora lets out an *oof* as her arms come up to wrap around Catra's lower back to hold her, and then slide down to grab her ass just to support her when she realizes Catra is wrapping her legs around her waist and her arms around her shoulders, already purring and setting to refreshing the marks along her neck as she rubs her cheek under Adora's jaw.

"Miss me that much?" she manages around a delighted laugh, taking a stumbling step into the apartment with Catra still thoroughly wrapped around her. Catra's tail is waving in rapid excitement behind her as she continues to mark along the side of Adora's neck now, purr rolling louder in answer. As Adora turns to kick the door closed behind her, her arms thoroughly full of magicat, she notices they still have guests.

Scorpia's expression looks like the physical representation of a cooing noise, while Perfuma looks both fond and exasperated from her spot on the couch beside her girlfriend. Adora throws them both a sheepish smile as she hikes up her grip on Catra where she was slipping a bit and staggers over to their single armchair.

She collapses into it, Catra in her lap and still purring like an engine. Her tail has hardly slowed as she nuzzles in. Adora slides her hands up to the far more respectable location of Catra's back, holding her roommate close as she continues her apparent mission to overwrite every trace of scents from the outside world on her.

"I already smell like you, you know . I was getting looks at work all day," Adora tells her , a bit amused as she slides one hand up to scratch at the back of Catra's head. Catra goes *limp* against her, but she growls lowly.

"*Mine*," is her only reply to that. Adora hums, bending down to press a kiss to the base of Catra's ears.

"Always. How are you two?" Adora asks, directing her attention over to the two visitors on their couch. Clearly yoga this morning went well if they are still here. Adora had been worried – like, *really* worried, on top of her jealousy – but apparently it was good, and Catra still missed her even with her friends over all day. This is not the first time Catra has tackled her upon her return home, but it is the first time she has done it without Adora being away from more than a day for an away game or something.

Perfuma is wearing the exact same expression she was when Adora first spotted her, torn between exasperation and fondness, but Scorpia looks a bit *jealous*, which just makes warmth spark in Adora's chest as she cradles Catra – still purring, waving her tail, and marking her – a bit closer to her chest. It doesn't look like the nasty kind of jealousy Adora feels about Catra - Scorpia has been over her feelings for a while now - but Adora can't blame even a friend for wanting cuddles with purring Catra. Seeing that jealousy relaxes her. It means Catra was nothing like this with Scorpia and Perfuma.

"Good. Work has been a little busy, especially being down a paralegal these last few days, but things are going well. Scorpia thinks she might be up for a promotion soon," Perfuma tells her. In Adora's lap, Catra chuffs before Adora can congratulate Scorpia. Adora raises a brow down at Catra. Perfuma looks infinitely more amused.

"We should probably go. Catra asked us to stay until you got home, but we do have some things to do today. She has been as hissy as she is cuddly, anyway," Perfuma tells her. Adora chuckles as, in her arms, Catra thoroughly fails to disprove Perfuma's statement when she growls lowly.

"She gets like that, during her heat. It's just an easier way to communicate. Don't take it personally," Adora tells them as she runs a soothing hand down Catra's back. Catra's growl dies, but she definitely still mutters *fuku* against Adora's neck as she wriggles a little closer.

"No, nothing she did seemed like personal behaviour, don't worry," Perfuma says, still amused. Adora feels her brow furrow, unsure of what that really means. In her arms, Catra huffs and turns her head out from rubbing along Adora to glare at Perfuma.

"Can you stop talking about me like I'm not here? Leave me and my roommate *be*. We have a cuddle quota we need to catch up on," Catra complains before tucking into Adora's chest again and

resuming her gentle purr. Adora knows her face twitches with her conflicting effort to hold back both a laugh and a small barrage of ear kisses for Catra. Perfuma and Scorpia both laugh, but they rise from the couch.

Adora bids them goodbye as they gather their yoga mats and corresponding tote bag, waving as they see themselves out. Adora's lap is a little too *full* at the moment to be getting up and sending them off. They lock the doorknob on their way out, at least, so Adora doesn't have to worry about much of anything but holding a still-purring Catra close. After several moments of silence, Catra speaks.

"I did miss you. It was better than being alone, but they weren't *you*," she tells her, voice quiet, finally replying to Adora's first question upon returning. Adora feels a strong burst of warmth in the center of her chest at the admission.

"I'm right here. I've got you," she promises, pressing a kiss to the base of Catra's ear.

Catra trills in Adora's arms, and she can't help but think about to Glimmer's words. Would this be it? Does she even dare to hope it would?

If she was in love

Chapter Notes

> This chapter contains some references to addiction (not for any of the cast from the show). This is a touchy subject, and I wrote it from my experience having family members with addiction issues. I tried to treat it with respect while also conveying the way it can impact the other people in their lives.
> Family issues and how Adora ended up in the foster system are discussed, so just be braced for that when it comes up later.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They spend Sunday evening cuddling on the couch while Adora does her homework. Catra never asks her for anything, despite Adora knowing it has been a full day now since she has gotten off, she does seem legitimately content after their time together last night.

Well, at least until dinner, when Catra coughs into her hand that she is going to be *in her bedroom for a bit*, and now is a good time for Adora to take a shower. Adora accepts the prompt dutifully and gratefully. After all the shit Glimmer was spouting, Adora is kind of glad to not be in such a vulnerable position with Catra. She feels like she would be overanalyzing everything, when the real reason for Catra's behaviour is that she is in heat and has nothing to do with Adora.

Unfortunately, there is *a* conversation they need to have, if only so Catra can be forewarned. Adora changes in the bathroom after her shower again, although when she comes out Catra is still in the bedroom instead of waiting for her this time. She settles in to watch the TV, and after a little while Catra emerges from Adora's bedroom, dressed in the shirt Adora had been wearing last night – when they

were having sex, Adora's brain helpfully supplies – and a new pair of boxers.

Catra plops down onto the couch beside her, a tell-tale purr still rolling through her as she shifts to tuck under Adora's arm. Adora sets the TV on mute with a sigh of regret. She shifts her arm to be properly wrapped around Catra, feeling how she hesitates. Clearly she is picking up on Adora's reluctance, but she does need to know.

"Something happened at work today," she says, and feels Catra relax a little in her arms. Catra shifts so she can look up at Adora, surveying her carefully.

"Are you okay?" she asks, her gaze searching. Adora draws in a sharp breath, blinking down at Catra as a spike of pleasant warmth spears straight through her traitorous heart.

"Yeah, I really don't care, but I wanted to warn you, because Bow told Glimmer," Adora tells her. Catra frowns, her brow furrowing and a nervous edge entering her vision, but she nods, prompting Adora to go ahead.

"Don't ask me how, because I know I hadn't showered but it had also been *days* - Anyway, the hybrids at work were all gossiping that I was having sex with a magicat in heat," Adora tells her, wincing a little at her own blunt wording, but that is also pretty much how *they* phrased it, so she can only imagine what they were saying was even cruder.

Her co-workers are nice, but they have noticed Adora has been single for the entire five years she has worked there. There have been efforts, including tricking her into going on a blind date, to "finally get her laid." Of course they were going to talk about it once it happened. Catra flushes, her ears pinning back as she stares up at Adora in shock. Adora flinches again.

"I'm sorry. I should have taken the time to shower first. I didn't know they would still be able to tell. They never noticed anything before,"

Adora tells her. Catra swallows, her gaze darting away as she shakes her head.

"It isn't your fault. I should have noticed. The whole apartment just smells like us, but- that is on me, not you," Catra tells her, shrugging and looking a touch *dif ied*. "How did Bow and Glimmer react?" she asks, a clear deflection. Adora takes it, though. As long as Catra isn't upset. It is a personal thing to have broadcast, especially to their friends who won't let them forget it.

"Mostly my name, in various degrees of disappointment. I had to tell them about our arrangement to get them to accept I wasn't taking advantage of you and it wasn't going to ruin our friendship or anything," Adora tells her in a bold-faced lie. That *is* pretty much all they said, but ignoring anything that brought up her being in love with Catra or their conviction that Catra feels the same. Catra blinks, twitching her ears and looking away quickly as she blushes.

"Nice of them to be worried, I guess. I'll brace myself for Glimmer being insufferable next time we see her," Catra says. She is clearly flustered, and Adora would *really* like to know her thoughts right now, but she worries about making her uncomfortable.

"You'll also probably get angry texts from Glimmer. She was a bit too aghast to register it at the time, but eventually she is going to remember that was my first time and start demanding if you treated me right," Adora tells her. Catra snorts, tucking her face into Adora's neck.

"And what's the answer I should give her to that question?" Catra asks. Adora blinks at the wall across from her.

"Are you fishing for compliments now?" she teases, reaching up to gently tug on Catra's ear. She does it very carefully, because she wants to be an asshole, yeah, but not an *ab e*. She never wants to hurt Catra. Catra doesn't respond except to flick her ear away. Adora frowns at the top of her head, leaning down to press a kiss to the base of Catra's ear.

"It was good, Catra. You took care of me," she assures, because apparently Catra needs to hear it. Against her neck, Catra lets out a soft breath. Adora thinks back to what Catra told her last night and decides to take a risk. "I'm glad it was you, Catra. I trust you," she tells her. She really wants to kiss Catra's other ear, but she worries doing that now will drive the statement exactly into the territory she wants to avoid, even if it is true.

In her arms, Catra trills in delight at the trust she is placing in her.

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Catra growls to herself as she is forced to pull on her own dress shirt and pants, with only Adora's cardigan and scarf to carry her scent with her throughout the day.

Here is the thing: Catra loves her job, she really does. Getting her paralegal diploma alongside her degree was a *bitch* there at the end, but she has a decent paycheck, and she gets to know she is helping people working at the non-profit, even if it doesn't pay as well as working for a lawyer would. Catra is grateful to Perfuma for putting in a word for her with her bosses, and if nothing else the work is a good steppingstone.

She still almost growls at the first coworker who approaches her. She doesn't, and he is just an idiot human who doesn't know any better and assumed she had been sick, but she really doesn't like being in public during her heat. She can't help but hear every single word said in the office, the lingering smell of burnt coffee doing nothing to cover up the unsafe scents of coworkers that set her on edge.

She is grateful when she gets to her desk, boxing herself off in the space to catch up on her work. It goes pretty well, although her nosy human and fae coworkers keep popping over to check on her, blind

noses totally unaware everyone else can smell why she didn't come in on her. Not that anyone asks why she didn't come in – it just isn't polite, workplace protections aside – but she can tell they are checking on her to see if she is doing okay now.

It is sweet, but it is also making her *les* okay. At lunch, she decides to take a measure she had really been hoping to avoid. She gathers her papers and work tablet and retreats to Perfuma's office. Perfuma has an office with a door, even if she tries to keep it open. Perfuma might not have Catra's hearing, but despite her unofficial open-door policy, she still gets overwhelmed by the noise of the office sometimes and closes it. No one should really look twice at it being closed for a day.

Whatever. She left a note on her desk telling people where to find her, Perfuma is still out getting lunch with her girlfriend, and Catra is free to sprawl across the top of her row of filing cabinets to work. It is narrow, but she can still sprawl more than if she was in one of the guest chairs across from Perfuma's desk, and the added height helps to calm her, letting her survey the territory around her and see she is safe, even if her body is a little reluctant to believe it.

Perfuma stares at her when she returns to her office, but Catra ignores her, continuing to put together the annotations her boss asked her for. After a moment of blinking in the doorway, Perfuma sweeps into her office, thankfully closing the door behind her, but she does turn on the light when she does so, which makes Catra flinch a bit.

Bright light is on the list along with any sound and most smells. The list is titled *[illegible] eek*. Perfuma has human vision, though, and her office window doesn't provide a lot of light, especially with Catra draped across the cabinets in front of it.

"W as anyone bothering you, Catra?" Perfuma asks diplomatically as she sits at her desk and begins to pull up her computer. Catra has to suppress a growl under her breath.

"Not with anything but their scents," she returns, glaring at her tablet. She could have made it just fine out there, but she would really rather hunker down if it is an option. By five is when her heat usually starts calming down, so hopefully by tomorrow or the next she will feel back to normal.

Perfuma hums an acknowledgement and sets about her own work. For a while, it is silent. Catra finishes her annotations, and she stares down at her tablet after she uploads them, reluctant to open up her next project.

"*Apparently* Adora still smelled like sex when she went into work. Her entire workplace was gossiping about her and her *mystery cat*," Catra says, begrudgingly, because Perfuma has been waiting for her to say something ever since she found her in here. Catra really just doesn't want to deal with the sounds and smell of the office at large, but, well – she has kind of been going crazy ever since last night.

"And how did Adora react to that?" Perfuma asks, not turning from where she is looking at her computer. She has Facebook pulled up. Catra narrows her eyes at Perfuma's back for a long moment. She can't tell if the casualness is making this easier or infuriating her. Frustrated, she growls and rolls onto her back to glare up at the ceiling.

"I don't *get* her. I thought I did, I thought I knew her better than anyone else, but we have sex and she is *totally cagey about it*, and then the next day she is telling me she is glad I was her first because she *thinks*," Catra complains, seething glare fixed on the ceiling tiles. Perfuma finally turns in her chair, but Catra is glaring at the ceiling now and not looking at her.

"Correct me if I'm wrong, but isn't that the exact excuse you gave *her* after your first time together?" Perfuma asks.

Catra's tail thuds heavily on the top of the filing cabinets.

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Catra gets off work before Adora gets out of her classes. As Adora rides a bus over to her evening shift, she texts Catra to ask her how work went. She frowns when she reads *f ine* because it is immediately followed by *I dont f eel like going to the office* , which kind of contradicts that first statement. Hanging out in Perfuma's office was the main way Catra got through going into work during her heat last time, but it still wasnt the most pleasant time.

Adora texts her whenever she gets a moment during her shift, and she is grateful she doesnt run into Bow . He wasnt supposed to have a shift today, but considering Glimmer drove over just to yell at her, she wouldnt put it past Bow to just show up anyway to make her talk about *f eelings* It is a relief that she can hurry straight home, texting Catra as she goes so she has plenty of warning. She still walked in on her with the warning last time, but Adora is kind of missing her right now, so she doesnt think it would be that *bad* to have a repeat now anyway, even though Catra rarely needs help by this point in her heat.

When she walks in the front door, Catra is waiting for her on the couch. She doesnt leap up and launch herself into Adora' s arms this time, but she does trill the moment their eyes meet and reach out to her with grabby hands. Adora smiles, dumping her bag against the wall as she locks the door and then crossing to the couch in long strides. Catra reaches up for her happily, and Adora notices she is flushed as she bends down and picks Catra up. Catra immediately sets to rubbing along her neck.

"Bed?" she asks, hopeful and a touch anxious. Adora hikes her grip up and turns them towards her bedroom.

"Of course," she returns, nudging the door open and depositing Catra on the bed. "I'll be right back," she promises her before she retreats to her closet, pulling off her dirty uniform and exchanging it

for a pair of bike shorts and a new sports bra that *doesn't* smell like she has been sweating in it all day. Then again, Catra might like that. Adora has never asked what part of her scent it is exactly that calms Catra so much. She kind of doubts it is the sweaty part though.

Adora returns to the bed to find Catra laying on her back, watching her through lidded eyes as she absently kneads against the comforter, her cheeks still flushed. Cautiously, Adora lays out on her side next to Catra, propping her head up on her hand. Catra doesn't give any instructions or make any demands – though her tone of voice in the living room gave Adora an *inkling* – so Adora decides to make a move she knows is safe.

She reaches over with her free hand, rucking Catra's shirt up to her ribcage so she can pet down the soft fur of her stomach. Catra releases a gentle sigh, wriggling a little back into the sheets as her eyes flutter closed.

"How was work?" she asks, her words reverberating a little. Adora blinks at her, trying to come up with any thoughts that aren't *Catra* and *fat* and *sex*.

"Good. Worst injury needed a Hello Kitty band-aid. Which I didn't supply, by the way, I have real band aids. I didn't run into Bow," Adora tells her, cautiously working her petting a bit lower on Catra's stomach. She doesn't want to suggest or encourage anything, not while Catra is still in heat, but Catra fur is so *soft* where it gets thicker below her navel. Adora has buried her face there to relax after a rough day. The touch doesn't have to be inappropriate.

Catra's hips immediately twitch. Adora stills her hand, awaiting direction. She is *not* going to be the one to initiate making a move while Catra is in heat. Not that she would ever dream of trying anything on a normal day, Catra wouldn't want her to, but if she *is* going to touch Catra, it has to be her idea. Adora is not fucking around with this, not with Catra. After a moment, Catra huffs.

"Do you want to do what we did on Saturday again?" Catra asks, in a bit of a rush, her cheeks flushed. Her eyes are still closed. Adora feels herself draw in a breath and carefully resumes her stroking.

"Can you look me in the eye when you ask? I need to see it's okay," Adora tells her. Catra's flush doesn't get any better, but she flutters her eyes open again and makes eye contact. Her gaze is intense as it holds Adora's, but it is *open*, vulnerable and pleading.

"I want to have sex again. I tried to take care of it myself but I couldn't, not without you here. I would be fine with you just holding me though, if that is what you're comfortable with," Catra tells her, eyes searching. Catra seems open, honest and sincere. Adora feels her mouth go dry and swallows reflexively.

"I'm okay with it. How do you want me?" she asks, shifting her hand on Catra's stomach to grip her hip. At the words, Catra's eyes flutter shut, but she is already reaching for her to give her the answer.

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After a day of being on edge at the office, Catra can finally relax once she gets home, but she can't *let go*. She gets off in Adora's bed, but it barely seems to loosen to the coil in her stomach. Maybe because the coil isn't pure desire. It is stress and worry too, and she needs Adora to release that. Her scent, her touch, her arms around her.

Catra should just ask Adora to hold her through it like normal. They agreed to that *years* ago, after all, and this isn't really about getting off, rather feeling safe. Perfuma's words are getting in her head, though. It is either a dawning realization or insidious poison. Either way, she has already decided what she is going to ask for before Adora gets home. The fact that Adora *agrees*, that Catra can smell

her desire once she asks, helps to ease Catra a little bit as she pulls Adora over her.

Maybe she is just a bit too hazy from her heat to notice it usually - likely, her own desire overpowers it - but she is almost certain she has never felt desire coming off Adora like this before. She props up on her forearms above Catra, maintaining eye contact as she slides her thigh between Catra's own. She is already starting to get that almost reverent look in her eyes as Catra arches her hips to meet her, feeling her entire body relax at the contact.

Catra props her leg up, like Adora had done for her on Saturday, sliding her thigh between Adora's own. She wants Adora on top this time, even if Catra was still going to be the one leading them and setting their rhythm. She wants that blanket of security above her, protecting her, letting her body relax after a day in public. She also just really needs to look Adora in the eyes while they do this. She needs to know.

Adora bites her lip, her cheeks flushing as she shifts her hips down until they are both lined up together, legs pressing but not moving, not yet. Adora shifts one of her arms and Catra is surprised to find her turning her hand so she can tangle it in Catra's hair even as she stays propped up.

"Is like this okay?" Adora asks, her tone cautious. Catra swallows, nodding and feeling the slight tug on her roots. Experimentally, Adora flexes her hips down. Catra swears she is doing the body roll she taught her as choreography, damn but fuck if it doesnt do things to her to feel it like this. Catra decides to throw overanalyzing out the window for the moment and reaches up, grabbing Adora's hips so she can pull them down to meet her as she begins to move herself.

They both gasp out in unison, eyes still locked on each other as they move, taking a few moments to sync up before they find their rhythm, and then Catra is throwing her head back and moaning as she finally feels the tension in her body start to release. She still

doesn't break eye contact, looking up at Adora through her lashes now as she rolls her hips.

Adora looks totally awestruck, her gaze darting across Catra's face, landing on her parted lips as she pants out soft moans, but mostly staying stuck on Catra's eyes, holding her gaze. Adora seems open, utterly unguarded, and though Adora is honest *always*, she looks *raw* above Catra. Maybe she is just one of those people who kind of falls in love when they fuck due to the euphoria spike. That *fades*.

Catra's body feels alive, her blood rushing through her as she grinds down on Adora, meeting her every movement with hungry moans. Not that *Adora* is silent either. Adora moans softly, gasping out quiet syllables approaching curses occasionally. All Catra wants her to say is her name. Catra has said it *so many times* when she came while Adora held her. That first time, she moaned it all the way through. If Adora doesn't say her name, it will be the proof she needs to finally dismiss Perfuma's words.

And she doesn't. She moans and shudders as she works herself down to meet Catra, and Catra cries out and moans *her name* as she rocks up to meet her, but aside from causing Adora to whine and stutter her hips, she doesn't get a response to that. The heat is flooding through her, overtaking her, and she should be relieved that release is finally coming, but she isn't *done* yet.

"Adora, please," she manages to whine out, her eyelids fluttering, but still maintaining eye contact. She can't stop herself from saying it, even though she can't ask for what she really wants. Even if Adora would give it to her, it wouldn't mean anything if it came from prompting. Adora's gaze is all awe-tinged desperation.

"What do you need, Catra?" Adora asks her, and *by* the answer is *nothing*, because the raw desire in Adora's ragged voice is enough to have her mewling and clenching down on air as she desperately rolls her hips to meet the liquid fire burning her from the inside out. The utter *reverence* and hunger with which Adora watches her as she shakes apart only fuels the flames running beneath her fur.

She comes moaning Adora's name. It is *almost* loud enough that she misses the soft gasp of *"Catra"* before Adora is joining her.

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Adora did her best to be quiet. She cant stop herself from moaning completely, but she wanted to drink in every pant of *Adora* from Catra's lips, greedy for the way she whined and moaned her name. She knows Catra can be totally silent if she wants to – she has come with nothing but unsteady breathing in Adora's arms enough times to prove that – but Catra doesnt bite down on a single one of her needy sounds and Adora wants to commit each to memory.

She shudders and gasps herself as she comes, feeling her arms tense on the bed, but she manages to stay upright. Catra keeps her thigh up until Adora stops shaking, and then she goes *limp* beneath her, tugging on Adora's hips to pull her down to lay over her. Catra chuckles as Adora mutters vague obscenities into her fur, aftershocks rolling through her.

For a while, they just lay together, breathing heavily and coming back to themselves. Adora nuzzles into Catra's neck, absently running her hands along her sides and humming as she traces the stripes on her ribs. Catra is a little boneless beneath her, but Adora doesnt blame her, not when she just went a full day without getting off during her heat, on top of having to go in public.

Eventually there's a soft *rip* above her and Catra's purr stutters out as she rouses. She didnt pass out, nowhere close, they were just both *content* afterwards and she slipped into something approaching sleep. Adora props herself up on her forearms again as Catra stretches her body out beneath her, limbs shaking a little.

"Mm, thanks," Catra hums, her eyes still closed. Her body is utterly relaxed, face peaceful. Adora doesn't know what possesses her to do so, but she reaches one hand out and strokes along Catra's cheek. Catra shudders beneath her, her eyes fluttering open to peer at Adora with a burning intensity. Adora swallows and quickly finishes the attention with a scratch under Catra's jaw, something she likes and that isn't at all weird for Adora to do.

"No problem. I mean, obviously I enjoy it too. You don't have to thank me," Adora kind of scrambles, her brain not totally functioning. Catra's gaze is not *accusatory*, but it is burning. It concerns Adora. Until the cheek stroke, she thought she was good. She held herself back, she didn't spill out her undying love for Catra despite how she *wanted* to when she was trembling beneath her and moaning her name.

Catra just watches her with narrowed eyes for a moment. Adora decides her best option at this point is *def lection*.

"I'm really thirsty, and it's about dinner time. Want to move to the kitchen? I'll cook," Adora offers. Catra's brows draw together, something clouding her gaze for a moment, but after a few seconds of hesitation she nods. Adora forces herself to not let out an audible sigh of relief.

They take turns in the bathroom, neither of them acknowledging *why* they need to clean themselves up, but Adora is pretty sure that is the wettest she has ever been in her life, and she may have chosen the bike shorts for strategic reasons, but they don't hide a lot of sins after the fact. She ends up pulling on a pair of sweatpants instead, though she doesn't bother with a shirt still. It isn't the first time she has cooked in her sports bra.

Catra disappears into her own room for once to retrieve a new pair of boxers, and then she perches on the kitchen counter and watches Adora as she moves between the fridge and the stove, settling on skillet chicken as an easy meal for them both. They don't have much in the apartment that Catra can't eat, but Adora has a few sugary

things that would have Catra curled in a ball on the floor if she were to eat them, on top of a few breakfast foods too high in grain for a magicat. Adora has long become accustomed to eating a low-grain diet so they can easily share meals and save money on groceries, but she can never quite kick sugar.

Adora can feel Catra's eyes on her constantly as she cooks, though her perch is to Adora's back as she stands over the stove. That was probably intentional. Catra tends to track all her movement around a room when she is in heat, but this feels different. Adora doesn't know if she is imagining the tenseness, or if she actually has reason to be worried. Adora sighs, flipping over the chicken breasts and putting down the spatula. She turns to Catra to find her quickly turning her head away, staring determinedly at the apartment wall. Right. So Catra doesn't want to talk about it, whatever it is. Adora has a feeling she doesn't want to either, but she has time before the chicken will need attention again.

She crosses the few feet in their tiny kitchen to Catra's counter, watching the fur on her shoulders fluff up a little as Adora leans against the counter beside her crossed legs. Adora reaches for her, wrapping her arms around her waist and pulling her closer to hug her. If this is just heat moodiness, contact usually helps. It doesn't make Catra relax, though. Adora frowns, instantly releasing her and backing away. Catra winces a little when she does so, flicking her gaze to Adora for a brief moment before looking back to the wall. After a moment, she clears her throat.

"Are you going?" Catra asks, softly. Adora feels her brow wrinkle in confusion. Catra just tilts her head forward, and Adora realizes she wants her to follow her line of sight. She frowns, but turns around and squints at the calendar they have hanging on the wall. *Oh*, right. Adora draws in a sharp breath, looking at the blue circle drawn on this Tuesday, no label written within it. She sighs, turning away from Catra and the calendar, crossing back over to the stove. Her sudden tenseness makes sense now.

"Probably not. I dont know I can handle it," Adora tells her, shrugging as she picks up the spatula again. She really doesnt think she can. It has been almost two months since her last visit. She hasnt gone since the weekend of her twenty third birthday and she always goes on the anniversary, if only to calm her fears about it becoming a repeat of the anniversary the year she turned fifteen should she not show up, but without Catra she just *cant*. Behind her, Catra is silent for a long moment.

"I'll go with you, Adora. Even if it was the first day of my heat, I wouldnt make you miss it," Catra tells her. Adora draws in a sharp breath, blinking rapidly as she stares down at the chicken that really doesnt need her attention right now. She is *not* going to cry. She decided a long time ago not to cry about this anymore.

But she isnt really crying over *this*, she is crying because of Catra. Slowly, Adora puts the spatula back down and turns to face Catra. She crosses the kitchen in quick strides, reaching for Catra again and tugging her precariously close to the edge of the counter as she buries her face in against her shoulder.

"*Thank you*, Catra. I dont- I cant go without you," she manages, her voice thick with emotion. Catra wraps her arms tight around Adora's back.

"I know," she returns softly. The tears come, bidden or not.

One side of the chicken ends up being a little burnt, but Catra doesnt mention it.

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Mixed signals have always been Adora M.O. when it comes to her feelings, but Catra doesnt know what to think anymore. She looks at

her with such reverence, touches her with soft care, and then she is clearing her throat and ushering them out of bed like she doesnt want to keep touching her. There is a way too-hopeful part of Catra's brain that says *maybe she does* , maybe the whole reason she stops is to keep from going too far, and Catra hates herself for it. She thought she killed those thoughts junior year of college.

But Catra cant get the breathless awe with which Adora said her name out of her head, and it only fuels her useless hope. She watches Adora's back as she cooks, trying to gear herself up to say something, but then Adora turns to her and she *cant* . She scrambles for any distraction, and is grateful when her eyes fall on the calendar.

It is something they have to talk about, anyway. It is something heavy enough to warrant her hesitance that Adora has definitely picked up on. She still means every word she says. She would never make Adora go the trip alone, and she wouldnt make her miss it either. She only does it a few times a year anyway. Catra's not-quite annual, shifting heat schedule has led to it unfortunately lining up this year, but she isnt leaving Adora to this.

Yes, she tends to stay in the apartment when her heat hits, and being around someone she feels so conflicted towards while going through it is going to suck, but she would hate knowing she forced Adora to miss the trip more. She is really grateful Adora agreed to sex tonight, if only because it seems to take the edge off more, and hopefully she will still be coasting on that high tomorrow night.

Work at least goes better on Tuesday. After being with Adora again, her libido is calmed, and on day five her senses are starting to ease off, even if being in public is still a grating experience. She gets home before Adora and gets off, burying herself in their sheets, just to take the edge of anxiety off. She spends thirty minutes debating what the wear, because she usually wears her suits for this, but she also thinks she needs Adora's clothes this time to get through it.

She settles for a black pair of Adora's skinny jeans that are just plain jeans on her. She finds one of Adora's nicer shirts, a simple red

blouse, and then covers it with one of Adora's cardigans. She isn't in her full lawyer power suit, but she could pass for business casual, and it will have to be close enough. Adora breaks into a broad smile when she comes home and sees Catra already dressed in her clothes.

"It isn't even that cold," Adora teases as she crowds Catra against the wall beside the front door. Catra growls to her and marks under her jaw. She knows her tail is waving, giving away her utter delight that Adora is home again, but Adora just giggles, bracing her arms on the wall and letting Catra rub her face along her neck and collar bones.

And then Adora drops her hands and slips them beneath the hem of her shirt. Catra's heart *jumps* for the half second before Adora puts her hands, cold from the chill of outside, directly on her stomach. Catra squeaks and *arches*, trying to squirm away and suddenly realizing why Adora crowded her instead of letting Catra pin her to the nearest surface with her marks like she *normally* does when Adora comes home during her heat.

After a few moments of torturous teasing - Catra hissing, snarling, and squeaking the whole time - Adora finally withdraws her hands and presses a totally unapologetic apology kiss to the base of each of her ears as Catra tries to catch her breath, back still plastered to the wall.

"I'm going to get changed and use the bathroom, but then I'll be ready to go if you don't need anything first," Adora tells her, pulling back to peer down at her, an edge of uncertainty in her eyes. It is almost like she expects Catra to back out, but Catra would never promise her this and then back away. She shakes her head.

"I'm fine. Go get dressed. Put on something nice. Compensate for me," Catra tells her. Adora smiles, the corner of her mouth quirking up and her eyes crinkling, before leaning in to wrap Catra in a tight hug.

"Will do," she agrees, before finally pulling back.

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Catra has had both her hands buried in her pockets, protecting them from the cold chill in the evening, but she slips one out to take Adora's hand in her own as they approach the front doors. Adora sends her a grateful smile, squeezing her hand as they step inside the lobby doors. Usually Catra handles this part for her, letting Adora brace herself, but she refuses to make Catra interact with strangers right now.

Adora approaches the front desk and takes charge of signing them in and asking if the resident of room two-thirteen is up for seeing visitors. The receptionist smiles and says he has been expecting them. Catra growls lowly, *ahem* under her breath, when the poor woman relays that information. Adora knows she is probably annoyed by Randor expecting them to come, as if they owe him the visit. It isn't like that, Adora always comes on the anniversary of her mom's death, but Catra has issues with her dad that are hard to look past. Adora has the same issues, truthfully.

"Rainbow! You came!" her dad babbles excitedly, throwing his arms into the air when they walk into his room, a blatant request for a hug. Adora squeezes Catra's hand once before dropping it and crossing the few feet to where he is settled in front of a desk. He had been drawing before the nurse led them to his room, working on his dexterity or hand strength most likely, but the coloured pencils lay forgotten as she bends down to hug him in his wheelchair.

"I try to come whenever I can," she tells him, even though they both know that by now. Her visits are erratic, but certain days she always tries to spend with him. The assisted living home is outside of the city, so the public transit route is winding, and if she has work on top

of school one of those days, she might not have the time to make it out.

"I know , I know. You have your own life and Im very proud of you for it. I just miss you," her dad agrees, smiling warmly up at her as she pulls back. Adora feels herself swallow, sending him a thin smile. It is *hard* how kind he is, and yet Adora never really got to have him in her life.

A light dawns in his eyes and he excitedly spins his wheelchair, crossing the room to his nightstand drawer and pulling it open. He fishes around inside for a moment before finding what he is looking for and tucking it into his lap. He turns back around, wheeling over to her and smiling up at her as he picks back up his trophy and holds it out to her.

"I got a new chip this week!" he says, proudly holding it out to her . Adora feels tears prick in her eyes, taking the eight-year chip from him and smiling to herself as she turns it over in her hand. Her dad's eyes soften as he watches her look at it. After a moment, he tears his gaze away from her , giving her a moment of privacy as he looks to where Catra is hung back, leaning against the door.

"It is good to see you again, Catra. Y ou have been taking care of my Rainbow?" he asks, all warmth and kindness. Adora forces her tears back as she stares down at the chip in her hand.

"Someone has to. I got a raise at work right after our last visit, so things have been a bit more comfortable. Adora is doing well in her PT courses, too," Catra tells him. Her voice is neutral. Catra doesnt hate Randor – she is just always going to be angry with him, for being so good and so kind, and yet being the reason Adora was at Shadow's. She told Adora once *you deserve a perfect life if she can get it together* .

It is not that simple, and Adora wouldnt have had a perfect life if Catra wasnt a part of it, but she never said that. Catra knows she doesnt understand this. Adora doesnt either , but she knows how it

works on an academic level, at least. The brain chemistry behind it, how it wasn't a choice he made, just the fact that he never got help was. At least not until the stroke forced him clean.

"I'm proud of you, Rainbow. I know your girl hates when I say that, but I am," Randor tells her. Adora takes a deep breath and makes eye contact again, reaching out to hand him back the chip.

"Thank you, dad. It does mean something to me," she tells him. He smiles, watery and a bit overwhelmed.

"Your mom would be proud of you, too. Not just for school. You've grown into a stunning young woman. And I know you are taking care of your girl just like she is looking after you," he tells her. Adora is *not going to cry*.

"Always," she returns.

--

Visits with Randor are always a special kind of hell, even if Adora is better for them. They make her almost cry every time, and she usually is a bit depressed afterwards, but Catra knows that it really does mean something to her when she hears her dad is proud of her, even if *he* has nothing to do with how good his daughter turned out. That was all Adora.

Catra usually hangs back during the visits, there to support Adora and cover for her in the conversation when she needs it. She always dresses up, showing Randor she is professional and *responsible* – the one thing he never was, despite his kindness and warm heart. She especially doesn't want to get near him when his scent is hitting her heart like acid, but Adora needs the support, so Catra ends up

only two feet from him with her arm around Adora's waist while he shows Adora his drawings.

He used to be very good. An architect, before the stroke lost him his legs and ruined his hands. Catra doesnt know what average artistic skill is, but she imagines this is it. Nothing hideous, but nothing good or moving either. All of them are still-lifes. Adora still praises his progress, and politely declines when he asks if she wants one.

"I dont think it would be good for me to have the reminder ," Adora tells him, voice strained, because they are at least to the point now where they can be honest about how he has fucked her up. Randor is disappointed, but he nods and accepts her words immediately, lowering the drawing he was showing her. Eventually, Adora asks if she can go talk to the nurse about his progress. Randor's mind is mostly there, but, well, parts of it are *dead*, so important stuff like this it is best to ask the staff about.

Randor nods and asks if he can have a moment alone with Catra while she goes. Adora shoots her a worried look, but this is not exactly unusual for their visits. Randor is under the mistaken impression they are together. Catra isnt sure if Adora has figured that out yet, but for the last four visits he has pulled Catra aside and asked her when she is going to ask Adora to marry her. Catra just rolls her eyes and shoos Adora on. If they get this over with, they can get home and be alone again. Adora chews on her lip as she goes, but she does still leave to find the nurse.

"I wanted to give you something," Randor tells Catra as soon as Adora is gone, wheeling back over to his end table. Catra will probably throw it away, but she doesnt tell him that. He would understand, he is well aware what a shitty father figure he was, but it isnt necessary to be cruel to the old man. He is trying now , even if it is too late for the damage done to Adora's emotional development.

Randor wheels back to her with a small cardboard box in his hand. It is small enough to fit in his palm, the kind of box you would put a collector's coin in or something. Catra frowns as she takes it from

him, pulling the lid open and immediately feeling her tail puff out when she realizes what is inside.

"You don't have to use it. I'm not asking you to, in fact. I know I don't have the right to ask anything. I'm lucky enough to still get to watch Adora grow into the woman she is now. But I want you to have it. It belongs to the family, and you are her best family. You know better than me if she would even want it," he tells her. He struggles with his words a little as he speaks, tripping up a bit, and Catra can't help but feel he has practiced this. She wouldn't be surprised if a search of his room revealed drafts of this speech.

Adora always makes drafts of emotional conversations, even if it is usually only in her head. Randor might not have had much of a hand in raising her, but he definitely passed on some things. Catra is never going to forgive him, but his actions aren't hers to forgive, and he has done his best these past few years since he got clean. She swallows and replaces the lid, hiding away the engagement ring. Reluctantly, she tucks it into her jeans pocket. She doesn't need to ask to know it belonged to Adora's mother.

"I'm not going to propose with it. She wouldn't want that reminder on her finger. But she might want to just have it one day," she tells Randor, looking him in the eye to find brimming hope and sadness there. She is not proposing *anyway*, but she told him that the first time he asked, and he had forgotten it by the next visit. She will always be upset with him, but he is trying, and so she gives him what she can. Adora wouldn't want this ring to be her ring, but Catra might feel the time is right to give it to her one day. Not now. It would only hurt now. Catra will tuck it into a deep drawer in her dresser and pretend it doesn't exist until then.

"Thank you. For this, and for looking after my Rainbow. I'm very grateful you're in her life," Randor tells her. His hands twitch like he wants to reach for her, but he doesn't. He has a scar on his arm from when Adora was fourteen that tells him to think better of that idea. Catra swallows and looks away from him.

"Yeah, well, I know how lucky I am to have her," she agrees, even though she *doesn't* have her, not the way Randor thinks she does. She is still lucky. Moments like this remind her why she stays quiet – she can't lose Adora.

Adora returns from speaking with the nurse, praising Randor for how long he is able to stand with support now, even if he can't walk and never will. She notices how twitchy Catra is and sends Randor a watery smile, saying they should really get back if they want to catch the bus. Catra is so fucking grateful. These visits are always a lot.

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Adora spends most of the trip home with her arm wrapped around Catra's shoulders, shielding her from the strangers on the bus, but also just holding her close for her own sake. When they get home, Catra disappears into her own room to change, and then emerges in *nothing* but boxers to duck into Adora's room for one of her shirts. Adora does her best not to choke on her water.

Her dad's physical handicap may be improving a bit, but apparently his mental state is declining. It isn't surprising, considering his age and health, but Adora didn't need the nurse to tell her that. The way he kept calling Catra *Glimmer girl* was obvious enough. He has called Catra that for the last few years – ever since the overdose that led to his stroke - but there was clear intent behind it today. He seems to have forgotten she and Catra *aren't* together.

As Catra emerges from her bedroom in one of her tank tops and flops on the couch, making grabby hands in her direction, Adora can't help but think back to what Glimmer said: how *would* Catra act with someone she was in love with? Adora climbs over the back of the couch to drape herself across Catra, burying her face in the soft fluff over Catra's heart and *thinking*.

She would obviously do this. Cuddle and comfort them. She has hugged and held Scorpia and Glimmer before when they have been upset though, so that isnt exclusive. She would go with them on emotional trips like this, clearly, because she is willing to do it for Adora. Adora is pretty sure she would do this for a number of their other friends, though.

She wouldnt be left alone in the room for them, though, she is pretty certain. Adora was shocked when she agreed to that. She was even more surprised when she came back and Catra seemed no worse for wear, at least not outside of the general anxiety of being in public for so long.

The problem is Catra has never been in a relationship, nor expressed any interest in changing that. Occasionally she hooks up, but she seems to be content with their life. Adora doesnt know how much of that is true and how much is her own projection, though. Maybe Catra just hasnt met someone she thinks she can trust that way. She trusts *Adora*, but she also once trusted Scorpia while feeling nothing for her.

Adora is running in the same mental circle she has been for years, truthfully. Her heart is so tired after today, she just cant think about this right now. She sighs and buries her face deeper into Catra's chest. Tomorrow, she will think about it. For now, she just wants to hold her.

Chapter End Notes

- King Randor of House Grayskull is Adora's dad from the 80s original. And yes he did name his daughter Adora Rainbow Grayskull. This man is all sunshine okay. He was a hippy back in the day.
- The fourth fic in this series will be another prequel fic, set when Adora and Catra are 14/15, and exploring the backstory with Adora's dad. Adora grew up in Shadows from a young age, but her dad had visitation rights, so she still saw him.
- Randor's assisted living is provided by the government since he

really isnt capable of living on his own. Randor legally has no family since he lost custody of Adora, and Adora couldnt af ford to support him anyway.

K*ss me

Chapter Notes

You ever have a stimming incident lads because I have.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra is going to lose her fucking mind.

She is laying on her back. Normal. In Adora's bed – also normal, at least for day seven of her heat. They have just been cuddling ever since Adora got home from work – that is normal even outside of Catra's heat. Not a daily occurrence, certainly, but not unheard of.

Adora's hand is on her nipple. Still normal. Catra is doing her best not to grit her teeth as Adora flicks her finger back and forth over her through her shirt. She is humming to herself, texting Glimmer and Bow about something that must be very distracting, because she has been absently moving her hand over Catra's nipple for three minutes now without realizing what she is doing.

Catra would tell Adora to either fuck her or stop – but she also can't say that. She is getting worked up, despite how her heat is edging past done by now, and she can't even call Adora out on it because she knows she is just absently fidgeting with her surroundings. She does it all the time, twisting and fidgeting with whatever is beneath her hands. It is how she got the thin scar on the left side of her jaw, twisting absently with Catra's tail hard when she was a kitten. Adora didn't know what she was doing, and Catra didn't know why she hurt her, so she lashed out.

Now, Catra screws her eyes shut, fighting the whimper that wants to spill out of her throat. She doesn't mind Adora' s fidgeting, just like Adora doesn't mind it when she purrs and kneads, but this is ridiculous. At least she isn't actually hurting this time, but that is a false Hail Mary, because if Adora twisted Catra wouldn't be able to

keep silent any longer, and then at least Adora would *know* . Catra does not want to call her on this, though. Adora has gotten better about it, but she has had baggage about her autism ever since Shadow banned the word in the home. She grinds her teeth to keep quiet, and Adora's hand freezes. Catra doesnt open her eyes, her tail lashing beneath her.

"I've been- touching you, havent I?" Adora says, dawning embarrassment in her voice. Catra clears her throat, willing her voice steady as she tries to fight down her flush.

"Brilliant deduction," she manages, words a little rough. Adora's hand leaves her. Catra doesnt know where it goes – her eyes are still screwed up – but her body mourns its loss even as she breathes a mental sigh of relief.

"Sorry . How long was I doing that?" she asks. She sounds apologetic, worried, and a bit ashamed.

"*Several* minutes," she tells her , forcing her jaw to unclench as she opens her eyes. She turns her head to see Adora watching her with concern from beside her on the pillow. Catra sighs, rolling her eyes. "I know you were just stimming. It's fine," she tells her . Adora doesnt look placated.

"Stop me, next time. You dont have to be *that* understanding. I never want to touch you like that on your heat," Adora tells her . Catra feels her brows drawing together, her tail thudding against the mattress uncertainly.

"You *only* touch me like that during my heat," she points out. Adora flushes, but she huffs and rolls her eyes, turning over to deposit her phone on the nightstand. It continues to buzz for attention as she rolls back over and sends Catra a cautious look.

"Only when you ask me to. I told you in that first check-in, I wont ever start it. If you need something, Im here, but I dont want to push you into something you didnt want. And I try not to actually *touch*

you. I know you can still consent, but- I don't want to take advantage of you," she says, blushing a little. Catra blinks at her , feeling herself flush even as she absently shifts her hips.

It is true that she was *fine* until Adora started touching her, and now she definitely would like Adora to pin her down. Not that Adora *told* , but – maybe she would? Not during her heat, clearly , but maybe outside of it is actually a possibility. At least from the way Adora is talking, it is something she has *thought* about, been worried about.

"Take advantage of me, huh? You're that desperate to get in my pants, Adora?" she teases, because she doesn't know how to process this or get the answers she wants through *normal conversation* . Adora blushes all the way to her ears, eyes going wide. Catra chews on the inside of her cheek, despite how her fangs make it hurt like hell.

"Listen, I'm sorry . Stop me next time. I don't want to make you uncomfortable," Adora says, not acknowledging her words. Catra tastes blood and releases the inside of her cheek. Adora is still flushed, she still looks worried and a bit scared, but she is holding Catra's gaze. They have been here before. Catra gives her an opening, any chance to say something, and Adora just *doesn't* . Even worse is when Adora gives *her* an opening, and Catra takes it, and Adora outright ignores it.

The thought makes her eyes burn. Catra turns away with a grunt, showing her back to Adora as she curls into a ball in the sheets. She isn't going to cry , but she doesn't want Adora see her trying not to, either. She doesn't know why she even *thought* about listening to Perfuma.

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Adora does her best to give Catra space on Wednesday night. She really fucked up, her subconscious driving her hand and letting her touch Catra like that. Her *nightmare* is she doesn't touch Catra on her heats. Her hands are never on Catra – at least not like that. Her stupid fidgeting had to do what her conscious wouldn't, and then Catra pulled away, *turned* away, clearly uncomfortable.

She spends most of Thursday worrying. Catra's heat is passed now, which means it is time for their check-in talk. Adora thinks they are okay – but she really worries they aren't. She doesn't really focus in her classes, distracted even as she heads to work. Work, where Bow is. He corners her in the hallway near the end of her shift.

"How's Catra?" he asks, pointedly. Adora hikes the equipment bag she is hauling up on her shoulder, sending him a pointed glare. He simply raises a brow at her. She growls to herself, and then concedes.

"Fine, I think. Our check-in talk is tonight," she tells him, finally reaching the storage closet she is supposed to be stowing gear in. Bow steps in front of her, blocking her path.

"Have you thought about what Glimmer said?" he asks. Adora narrows her eyes at him.

"Yes, I have, and I really don't know what you expect me to say," she tells him. She knows what he *wants* her to say, but the problem is she has spent the last few days overanalyzing Catra's behaviour and only come up with *inconclusive* or *inconclusive*. Granted, there had been a *lot* of inconclusives, but circumstantial evidence can't be added up to make a conviction. Adora learned that from Catra's law studies. Bow actually throws his hands in the air.

"*Adora*, she climbs into your bed at the first excuse and gives you *flying tackle hugs* while *purring* when you leave the house for a few hours. She marks you as *hers*. What more do you need?" Bow asks, exasperated. Adora shifts uncomfortably. She really regrets telling Bow about that hug, but on Wednesday he got on her about the

hooking up putting strain on their friendship, and it seemed like an easy way to prove that Catra wasn't bothered. Now he is using it against her.

"For her to say it? Look, Bow, I'm not ruining what we have for some *half*," Adora tells him, finally shouldering past him to drop the bag in the empty cubby. Bow stands in the doorway, sending her a thoroughly unimpressed look.

"Adora, she is basically your *wife* at this point. She lives with you, she does everything with you, and she got her paralegal diploma to *provide for you* while you went to school. Now you're having sex. Has it ever occurred to you maybe she is just as scared? It's about *Catra*. Emotions aren't her thing," Bow tells her. Adora tries to suppress the shudder that runs through her at hearing Catra being referred to as hers like that, but she does a terrible job. Bow groans when he spots it. She is so fucked.

She is not completely oblivious. Adora is *aware* of all this. She always kind of was, but especially since Glimmer brought it up on Sunday. What she can't justify is potentially ruining what they already have for some *half* at more. What would the *point* even be? Kisses and sex outside of her heat? Adora is not going to let her selfish desires ruin the best relationship she has ever had. Catra is her rock and she would never forgive herself if she pushed her away with her lust.

It is inconclusive, what Catra feels, but she has never said anything to Adora. She is happy as is. Adora *wants*, she always has even if she didn't understand it for years, but the fear of losing Catra is too great to take the chance on *inconclusive*. Bow cuts into her thought process, her spiraling series of justifications for maintaining and never saying a thing despite how the word *love* is damn-near always on the tip of her tongue.

"Does she say your name when you're having sex?" he asks, far too personal, but he sounds like he is just about at the end of his patience. Adora swallows as she straightens from stowing the bag.

"Yes. She always has," she admits. The noise Bow makes belongs in a nature documentary, overlaid with some tundra animal *dying*. Adora looks over her shoulder finally, making eye contact with Bow, who is actually *glaring* at her at this point.

"Adora, that's her *saying it*," he points out. Adora swallows.

Okay, maybe she mislabeled some *inconclusive* evidence, she can admit that.

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Catra comes home from work and reluctantly goes back to her own room to change. Really, her heats aren't a full seven days, but they definitely affect her *mom* for that long, so what Adora doesn't know won't hurt her. It is day eight – she has no excuse to crawl into Adora's bed, or her clothes, or between her legs anymore. Not for another nine months, anyway.

She comforts herself with the fact that *repeats* are probably on the table. It works until she flinches at the reminder that now it is time for them to *talk* about it. She collapses in her own bed, untouched for a straight week now and *cold*, and tries to move the blankets around until she is comfortable. Adora lets her pile up her blankets into a cozy nest in her normally-neat bed, and her own mattress just can't compare.

Having separate rooms seemed like a great idea when Catra was trying to outrun her lust, and the area the apartment was located in was its real selling point, but now that Catra is curled up in her room alone, no traces of Adora in the space, she *hates* it. This is her first heat with them having separate bedrooms – they have only been in this apartment a few months, after all – and the isolation she feels afterwards is only amplified by the empty room.

Catra is so fucking frustrated. She always feels so adrift after her heat passes, getting accustomed to having so much of Adora and then just *losing* it overnight. She burrows into her blankets, completely disappearing beneath them and curling into a ball, tucking them around her to try to create something approaching the comfort and safety of Adora's bed.

It *is* safe, dark and secure, but it doesn't make her feel that same peace that truthfully has never had a damn thing to do with safety. Her mind wanders to the engagement ring tucked behind her dresser, fucking *mocking* her. Not that Catra would give Adora that ring in a million years, but the thought was sweet. No, it is more that the ring stands for what she will never have. Adora doesn't want her – or if she does, she doesn't *love* her. Catra keeps laying herself bare before Adora, and every time Adora hurries to find her a robe to cover up with.

Adora comes home eventually. She is late, but not late enough to warrant a text. Bus delayed, maybe. She goes straight to her room, and Catra listens to Adora moving around inside, dropping her bag and opening her dresser. The sounds of Adora remaking her bed with the military corners Shadow drilled into them young is especially heartbreaking. Catra turns her head to bury her nose into her own mattress. It doesn't help – all it smells like is lingering traces of her own scent and dust.

Adora leaves her room, heading down the hall, and Catra listens to the sound of the shower turning on. Adora usually waits until after her evening run, but maybe she got grimy at work. If she had to run out for a field injury, it would make sense. Maybe she is just stalling. She avoided Catra last night after she made the joke about Adora wanting into her pants. Catra got the fucking message: no, she doesn't.

She wallows in her self-loathing as she listens to Adora emerge from the shower, water dripping as she makes her way back down the hall. After getting dressed, she settles in at her desk. Yeah, that will

last long. Catra is fucking *eternal* right now, and she may hate lying to Adora, but sometimes it is all she has.

Actually, it lasts longer than Catra expected it to. After two minutes, Adora seems to realize their shared laptop isn't at her desk. The door to the bedroom next door opens, and then there is a cautious knock at her door.

"Entraptra has it. Blue screen," she calls from inside her blanket fort. It isn't in the slightest bit true, Catra just hid it. She wanted Adora to come over. She wanted Adora to not be able to work, so she had no reason *not* to have movie night, and hopefully cuddle on the couch. Fuck, she is desperate. Adora hesitates outside her door.

"Can I come in?" she asks. She really shouldn't, or she will see Catra's depressed huddle, but also all Catra wants is for Adora to be near her right now. "I'm coming in," Adora decides after a minute of Catra's silence. Catra shoves her purr down in her chest as Adora eases the door open. Light pours in from the doorway, but it doesn't really penetrate the blanket cocoon Catra has made. Adora crosses the room, crouching by the edge of the bed. They would be at eye-level, if Catra's face wasn't tucked inside the comforter.

"I know Entrapta is on a business trip right now to repair a remote server. You want to try again?" Adora asks, entirely unaccusing in tone despite her words. She reaches out, petting along Catra's body through the blanket. Catra forces her throat not to close in fear. Adora doesn't sound *mad*. She should be. Catra would be pissed if Adora pulled this shit, but she has always been a hypocrite.

"It's under the bed," she mutters, reluctant, waiting for Adora to bend the rest of the way to retrieve it and *leave*. Adora sighs, her hands leaving Catra. Catra bites down on her disappointment. She knew it was coming. After a moment, there is the slight scrape of the laptop being pulled out, and a thud as it is set aside.

"Did I do something, Catra?" Adora asks, tone level. Being the *adult* one about this. Catra sighs into the bed. Adora has never

done *anything* but be an unreasonably good friend to her. It is Catra's fault for still wanting more from her. She made her move last night – her fucking *hundredth* one. Adora made it clear she doesn't want her. Catra needs to stop wallowing and get over it. She should be grateful for how much of Adora she *does* get.

"No. Hormone crash. You're fine," she tells her. Adora is silent for a long moment, and then she is straightening. Catra feels Adora's hands on her before she can really register it, and then she and her entire blanket cocoon are being lifted into the air. She doesn't *mean* to whine, but she does as Adora carries her out the door and into her room, depositing her on the perfectly-made bed.

A moment later, Adora crawls in it with her, wrapping around her in a tight hug as she tugs on the edge of the blanket to reveal Catra's face. Catra glares at her with no heat as the light comes flooding in again, squinting a little and twitching her ears back. Adora smiles softly at her as she pulls her closer.

"There she is," she murmurs, almost to herself, and it shouldn't make Catra trill, but the soft affection in the words still does as she nuzzles beneath Adora's chin. Adora just holds her close and lets Catra mark her. "What do you need, Catra?" she asks, softly. She shouldn't be this kind to her. Catra is being a moody asshole. Catra sighs.

"I wanted attention," she mutters, reluctant. There, Adora knows and she can tell Catra to fuck off and stop being a baby now. Except she doesn't. She hums thoughtfully, curling one arm up to scratch at her scalp. Catra melts beneath her touch, purring and kneading into the side of her blanket cocoon. Adora never does this once her heat has passed, but she presses a kiss to the base of her ear. It is just the surprise that causes Catra to release a soft sound, pressing closer, hungry for more.

Her heat has never made her hungry for Adora – that is all her. It is an excuse, a reason for her neediness to be allowed because for a week it isn't her fault. Adora hums softly and shifts to kiss the other ear. Catra knows she shouldn't be purring this hard, but this is

exactly what she wanted. Adora holding her, giving Catra her undivided attention, *kissing* her.

Well, not in *that* way, but before Perfuma poisoned her mind, she had been well aware that Adora was never going to love her like that. Now that her heat hormones have left her, sense is returning, and she knows better than to indulge in Perfuma's words.

"Just ask me, next time. I have homework I have to do, but I can lay here for a little while, and you can stay in the bed if you want," Adora tells her, brushing a hand over her ears before scratching at their base. Catra melts beneath the touch, despite the reluctant grumble the words illicit from her. Adora laughs lightly.

"And we need to have our check-in. Are you up for that tonight, or do you want to wait?" Adora asks her. Catra sighs. No, it might actually make her feel better to do it now. If she can get confirmation that in nine months she gets to have all this again, it might soothe her that the loss is only temporary.

"Let's do it now. And then cuddles," Catra tells her, marking along the side of Adora's neck. Adora nods into the top of her head.

"How are you feeling?" she asks, because that is how she always starts.

"A little sad, without the hormones. Tired," Catra tells her. Mostly true. It isn't the *bonds* leaving that are making her curl up in her blanket, but Adora doesn't need to know that. Adora runs a hand soothingly down her back over the blanket cloak.

"Did it still help to have me hold you through it? Do you want me to keep doing that?" she asks, like she always does, despite the answer always being-

"Yes," she tells her, holding her breath and waiting for the new elephant in the room.

"Okay . And the grinding? W as that okay, and do you want to do that again next time?" Adora asks her , voice perfectly even, because the questions she is asking mean *nothing* to her, at least nothing close to what they mean to Catra.

"Y eah, it helped a shit ton. I googled it. The body can tell when it is actual sex. That is why you smelled so obvious this time," Catra rambles out, feeling her claws flex nervously into the blanket. Adora hums.

"It changes the type of pheromones your body produces for the rest of your heat, apparently. I tried to use my medical training for evil and I barely understood it. Pheromones aren't my specialty ," Adora agrees, still petting down her back. Catra snorts, nuzzling in closer .

"No, you're a muscles girl, I know ," she agrees. She feels more relaxed, knowing Adora is okay with all this, even if her academic approach to setting the rules disappoints her. She knows why she does it this way, she *appreciates* Adora trying to make sure she doesn't feel pressured, but part of her is always hoping for Adora to be just as needy about this as she is. Not that she wants Adora to beg to fuck her again- Actually, no, she definitely wants that, why did she even try to delude herself otherwise.

"And the other stuff ? My bed and my clothes? Those are still making it easier?" she asks, pressing a kiss against Catra' s ears again. Catra purrs softly in her arms.

"Y eah, everything was good. I've told you before, I'll tell you if something makes me uncomfortable, even if it is only in retrospect," Catra tells her. Adora had been really nervous around her first two heats, but they've worked out a system, and Catra promising to always correct her has let Adora relax when it comes to this. Adora hesitates.

"I'm sorry about last night," she murmurs. Catra swallows, closing her eyes as she tucks her face into Adora's neck. The message is obvious. She didn't say anything then. She didn't *want* to. She

wanted Adora to keep going, to push up her shirt and do it directly, maybe mirror the movement with her tongue on the other side-

"That wasnt making me *uncomfortable*, Adora, it was turning me on, and I know you couldnt help it," Catra tells her. It also had nothing to do with her heat – the same rules dont apply. Adora is silent for another moment.

"Having Scorpia and Perfuma visit while I was out helped?" she asks. Catra sighs. She is tired of the questions, even if the number Adora is asking to make sure she is comfortable makes her chest warm.

"Yeah. They arent you, but they at least let my body accept I wasnt in constant danger. Are you out of questions, now?" Catra asks. Adora is silent for a moment. Catra can feel nerves rolling off of her. She stills in Adora's arms, *terrified* of what is coming.

A gentle hand slides up from her back, cradling her jaw and encouraging her up and back until she is face-to-face with Adora, blinking at blue eyes brimming with anxiety.

"Just one more," she promises, her voice soft. Her eyes flick down before meeting Catra's gaze again. "Can I kiss you?" she asks.

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Adora feels like her heart has stopped. She doesnt know why she thought that was a good idea. She planned it the whole way home, Bow's words echoing around in her head. She paced in the apartment lobby for ten minutes just to work her courage up. Catra clearly missing her, *needing* her, had given her the resolve to go through with it, but she was a fucking idiot to say anything. Catra is just staring at her, wide-eyed, and the panic in her throat is

threatening to suffocate her as it builds. Catra looks like she might be in *sh*ock.

"I'm sorry," Adora rushes out, already pushing herself back, giving Catra *spa*ce. She is a fucking idiot for listening to Bow. This is the same moron who didn't get with Glimmer until he was twenty-three, despite them both knowing they were in love and having talked about it. They still haven't even had sex yet. All she can do is hope is that Catra doesn't ask her to move out or something.

She is on the verge of tears as she pulls away, but then she hears *te*aring, and there is a clawed hand wrapping around her back. She blinks down in surprise at where Catra sliced straight through her comforter to keep Adora from pulling away. Swallowing, she looks up to make eye contact with Catra. Catra's eyes are still just as wide, her ears pinned back as she stares at Adora.

"Adora, did you mean that?" she asks, her voice a little hoarse. Adora sq*uee*zes her eyes shut, nodding. She kind of wishes she had led with this, so she didn't remind Catra of everything she has done that is a violation in retrospect beforehand. She had needed the time to get her courage up, but she was an idiot to even say anything at all.

"Okay," Catra says, voice a bit strained. Adora keeps her eyes screwed shut, waiting for the rest. Waiting for Catra to finish processing and probably call her a bitch and throw her out of her own bed. After a moment, she realiz*e*s more isn't coming. She blinks her eyes open, finding Catra laying in her bed a little stiffly but doing her best to throw her a cautious smile.

O, that kind of *ha*y. Adora draws in a sharp breath.

"Are you sure?" she asks, despite how she is already shuf fling closer. Catra lets out a shaking breath, but she nods. Adora leans closer, and then hesitates. Catra doesn't pull back. Her heart is thudding in her throat right now, but cautiously, Adora closes the remaining gap between them, pressing a soft kiss against Catra's

lips as her eyes flutter closed. She has never done this before, and she doesn't know what she is doing aside from what she has learned from observation. Every one of her nerve endings feels alight, buzzing with anticipation.

The slide of lips is cautious and experimental, but Catra moves in turn, tilting her head a little to get a better angle as she takes control, kissing Adora long and slow, with *experience* that makes Adora shudder as she reaches for Catra again, wrapping her arms around her and tugging her closer. Catra follows – she *does* more than follows, pressing forward until she has Adora laying on her back, Catra straddling over her hips, kissing her with determined purpose.

It feels fucking *amazing*. Adora knows they have already had sex - she knows she wasn't even that *bad* during it, especially not the second time - but this feels monumental in a whole new way, waking her body from her fingertips to her toes as she tugs Catra closer, tangling one hand in Catra's hair and tugging on it the way she had wanted to when she had Catra laid out beneath her on Monday.

She never thought she could *have* this. Adora has thought about sex with Catra – alright, *a lot* – but that seemed actually possible, even before it happened. She had fantasized about Catra asking her to give her a bit more *help* on her next heat and finally getting to touch her, but she still didn't think she would get to *kiss* her. Kisses were for lovers, girlfriends and boyfriends, people who feel more than lust for each other. She hardly let herself consider such a thing outside of frantically-changing fantasies as she worked herself over, alone in her bed with her thoughts drifting to Catra against her better judgement.

There is more tearing, and she feels fabric shreds falling onto her stomach, but she certainly doesn't give a shit about Catra slicing her comforter open all the way to reach for her, one hand on Adora's waist and the other slipping behind the back of her neck, both of them tugging her up and closer until their bodies are pressed together. Adora releases a soft gasp against Catra's lips, and Catra deepens the kiss, licking into her mouth and moaning softly.

It is everything Adora never let herself picture. She shakes a little in Catra's arms, trying to follow her lead as best she can, although she feels clumsy against her. Her inexperience is not bothering Catra, at least. The hunger in her kisses is just growing stronger, stoking a fire in Adora that she normally tries to keep in ashes. When Catra's hands start wandering, Adora feels a spike of panic make its way through the endorphins already hitting her body. She makes a desperate grab for Catra's hands, taking her wrists in her hands and feeling Catra freeze against her.

"Catra, wait. This isn't- This isn't about *sex* for me," Adora gasps out. Catra's lips are still against hers, even if they are not moving now. She draws in a sharp breath, waiting, as Catra remains totally still above her. She thought she was clear, if only because if it *was* about sex she would have said that upfront, but Adora is now realizing that Catra was definitely kissing the blonde in the club bathroom and this might *mean something* to her.

"Then what is it about, Adora?" Catra asks, her voice low and a touch *sedate*. Her lips brush against Adora's with every word. It is definitely suggestive, at least. Adora feels her throat flex, but Catra wouldn't fuck with her like this. She would pull away, she would tell her no, but she would not lead her on.

"I love you," she breathes, squeezing her eyes shut and waiting. She is either about to get fucked through the mattress or thrown out of her own apartment.

The answer is fucked through the mattress.

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Catra hears the words. She registers them, processes them, understands them, and then she surges forward, growling

possessively as she claims Adora's mouth for her own. Because it *is* hers, it always has been, even if Adora wanted to be stupid and oblivious for twenty years there. Adora gasps against her, whining a soft *Catra* that has her purring as she licks into Adora's mouth, her hands trailing down her body again. Adora makes no protests this time, arching up into her touch and squirming beneath her.

Catra has never gotten to touch her before. It was always Adora holding her, hands in respectful locations, or the *grinding* while they both just clung on for dear life. Now, Catra trails her hands down her body and actually gets to *feel*. Even through her shirt, it feels like a revelation to have Adora beneath her, feeling her chest expand and contract with her uneven breathing and tracing the curve of her breasts over her sports bra. Catra needs to ask, because Adora said *this is a big deal*, but she also *really* wants to touch her. She still refuses to pull away from the kiss.

"I fucking love you, Adora. I always have. Is this okay? I don't want to rush you, I've just wanted you for so long- I want to *touch* you," Catra manages to mumble between kisses, her own voice rough with desire and the subtle roll of her purr as she forces her hands to still on either side of Adora's ribcage, not wanting to go further than the skimming of her hands without permission. *Adora always asks*. Catra is not going to fuck this up.

She smells salt on the air and *panics*, pulling back to blink down at Adora. Adora is looking up at her with soft eyes, open affection on her face even as tears roll down her cheeks. She shakes her head, seemingly incapable of speech, and reaches up to hook her arms around Catra and pull her back down until they are chest-to-chest again.

"It's definitely okay. I've just been so afraid of going too far and losing you. I love you so much, Catra. I've always wanted you, *loved* you, even if I didn't understand it for a long time," Adora promises her, looking up at her with wide, nervous eyes. Catra releases a shaking breath, looking down at the *hero* she fell in love with at age five. *Focus*. Adora didn't know she felt for her – Adora doesn't

know how to let herself be looked after for ten minutes, much less *healthy* ones. They can thank Shadow and Randor for that.

And they can thank Randor for Adora being afraid of losing her – losing the only person she has left, the only person she has always had. The only one who promised her she would be there and *was*. Catra was never going to leave her, not for a second, not even if she didn't feel the same and *Adora* was the one sneaking into her bed to secretly get off while she was at work. Anyone else, yes, she would have thrown their ass on the street – but not Adora. Never Adora.

"You're mine," Catra reminds, her words shaking, nudging forward against Adora's cheek, *desperate* to get to taste her again, but she needs to get the response that always follows that, always has since they were fifteen, truly alone together in the system knowing Randor was never coming for them now. They planned the rest of their lives together, pamphlets on nursing, law school, and legal aid careers scattered between them.

"Yours. Always," Adora returns, emotion quaking through her words as she lets her eyes flutter closed and she tilts her chin up for another kiss. Catra doesn't give it to her, shifting the half inch back it takes to delay her, but no further. She never wants to *not* be kissing Adora again, but she isn't done yet.

"And I am yours. I always was, Adora," she adds, her voice soft. She tilts forward to seal their lips in a kiss as Adora lets out a quiet sound laced with emotion. The hand Adora has in her hair tightens, pulling her head back. Catra blinks down at Adora, her cheeks flushed as Adora stares up at her in *awe*.

"Say it again," she begs, her voice bordering on disbelieving. Catra swallows, blinking down at her dumbstricken- girlfriend? Not just *mine* anymore, certainly. She can't believe Adora doesn't *know*. Catra has clung to her for years, marked her and claimed her in every way. Of course Adora *has her*. Catra shifts back, settling over Adora's hips. She reaches one hand down to play at the edge of

Adora's shirt, sending her a slow smirk as Adora continues to stare at her with wide eyes.

"Can I take this off?" she asks her, feeling her smirk grow wider when confusion clouds Adora's gaze along with desire. She hesitates for a moment, and Catra feels *kind of* bad for making her wait when she has asked so *nicely*, but she also has a plan. After a moment, Adora nods, and Catra purrs to herself when Adora sits up so she can lift the shirt over her shoulders.

"Catra?" Adora asks softly, clearly unsure, when the shirt is discarded and they are merely inches apart, Adora shirtless and breathing heavy. Catra is still purring, leaning forward to kiss softly at the curve of Adora's jaw. When Adora's jaw started filling out, sometimes Catra would have to fist her hands in her sheets to resist the urge to run her fingers along it as they laid side by side at night. Now, she traces it with her lips and *tongue* as Adora shudders and gasps beneath her.

Adora's hands come up to grab her waist, to hold her close but also, Catra suspects, to hold Adora sitting *up*. Catra's hands slip up Adora's sides. She tucks her fingertips under the edge of her sports bra, stroking the skin indented by the elastic just beneath the band. She trails her path of kisses – which still has Adora *shuddering* against her – up to Adora's ear so she can breathe into it.

"Patience, Adora. Ill give you what you want. Ive wanted to take care of you like you do for me for so *long*. Can I take this off too?" she asks, feeling nerves alight throughout her body. She wants her hands on Adora's naked body *badly*, and she has promised to give Adora what she has asked, but she also knows she is denying her right now.

Luckily, Adora doesnt seem to mind. She gasps, nodding eagerly. Catra chuckles lightly to herself and curls her fingers properly beneath the band to tug it up at the same time as she nips at Adora's ear lobe. She gets a surprised sound followed be a giggle, which proves infectious as Catra leans back to free Adora from the bra as

well. Alright, ears dont do it for her . Scorpia had *loved* that, but everyone is different.

Giggling with a topless Adora is *amazing* . Catra feels a bit dumbstruck as she places her hands on Adora's shoulders and encourages her to lean back. Adora does, still flushed and giggling occasionally, although Catra can tell some of them are nervous now. Catra cant blame her , not when *no one* but Catra has her seen her exposed like this.

Catra has also never seen her *delight* , a playful but *nervous* expression on her face, eyes affectionate and hopeful, breathing still a little unsteady and her nipples hard as her breasts rise and fall with every breath. Catra knows her tail is lashing behind her as she stares, a little *entranced* at having all of Adora's skin laid out beneath her like this and knowing she could finally touch if her hands would just *move* already.

"Like what you see?" Adora teases. Catra flushes, looking up to find Adora watching her with all that nervous affection still, but there is a smug smirk spreading over her face now. Catra sends her a half-hearted glare, but it is cut by how awestruck she knows her expression must be. Catra has a *plan* , gorgeous tits be damned, and she intends to follow through with it.

She leans forward, kissing Adora once, firm and purposeful, Adora groans softly into the kiss, starting to strain forward to meet her when she pulls away, but Catra flexes her hands on Adora's shoulders and holds her still. Adora has the core strength to sit up regardless, but she does not even pretend to fight Catra's obvious instructions.

Catra shifts down her body a little, pressing a soft kiss to the side of Adora neck and earning a quiet gasp. Catra smirks to herself, setting a slow path of gentle kisses down the length of Adora's neck, occasionally flicking her tongue out to catch a trace of Adora's taste as she goes. Adora gasps, her breathing heavy the entire time as Catra works her way across the expanse of skin before her.

"Yours," Catra tells her, a whispered promise against her collarbone before she nips lightly there. Adora twitches a little beneath her, letting out a sharp breath Catra drinks in *greedily* as she nuzzles her way down Adora's sternum, kissing and licking occasionally as she goes. "Always yours," Catra promises again as she presses a kiss to the underside of Adora's breast. She is going to spend *time* on them, but later. For now, she nuzzles into her decadently soft skin there only once before kissing her way down to her ribcage.

"Catra," Adora whines, her voice high and thin. Her hands thread through Catra's hair again, tugging insistently, but Catra is going *nowhere*. She presses a kiss – firmer than the rest, because Catra knows Adora is ticklish here and featherlight would likely not result in the effect she is going for – against the lines of her ribs as they shift with her heavy breaths.

Catra has smelled Adora's desire before, but never like this. She has been able to tell Adora was wet when she was grinding onto her, but this is *need* and *hunger* dripping from every pore. It is soft too, *longing* and long-buried love leaving her quivering beneath Catra's lips as she follows the lines of her muscles down to her stomach.

"Yours. And you are mine. *My girl*. You know that, Adora? You're mine," Catra tells her, shifting so she can look up at Adora as she presses another kiss just above her navel. She is actually mostly looking at Adora's tits, the mountain too tall to surmount to see most of her face from this angle, but that is a good view too. Adora whimpers softly.

"Your girl," she agrees, her voice a bit *broken* with emotion, but Catra smiles to herself, all pleased affection as she continues her path of kisses. She knows it is *good*, even if she is overwhelming Adora right now. Catra needs this, needs Adora to know that this is a two-way street, both of them looking after each other. It has been one-sided for far too long.

Catra nuzzles against her hip, pressing a kiss against the jut of it and then tracing it with her tongue. Adora *whines*, her stomach tensing

beneath her as she shifts a little and tugs once more on Catra's hair. Catra groans, letting herself be tugged and led up. Adora still has tear trails on her face, but she isn't actually crying anymore. Her eyes are wide, reverent, and her cheeks are dusted with a high flush as she pulls Catra in for another kiss.

Beneath her, Adora untenses as they meet, slow and languid. Catra lets Adora lead them – clumsily , but she kind of *likes* it anyway – for a long moment before she pulls back to make eye contact with her brimming gaze. Adora looks so flushed, gaze a bit dazed despite the light in her eyes.

"Do you need a break?" Catra asks her , softly. Adora blinks at her for a moment and then nods hastily, an edge of nerves in her gaze. Catra carefully lowers her body to fully drape herself over Adora and watches her relax beneath her, one of Adora's hands sliding down to wrap around her back and hold them together.

"I *like* that, I just- I love you and it's so much," Adora tells her in a hushed whisper. Catra shivers, pressing a little closer and not bothering to fight her rising purr. She presses a gentle kiss to Adora's cheek and gets a soft noise of appreciation. Catra sets to kissing her way along the tear trail there, which has Adora's breath shaking again as salt graces Catra's lips, but her body is still relaxed as she holds Catra close.

"Do you want to lay on our sides? So I'm not on top of you. I don't want to overwhelm you," Catra asks when she pulls back, reaching out to stroke Adora's cheek softly and give her a hopefully-encouraging smile. Adora's eyes flutter open, and she looks at Catra with blatant affection.

"I think that would be good," she agrees, a small smile spreading on her lips. Catra tips them over so they are lying in a mirror of their earlier position, lying on their sides facing each other, only now her comforter is discarded, ripped in half somewhere in the bed with them, and Adora is topless. Topless against her. Which is- distracting, okay, she is *grateful* .

She is definitely flushing, and Adora *definitely* notices because she smirks now, pressing a little closer until their fronts are plastered together, Catra hyperaware of the swell of Adora's bare breasts against her thin cotton shirt. She swallows, looking away and pinning her ears back as her tail lashes behind her.

"What do you want, Adora? I'm- I have *been* ready for anything you wanted for years, but I know this is new for you. What are you comfortable with?" she asks her, because Adora said it *isn't about sex*, but she clearly wants, and she agreed to *take a break*, but now she is looking at Catra with smug hunger. Catra just needs direction. She needs to know what she can do without fucking this up.

Adora strokes her cheek with one hand. Catra lets her eyes flutter closed, nuzzling into the touch and releasing a soft sigh she knows Adora can feel. They are pressed tightly together - Catra doesn't want there to be space between them, and from the desire pouring off Adora she suspects she does not want there to be any either.

"You said you've wanted to touch. Can I do that too? I just – Catra, I am *ready*, I just need to go a little slow. I want you, I want you so *bad*, I just don't want to rush past getting to touch and kiss you," Adora tells her. Catra feels a fond smile twitching up the side of her mouth, opening her eyes to look fondly at the idiot across from her – *her* idiot.

"You can touch me however you like, Adora. Whether that means wandering hands or two knuckles deep. However slow you want to do this is fine by me," Catra promises her. Adora's eyes glaze over, the fingers of her hand cupping Catra's cheek *twitching*.

"I want to touch you, first. We'll see about *knuckles deep* after that," she responds, her voice a bit hoarse. Catra smirks.

"Then *touch*, Adora," she tells her.

Chapter End Notes

I posted on tumblr and some people noticed in the comments, but I had to add another chapter to the count. The smut got too long and I had to give it its own chapter. Oops. More of these idiots incoming.

Lovers

Chapter Notes

> (NSFW Twitter link) Hey there's fanart by em of the second smut scene!It killed me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

At first they just kiss, Adora's hands roaming cautiously over Catra's body through her clothes. Everything they have done, and Adora still needs steps to do this without feeling overwhelmed, but *fuck* does she want this. She thinks she could easily have sex with Catra if she *hadn't* said I love you back, but the emotion is kind of overwhelming her right now, and she needs the time exploring just to let it settle despite how badly she wants Catra naked against her.

Catra understands. She prompts her to set rules, tells her *it's okay* when Adora's hands hover nervously at the hem of her shirt. Having Catra shirtless against her – being shirtless herself and feeling Catra's fur on her skin – is a whole new revelation to process, and though Catra smirks at her, she seems to understand. She lays back and lets Adora roam her hands, feeling, petting, stroking, *seeing*, just becoming acquainted with the body she knows in every way except *this* one.

Adora presses kisses along the stripes on Catra's arms and sides. She nuzzles her face into the soft expanse of Catra's stomach, something she has done before with permission but always felt *held back* during, and breathes in her friend-

Adora pulls back, blinking down at Catra. Catra is flushed, her tail swaying back and forth. Her fur is fluffed up a little, but Adora is *pretty sure* it is in a good way, considering the fond look in her eyes and the smile playing at her lips.

"Are we girlfriends?" Adora asks her , hands on Catra's hips and thumbs stroking through her fur absently. Catra rolls her eyes, but her smile only grows.

"Yes, Adora, we're girlfriends," Catra agrees, open affection in her face, eyes, *voice* even. Adora feels a bit breathless on the receiving end of it, even though they have long been affectionate. This is a different level, another layer to the love they always gave each other.

"I love you," she says for probably the sixth time tonight, but she feels *so much* and it is the closest way she knows to vocalize it, even if it is nowhere near *enough* . Catra purrs, her eyes fluttering a little but not quite closing as she gazes up at Adora.

"I love you too. Since we were *five* , Adora," Catra tells her , and then smirks as Adora *stares* down at her in shock. That- explains a lot, actually. All the things she dismissed as things Catra has always done, but she *always* loved her apparently.

Adora is feeling lightheaded again, so she ducks her face down and buries it in the soft fur of Catra's stomach. Catra's purr rolls against her, a soothing rhythm combined with the softness that grounds her. After a few moments, Adora is feeling mostly normal again. Catra's hands fall into her hair, gently stroking through it in the motion that has always calmed her. Adora lets out a soft sigh against her *girlfriend*

"Feeling better?" Catra questions, softly . She knows how Adora can get overwhelmed and it can lead to panic — when she was younger , it could even lead to fits of anger, although Shadow managed to train those out of her, even if she couldn't visibly hurt her like she could the kids who were orphans and had no one to *notice* .

Adora nods wordlessly into Catra's stomach. She shifts up a little, rubbing her face into Catra's fur as she goes, to press a kiss to the stripes along Catra's ribs.

"I'm an idiot. I didn't realize until your first heat. I think I always felt it, but I just didn't *understand* ," Adora tells her , a bit too embarrassed to look up and see Catra's reaction to that. She doesn't want Catra to think she isn't invested in this too, that she feels any less than she does, just because she didn't *know* . Catra is silent for a moment and then she *laughs* , a light, derisive chuckle.

"That explains so much, actually . I had tried to drop so many hints already, by then I had kind of given up on you ever feeling the same," Catra tells her . Adora pulls back, blinking down at Catra in shock again. Catra rolls her eyes, but she is still smiling. "Adora, when most people tell you *you're mine* , it isn't platonic," she points out. Adora flushes.

"I thought you were just trying to comfort me. You weren't good with feelings then. I thought it was the only way you knew how to say you were sticking with me," she mumbles. Catra sends her an exasperated look, and then tugs harshly on her hair, dragging her into a hungry, open-mouthed kiss.

"You fucking-" she cuts off to lick into Adora's mouth, "-*idiot* . Fuck, I love you so much," she grumbles into the kiss. Adora lets out a shaky laugh that cuts off in a sudden moan when Catra nips harshly at her bottom lip. Catra kisses with hunger, with *purpose* , mapping the shape of her and *claiming* her as she goes. Adora moans softly, eagerly pressing in to let herself be taken, wanting to drink in every moment so she can return the gesture later. They pull apart for breath, and Catra looks up at her with a gaze darkened with hunger .

"Can I lay you out, Adora? You've taken care of me so many times. I want to return the favour, but only if you're ready for it," Catra asks, her gaze searching despite the desire dripping in it. Adora swallows. She needed to slow down to process, but she *has* processed, at least everything she thinks she can get to tonight. She wants to finally *have* Catra, but if Catra wants her, she is happy to give herself over.

Besides, it might be best for Catra to go first, to show her how this is done with a partner so she can better take care of Catra. She has a fantasy, a fantasy she has had ever since Catra's first heat, but she has had that fantasy for three years and it can wait a bit longer, especially in the face of Catra against her.

"I'm ready ," Adora promises her , pressing in for another kiss. Catra groans softly, her arms wrapping around Adora as she kisses her back. Without their lips ever parting, Catra rolls them back onto their sides, and then tips them so Adora is on her back again, Catra straddling her hips. Adora sighs a little into the kiss, letting her body relax into the sheets. Catra pulls back, making eye contact again as her hands slide to Adora's ribs, a promise of more in her eager grip.

"Okay?" Catra questions, checking in now they are repositioned. Adora feels a burst of warmth in her chest, a smile spreading across her face.

"Fantastic," she returns, leaning up to kiss Catra again. It is a mirror of their exchange the first time they had sex, and she knows Catra picks up on it from the soft groan she gives as she kisses back and *f inally* slides her hands to properly touch her.

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Catra kisses a line down Adora's neck. She intends to carry a trail of kisses all the way down to her chest and finally get to kiss and *bite* the tits that have been taunting her since puberty, but Adora lets out a soft gasp when Catra kisses the side of her neck. Catra purrs in satisfaction, settling for skimming her hands along Adora's body as she lavishes attention to Adora's neck, biting and sucking dark marks into her pale skin.

Adora likes this, and she deserves it *all*, not just some desperate fuck, even if it feels like the tension has been building for a fucking decade. Adora cries out when Catra bites her, gasping her name and moaning for *more* as she marks her, leaving traces that even humans will be able to see to know Adora is *hers*. Now there is a thought.

"*Mine*," Catra growls out, before nipping at her bare collarbones. Adora finally knows what she really means by that, what she *always* meant by that. Adora is not totally wrong about how Catra wanted to comfort her that they were in this together and not knowing how to say it in a more vulnerable way, but if she wasn't so possessive she *probably* could have found one. Adora moans, her legs shifting beneath her.

"Yours. Always," Adora agrees. Catra's purr is *loud* as she bends to mark the top of Adora's tits, first with her cheek and then with her *teeth*. Adora keens, head throwing back as she tangles her hands in Catra's hair, tugging and pulling as she scatters three dark marks across her breasts. Catra glances up, finding Adora's expression hazy with lust and her skin flushed, but she notices Catra looking up to her and smiles softly. "I'm good. I like this," she assures, shifting her hands in Catra's hair to stroke encouragingly before a bit of a wicked smile crosses her face and she *tugs*.

Catra mewls, her eyes falling closed and a shiver running through her body. Adora *knows* how sensitive her scalp is, she knows from the last two times they did this how much Catra likes it when she pulls her hair, and she is using that knowledge *against* her. Catra can't help the purr rolling through her as she sets back to kissing her way across Adora's breasts, assured now that Adora is comfortable. She smirks for a moment to herself before licking roughly at one of Adora's nipples and sucking it into her mouth.

Adora doesn't *scream*, but they are definitely going to get a complaint from their neighbours. That is fine. If Catra gets her way, they won't need an apartment with two bedrooms much longer. She sets to sucking against Adora's chest, laving her tongue over her –

only occasionally, so the roughness of her tongue isnt *on* – and coaxing more of those needy noises and beautiful moans of her name out of Adora.

Adora was *holding back* last time. Now, every other breath is a needy noise, and every third sound is her name. She is *dripping*, the scent of her desire filling the room despite the fact that she still has sweatpants on. Catra is going to *take* her, and the thought only makes her own desire build higher. She releases Adora's chest with a slick *pop*, grinning up at where Adora is panting desperately, her chest rising and falling, staring at her with that same awestruck expression.

"How do you feel about *naked*?" Catra asks, feeling her grin slant into a smirk that flashes her fangs as Adora's flush spills down her chest. Catra's hands are already on her waistband, but she waits as Adora gazes down at her. If she needs Catra to slow down more she will be happy to do so, but considering the noises Adora is already releasing, she thinks she is ready for *more*.

"*Please*, Catra," Adora manages. Catra doesnt need to be told twice, kissing her way down the planes of Adora's cut abdomen as she tugs the pants down and discards them. She leaves Adora her trunks, though she doesnt expect that to last *long*, but she still wants to give her a few moments to adjust and ease into it. It also gives her a second chance to stop them if she starts feeling overwhelmed again.

Actually, Catra decides, now is a good time for a *pause*. She shifts up, kissing Adora softly, slowly, tangling her hands in Adora's hair. Adora lets out a gentle sigh beneath her as Catra sets to stroking her hands through Adora's hair, keeping the kiss languid and giving Adora a few moments for her breathing to even again. Adora lets out a soft sound beneath her, nudging her nose against her cheek, and Catra pulls back to make eye contact with her again.

"I love you," Adora breathes, because it has been a few minutes since she has said it, and apparently that is too long. Catra still feels

a slight shiver, surging forward to kiss her hungrily in response. Adora hums happily into the kiss beneath her, apparently satisfied with that response. After Catra has finished drinking Adora in again, she leans back to look Adora in the eye as she shifts down her body.

"I love you too," she returns, before ducking down to kiss along the lines of her stomach. Adora releases a soft breath, shuddering beneath her and arching her back as Catra's trail of kisses passes her navel. The smell of Adora's desire is *strong*, making Catra's mouth water, but despite the tricks she knows with her tongue, her tongue is also a lot, and she is trying to take care of Adora slowly and gently. It is best she holds off until she knows what Adora can take. She settles back on her haunches, her hands on Adora's hips and thumbs rubbing purposeful circles as she admires the trail of marks she has left across Adora's body.

"Can I take these off?" Catra asks, finally trailing her gaze up to make eye contact again. Adora's eyes are dark with desire. Adora nods, her breath stuttering a little too much for words apparently. Catra hooks her fingers into the edge of Adora's waistband, pulling her trunks down and feeling her tail puff up a little as it sways in anticipation behind her. Adora pulls her knees up – to slip out of her underwear as Catra pulls them away, but it means she is not only naked, but on *display*, and Catra tosses her underwear aside to grab Adora's knees, holding them in place with her legs spread as she *looks*.

Adora flushes even more, clearly embarrassed, her chest still rising and falling rapidly. She also *looks*, and a fresh wave of desire hits the air. She is nervous – first times always have a bit of anxiety, Catra has learned – but this is clearly turning her on too, so Catra lets herself *admire* as she slides her hands down along Adora's thighs.

Catra has seen Adora naked. They lived in a one-room dorm, and then in a one-bedroom apartment. Before they aged out of the home, they lived in a room together with two other girls, the two of them sleeping in the same bed together. Catra has *seen* Adora naked –

but she has never seen her naked like this, from this angle, flushed with desire, finally allowed to look and *touch*. It is a mirror of her revelation with Adora's tits earlier in the night, but this is *another level*.

She slides her hands up, finally touching Adora, her fingers exploratory as she strokes over her, almost absently rubbing her thumb against her clit as she traces the shape of her with her fingertips. Adora gasps out, her head falling back and her muscles *jumping* even from the gentle stimulation. Her hips twitch down as Catra strokes her fingers between Adora's entrance and clit, still rubbing over her clit with her thumb even as she makes a mess of her slick. Actually, Adora made that mess herself. She is absolutely dripping, so *ready* for Catra.

Adora has held her and treated her with gentle care more times than she can count. She has made Catra feel safe and - though she thought she was deluding herself at the time - *loved* as she helped her work herself over. Catra just wants Adora to feel what she felt as Adora gazed down at her with reverence earlier in the week.

She leans forward to capture Adora's mouth again as she trails her other hand up, fingertips stroking over her entrance. She sets one hand to work over her clit, keeping her motions steady as she licks into Adora's mouth and drinks in the way her breath stutters against her every time her fingers stroke over her entrance. She slides them back and forth, pressing a little harder each time, causing Adora to twitch her hips down, wanting more.

"Catra, please, I *want* you," Adora begs, a desperate mumble into the kiss, but it is all Catra needs. She nips at Adora's bottom lip and slides forward, pressing in with a single finger, testing her. She doesn't know why she bothered, because Adora's stuttering breath aside, she is so open one finger is hardly *anything* to her. Catra purrs in satisfaction as she pulls back and presses in with two fingers this time.

Adora whimpers against her mouth, kissing her messily, but Catra certainly doesn't *care*. She has time to teach her how to do it right, and she doubts she was that skilled either the first time Scorpia fucked her. She pumps her fingers in and out, putting more of her focus into her movements over Adora's clit than fucking her. She has overheard – alright, *perfectly* – Adora enough times to know she doesn't always use her fingers like this, defaulting to just touching herself. The sounds through the wall have been responsible for Catra hurriedly stuffing a hand down her pants and biting down on her bottom lip more than once.

She bites down on *Adora's* bottom lip now, sucking it into her mouth before tugging on it carefully. She times it with a firm thrust and gets a desperate cry of *Catra!* as Adora jerks her hips down. Catra wants *more* of those noises. She tucks down into Adora's neck, biting at the side of it so Adora's mouth is free to pant and moan – both of which she is doing now as she twitches her hips. Her skin is radiating heat and desire, her chest pressing up into Catra's with each ragged breath.

"*Catra*," she gasps, sounding almost *lost*, completely overtaken with desire. Catra groans, her eyes fluttering closed as her hips twitch to grind down into the mattress. The comforter is damp beneath her, her own desire soaking through her lounge pants. Catra pulls her head back just far enough to take in the sight of Adora, needing to *see* what she is doing to her, but not wanting to lose the press of their bodies together.

"What do you like, Adora? Let me take care of you," Catra asks, her voice a little ragged, but can you *blame* her. Adora twitches down onto her fingers, hips stuttering as she lets out a soft gasp. She locks eyes with Catra, her gaze pleading.

"Harder, on my clit. Please. I need it. I'm so close," she tells her. Catra feels herself drawing in a sharp breath, throwing a little of the *cat* with which she touched her out the window. Adora instantly gasps, drawing a ragged moan of "*Catra*," from her lips as her

breath stutters. Catra thinks she must look like Adora did that first time: awestruck.

"Fuck, I love you," Catra murmurs, not really thinking about the words, just transfixed by the beautiful woman before her, totally splayed out for her, *hers*. Adora lets out a soft gasp, her eyes screwing up for a moment before she twitches down on Catra's fingers. Her eyes fly open to lock gazes with Catra again, and Catra gets to watch dark desire cloud Adora's vision as her muscles tense, clenching down on Catra's fingers.

"*Catra*," is the only intelligible noise in Adora's panting and needy noises as she squirms beneath her, working her body towards *release*. It overtakes her with a sharp cry, her body finally going limp as her walls roll down on Catra's fingers in waves. Adora is flushed, desire pouring off her as beads of sweat run down her burning skin. She collapses back against the bed, panting, her eyes still locked on Catra's, even if her vision is hazy and unfocused.

Catra feels utterly speechless. Her own walls twitch on nothing, and she feels her hips roll without telling them to, because *fuck* does she want to come now, seeing *that*. She has heard Adora, but only ever when she is trying to be quiet, and the way she said her name is going to be imprinted on the inside of her ribcage for the rest of her life, her heart brushing against the word with every pounding beat.

Adora is looking up at her through her lashes, a satisfied smile slowly spreading over her face. Catra realizes she is still *inside her*, feeling the occasional aftershock twitching down onto her fingers. The sight of Adora totally paralyzed her. She swallows, carefully sliding her fingers out. Adora lets out a soft breath, but she makes no complaints as Catra reaches out to brace herself above Adora. She is fucking *shaking*.

"Hey, Catra?" Adora hums. Her smile is only growing more satisfied. Catra might be having heart palpitations. Her chest is certainly doing *something* erratic and unhealthy right now.

"Yeah," she responds, breathless like *she* is the one who just got fucked within an inch of her life – at least, that is what the noise complaint from their neighbour will probably claim happened.

"I love you," she says, smile a taunting mix of smug and *dopey*, utterly happy as she makes Catra twitch onto nothing and *whine*. Adora seems pleased with herself, her smile in no way fading as she reaches her hands up to tangle in Catra's hair.

"Can I fuck you now? I've kind of been thinking about it for *awhile*," Adora says, still grinning. Catra moans and doesn't even bother fighting the twitch of her hips as she eagerly nods.

Adora flips them, still grinning.

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"Lay like we usually do," Adora instructs Catra, after she has kissed her way along damn-near every inch of her body, discarding the remainders of Catra's clothes so it is just the two of them, their bodies pressed together. Catra raises a brow at her, but she lays out beside Adora and turns with her back to her, tail twitching and a light chuckle rolling through her as she shows Adora the stripes on her back and her *fantastic* ass.

"How long have you been thinking about this?" Catra asks, because she already *knows* without even having to ask that this is a fantasy of Adora's. Adora hums as she props herself up on one elbow and runs her free hand down Catra's side.

"Ever since your first heat. It always started with you needing *more* than just your hand," Adora tells her, pressing a kiss to the nape of Catra's neck as her hips twitch in response. Adora's hand *squeezes* lightly at Catra's hip before sliding down to her thigh, stroking along

the stripes there as Adora tangles her legs with Catra's own to pull the bottom one back and spread them. Catra whimpers softly just at being repositioned, hiking her top leg up to give Adora *acces* .

"I'm touching myself in this fantasy , aren't I? While you fuck me?" Catra questions, her voice rough and lower body twitching a little. Adora groans, burying her face in Catra's hair as she nods against her. *Yes*, that is the exact fantasy she has been having for years. Catra just *knew* her. Catra purrs in satisfaction. "Mm, I've had this one too," she admits, her voice low , and then Catra's hands are moving, one clutching at the sheets while the other slips down, trailing along her own body.

Adora whines softly as she watches Catra trace her fingertips through the trail of thicker fur leading between her legs. Catra is still purring, satisfied, as she finally touches herself. This is Adora's first time *watching.* She always kept her gaze fixed on Catra's face, or the wall if she had an extraordinary level of self-control that day. She feels her own thighs clench as she cautiously traces her hand down from Catra's stripes to her inner thigh.

Catra releases a soft breath approaching a whimper and twitches her hips down into her hand. Adora swallows, her mouth *dry* as she finally slides her fingers to trace over Catra. Catra whines now, her own hand pulling back to rest in her fur trail while Adora traces her fingers over her, giving Adora access to just touch and *feel*

Catra is absolutely *aching* , clearly worked up from all the build-up and the idea alone, letting out soft, needy breathes as Adora runs her fingers cautiously over her folds. Catra's eyes are closed, her cheeks flushed and lips parted to let out a quiet moan as Adora rubs gently over her clit. She *does* want to fulfill her fantasy, but she also just wants to touch her first. Catra twitches her hips down into the touch, her breathing ragged. Adora can *tell* her, she is so worked up at this point, her slick already coating her fingers.

After a few moments of gentle attention to her clit, Adora runs her fingers down, stroking her fingers along her entrance carefully. Catra

breaks with a growl, her own hand sliding back to rub at her clit with purposeful motions as she rolls her hips down onto Adora's fingers. If Adora was properly lined up, she doesn't doubt she would slip in. Catra is so wet she has to be *open* for her.

"*Adora*, please, fuck me. I want you," Catra demands, her voice rough and *ragged*. Adora groans, burying her face in Catra's hair again, letting the arm she was propping herself up with truck in so she can be pressed against Catra, centering herself with the soft press of her body as she finally presses in with two fingers, slow and cautious. Catra *is* open, velvet heat surrounding her fingers as she finally gets to have her like she always wanted.

"*Yes*," Catra breathes, rolling her hips as she picks up the pace of her hand. Adora pulls back, despite how she just wants to feel Catra's liquid heat around her *forever*, pressing in again to slowly thrust into her, keeping the pace gentle as she feels her out. Catra groans, throwing her head back a little. "Fuck, Adora, your fingers are so *big*, I-" Catra cuts off with a moan on the next thrust. The sound sends a wave of heat through Adora, causing her to shudder and pick up the pace again.

Adora's hands are only a little bigger than Catra's – they used to compare hand sizes back when they were in football together – but her fingers are also *longer*. From the way Catra pants out the words, Adora can guess that Catra has *thought* about this fact before.

"How do you like it?" Adora breathes, because now all she needs is to fuck Catra, to finger her until she is bringing her over into satisfaction. Catra groans, twisting her shoulder back a bit to nudge into the side of Adora's cheek even as she keeps her hips in place so Adora can thrust into her.

"*Harder*. Show me your strength, Adora. I can take it," Catra tells her. Adora swallows. She can *definitely* do that. She picks up the pace of her thrusts, the angle new and a bit awkward, but fuck does she have *leverage* into. She wants Catra like this so badly, drinking in her needy moans as presses into her hard, trying to keep her

movements even. Catra's hand falls away from touching herself at one point, reaching back to cling at Adora while she desperately rolls her hips down, keening as she rides her fingers.

Eventually it is too much and Catra's hand is falling to touch herself again, gasping, *sobbing* moans slipping from her lips, every other sound a strangled attempt at Adora's name and the rest all curses as she jerks her hips down unsteadily before her tail puffs out, her body locking, and then her walls are rolling down on Adora's fingers as she goes limp against the sheets, panting and whimpering weakly.

Adora is totally breathless, turned on and wet all over again, as she pulls her fingers out and carefully gathers Catra in her arms like she has done so many times before. This time, she cradles Catra's naked body against her, Catra purring and nuzzling into her neck as Adora repositions them.

This time, Catra doesnt thank her like it is a *favor* Adora is doing her friend. She just purrs, nuzzling into her touch.

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They go again, after Adora has cradled her close and they take a water break. Of *course* they do. Catra is not done showing Adora her *appreciation* for every time she took care of her, and Adora is turned on all over again from taking care of her. They go two more times, actually, Catra touching Adora again and then *both* of them touching each other, *maybe* racing to see who can make the other come first, but they have always been competitive like that.

(Adora loses).

Afterwards, they cradle each other close, murmuring *love you*s and sweet nothings into each other's skin. They are both *exhausted*,

between the long day and the marathon sex, but their hands still wander, skimming over each other in exploration Catra is sure will not be done for a few weeks yet.

"I'm not sleeping in my bed again," Catra mumbles into Adora's neck. She doesn't expect it to be news, but she is starting to drift off, and this is the only place she wants to sleep ever again, cradled under Adora's chin with her girlfriend's arms around her. Adora snorts, running a hand through her hair and scratching at the base of her ears.

"Well, you don't even have a comforter anymore, so I guess you don't have much of a choice," she agrees, tone teasing and smug. She has nothing to be smug about. Adora was the one panicking before Catra could even process her words.

"Kissing you was more important," Catra returns, pressing a kiss over a bruise she left on the side of Adora's neck to prove her point. Adora's breath hitches and she just nods, apparently happy to concede the point.

"What are we going to do with your room then?" Adora asks, though her voice is tired. Catra is utterly limp against her. She doesn't doubt they will fall asleep during this conversation. She snorts softly, nuzzling into the side of Adora's neck.

"Turn it into your home gym. Then maybe I can stumble out of bed in the morning without being confronted with you *half naked* with your tits bouncing," Catra tells her. She *was* totally limp, but her tail is lashing a little now just at the memory. There is a moment of silence, and then Adora draws in a breath, realization hitting her.

"*Are you reading my mind*?" she demands, her voice a little high with the revelation. Catra chuckles, marking along the side of her stupid, oblivious girlfriend's neck.

"Did you think I was actually mad about the club? You did the right thing then, given your assumptions. I just couldn't talk to you dressed

like that without *saying something* , and I needed to blow off some steam before my heat hit,"Catra tells her . She had been dreading talking about this for real once her heat was passed, but now she can actually say the *truth* , it is kind of funny.

Adora is silent beneath her. Catra pulls back to find her blinking at the ceiling while she processes. She purrs in amusement, shifting where she is draped along Adora's body a little to give her the soft slide of fur to help her focus. Adora lets out a shaking breath, looking to her with a sheepish expression as she finally comes back online after her crash.

"I justified it with you being intoxicated, but I was just jealous as hell seeing you with that other girl. I reached for the first reason to pull you apart and decided she must be taking advantage of you so I could interrupt,"Adora tells her , cheeks blazing. Catra blinks down at her, hearing her purr roll loudly between the two of them. She *didnt* find that hot, but she totally does. Adora looks nervous, probably because she *also* knows Catra shouldnt find that hot and isnt expecting her to.

Catra leans down and kisses her, long and slow. Adora's behaviour that week makes a *lot* of sense in retrospect. Avoiding her after she had girls over, not texting her so she didnt have to overhear – Catra kind of feels shit about it, now, but apparently Adora is willing to let it go from how eagerly she kisses her back despite the sleep creeping into her limbs.

Catra drops her head back to Adora's chest, going limp again and drinking in the relaxed sigh Adora gives in return.

"I love you,"Catra mutters against her skin. She is fucking *exhausted* .

Before she slips into the darkness, she hears Adora murmur it back.

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Catra is snuffling softly in her sleep. Adora is having a fucking heart attack. It isnt that Catra has never done this before – although, the *against* part is new – but she kind of wants to coo, and she *cant* because then it will wake her *girlf riend* up.

In the back of her head, somewhere, she can hear Bow calling her an idiot. In her defense, she still thinks she is *right* . Most of the things Catra does with her, *f o* her, Adora thinks she would do for a friend. They just arent friends – not *only* friends, at least, that much was obvious before even round one, much less round four. Catra is not usually this insatiable even during her heats.

She tucks her face down into Catra's hair, pressing kisses along her ears because she has always wanted to and she *can* now. She always could, but the thought doesnt bother her as she hums softly to herself and pets her hands down Catra's bare back. It may have taken them awhile, but none of it was *a dtim* . Sure, they could have been having sex, but they had everything else, and Adora is more than willing to exchange every guilt-filled time she got off thinking about Catra for having her here in her arms now.

"It' s not morning yet," Catra mumbles against her chest. Adora freez es her path of kisses, hands stilling on Catra' s back. Catra immediately growls, so she resumes the petting, even if she still pulls back to survey Catra. Catra is looking up at her through slitted eyes, piercing yellow-blue shining in the low light filtering through Adora's curtain – which in truth is not a curtain, just one of her old dresses that she threw over the empty curtain rod after the z ipper broke.

"It is, but I kind of forgot to set my alarm last night," Adora tells her . She had been a bit *dist acte d* at the time, up until they both exchanged a few mumbled words and passed out. Catra's eyes narrow further as she plasters her ears back to her head.

"It's Saturday. The day was invented for sleeping in and having afternoon sex," she returns. Adora feels herself blush, which Catra *definitely* notices. Her ears twitch, perking up, and her tail begins to sway behind her as her eyes finally open all the way.

"I still have work. And I have to run down to the drugstore to buy concealer first, too," Adora points out, sliding one hand up to tousle through Catra's hair. Catra immediately growls. It is an unusual response to the touch – at least now her hair is short – but Adora immediately pulls her hand away. Catra huffs and reaches for it, grabbing Adora's wrist and placing her hand behind her ears, demand clear.

"Don't bother. It's scarf weather if you *have* to cover up the marks," she tells her. Adora can't help but smile as she sets to scratching behind Catra's ears. She already is going to walk into work smelling of Catra – at least to the hybrids – but apparently Catra wants the *humans* to know too.

"Glimmer is going to have a conniption once Bow tells her," Adora points out, because Catra hasn't gotten a threatening text *yet*, but Adora does not doubt it is still coming. Catra actually purrs at that, turning her cheek to mark along Adora's chest *again*, as if she doesn't already have scent marks on her all the way down to her inner thighs.

"Not my fault Bow won't get his act together. Maybe you should teach him that *thing* you do with your fingers. Fucking built-in vibrator. Maybe tell Glimmer, actually. I don't think even that would give him the confidence to go for it," Catra tells her. Adora is blushing *badly* now, but that only makes Catra smirk against her chest.

"I told you, I can't *explain* it, I just do it," Adora tells her, rolling her eyes. She figured that trick out senior year, when she was starting to get outright *desperate* for Catra. It is hard to do, and she is pretty sure it is all muscle control, which is pretty much the hardest thing to teach someone else. Catra just purrs against her chest, seeming content there as her eyes slip closed again.

Adora really should get up for work, but if she *isn't* running down to the pharmacy, that does give her a bit of extra time. She can't think of a better way to spend it than cradling Catra against her chest as she purrs softly.

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While Catra is making breakfast, she gets a text from Glimmer asking to meet up. Apparently her lecture is to take place in person. Catra feels a small grin spreading across her face as she texts back that she still isn't comfortable in public without Adora, and can they meet at the recreation center? She cackles to herself when Glimmer texts back an affirmative. Adora peeks over her shoulder at her phone screen and rolls her eyes at the chat. Catra *really* can't wait to see Glimmer and Bow's faces when they walk in together.

"They have been trying to get me to tell you how I feel for a while, you know. Bow berating me about it is what finally convinced me to make a move," Adora tells her, pressing a kiss to the edge of her jaw, just beneath her ear. That is a *new* spot, and it makes Catra melt a little bit back against her girlfriend.

"Oh, he *deserves* to know about that finger thing, then," Catra tells her. Adora snorts, wrapping her arms around her waist as she nuzzles a trail of kisses down the line of her throat. Adora is all about kisses, it turns out – it *also* turns out, so is Catra, when she is sharing them with someone she is in love with.

"That's just for you," she promises her as she reaches the hollow of her throat. Catra can work with that *happily*. She almost burns their food, distracted by Adora crowding her against the counter, but she manages to salvage it just in time to be edible, and then they rush out the door to take the exchanging bus lines to the recreation center.

Catra is wearing her own clothes, except for the addition of Adora's college varsity jacket. It is partially because she likes it and has always reveled in the times Adora gave it to her because she was cold, but it is *by* because she wants Glimmer to have an aneurysm upon spotting them.

"I always loved seeing you in this," Adora murmurs to her, reaching out to thumb the lapel as they wait for their second bus at the crowded stop. Adora is practically pressed against her front, but the wind is far too harsh and biting to leave the crowded bus shelter. She doesn't want the strangers waiting for the same bus this close, but Adora pressed against her makes it better. Catra purrs softly, leaning forward into the touch.

"I used to roll on it when you were in the shower so it would smell like me," Catra admits. Adora wore the damn thing nearly every day of college, and she still sports it frequently. Adora has apparently been *chasing* to be single for a while, but Catra was also doing everything she could to discourage others from approaching. Adora's eyes instantly glaze over at that information, her gaze distant as she processes.

Catra snickers to herself and presses a kiss against Adora's cheek as the bus finally pulls up. There aren't enough seats, but she happily drapes against Adora as she grips a pole, bracing them both as the bus rumbles into the rocky parking lot of the rec center. They are at least one of the first people to get off the bus. Glimmer and Bow aren't waiting for them – here, at least. Catra texted with Glimmer over breakfast to meet by the picnic tables next to the soccer field. The fact that Adora's first match of the day is in that field is *coincidental* – at least that is what she told Glimmer when she got a judging emoji back in response.

They go to Adora's office first, so she can time-in and pull her referee shirt on over her usual uniform. Catra fixes Adora's scarf afterwards to cover the bruises on her neck, but not without pressing a kiss to each one before they leave. Catra has been in Adora's office a number of times in the last five years Adora has worked here, but

she tries not to bother Adora at work. For a long time, this was their only paycheck after Catra quit her part-time job junior year. She doubled-down on her degree and paralegal diploma after that, wanting to support Adora through her program like she had supported Catra through hers.

Adora has about a year in the PT program left, and then she can finally move onto the job she actually wants. Not that Adora doesn't love the rec center – that much is obvious by how many people she waves to as they make their way out to the field – but it certainly doesn't pay like being a physical therapist will, and *helping* has always been Adora's passion. Things will be easier then, but for now Catra is happy to support Adora.

Glimmer and Bow are waiting for them when they reach the soccer field, despite Bow definitely having classes to teach today. Adora waves to them as they walk up, her arm around Catra's shoulders, and Bow waves back as he and Glimmer both eye them up. Catra grins, easy and satisfied as they draw to a halt beside the table.

"Alright, I've got to get going. Are you sticking around, or will I see you again at home?" Adora asks her, dropping her arm to turn to face her. Catra pauses, considering it.

"Probably won't want to be in public for that long. I'll meet up with you back at home," Catra tells her. Adora nods, and then hesitates a half second, sending a glance aside to where Glimmer and Bow are watching them *avidly*. Catra rolls her eyes, stepping forward to close the scant inches between them and stretching up on her toes, raising one hand to Adora's cheek to guide her down.

Adora breaks into an easy grin a moment before they meet. Catra keeps the kiss chaste, if only to keep Glimmer off her back, but Adora *doesn't*, nipping at her lip as she pulls away. Glimmer makes a squawking sound in the background as Catra lowers back down to stand flat on her feet, staring up at her smirking girlfriend with flushed cheeks. Alright, *two* can play at this game.

"Have a good day , *babe*," Catra tells Adora, mostly just to hear Glimmer choke on her own spit, but also so she can see Adora beam as she nods and finally turns away towards the soccer fields. Catra watches her go, feeling the tip of her tail sway behind her as she watches Adora's retreating back. When Adora is finally far away enough Catra cannot see the flex of her muscles as she moves, Catra turns back to the other half of their college study group.

"Bow , Adora has a *thing* she can do with her fingers I think you should learn," she tells them. She is pretty sure she watches a small part of Glimmer's brain die as Bow flushes a deep shade. Serves them right for meddling in her love life.

She is *grateful* for it in the end, but she is never giving them the satisfaction of that.

Chapter End Notes

There will be more of them now they're together in a later fic in the series. The next fic is a prequel fic and then the fic after that will be once they are together, with their friends reactions. The fourth fic will be Adora's backstory with her father, which will finally explain her emotional repression. The fifth is just smut lol. Subscribe to the series if you want to make sure not to miss them!Ill be posting the first chapter of bylm in the next few days.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!